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BRUCE HENDERSON

MIDNIGHT FLYBOYS

THE AMERICAN BOMBER CREWS AND ALLIED SECRET AGENTS
WHO AIDED THE FRENCH RESISTANCE IN WORLD WAR II



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*For the uncle I never knew, 1st Lt. Robert G. Silva, and all the other
flyboys who did not come back*

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INTRODUCTION

I grew up believing in heroes. For me, they were always pilots.

It began with U.S. Army Air Forces 1st Lt. Robert G. Silva, my maternal grandmother's youngest offspring. Bob went missing on March 4, 1944, when his P-51 Mustang named "Hi-Yo Silva"—imitating the Lone Ranger's command to his steed, Silver, on the popular radio show—dropped out of formation in a heavy overcast above the North Sea. His squadron—353rd Fighter Squadron of the 354th Fighter Group, which finished the war as the top-scoring fighter squadron in Europe—was returning from escorting bombers on the first daylight raid to Berlin.

Born after the war, I spent the fondest days of my youth at my grandmother Daisy's always-welcoming Victorian home in tree-lined Alameda, California, a small island community in the San Francisco Bay next to Oakland. I was eight or nine years old when I first opened a brown-striped suitcase kept in a closet in the middle bedroom, formerly my grandfather's room, but after his death a place to store trunks, boxes and the treadle sewing machine at which my grandmother mended, shortened and cuffed. I learned the suitcase was Uncle Bob's, used in his travels from home while he attended college before joining the Army Air Corps as an aviation cadet in 1942.

Inside the suitcase was a boy's treasure trove of pilot paraphernalia: leather-rimmed goggles; a soft leather helmet lined with chamois; leather gloves; a silk scarf; silver aviator wings; and two padded boxes, each containing a tiny folded U.S. flag atop a gleaming decoration. One was the Purple Heart, given to a member of the military wounded or killed in action, and the other was an Air Medal, for "heroic or meritorious achievement while participating in aerial flight." I was particularly taken with the design of the latter. The bronze medallion had a swooping eagle clutching a lightning bolt in each talon.

Through the years I slipped into the middle bedroom and opened the suitcase. In time, I read and reread all the letters my grandmother kept inside—more than a hundred of Bob's letters home from his earliest days in flight training until his last

one, in which he signed off saying he had to get some sleep because he was “expecting another date in the clouds with Jerry tomorrow.” A few days after receiving Bob’s last letter, my grandmother opened the dreaded Western Union wire expressing the secretary of war’s “deep regret your son has been reported missing in action.” That wrinkled and yellowed telegram was also in the suitcase. So was a neatly typed note from Bob’s commanding officer, Col. Jack T. Bradley, dated April 12, 1944. He wrote in response to a letter my grandmother had written to him. “I must apologize for not having written sooner, but under present circumstances time is at a premium. Bob went missing after a Berlin raid and was last seen as the squadron was climbing through the clouds near the French coast,” wrote Bradley, who finished the war as one of the top P-51 aces. “We ran into some terrible weather that day and feel sure that Bob lost control of his ship in the clouds, as did several others. We broke into the clear over the North Sea to find that he was no longer with us. We were at a high altitude and Bob had a good chance of getting out safely. We are hoping to hear he is a prisoner of war. Several men who did not seem to have as good a chance of surviving have been reported captured by the enemy.... If we receive any information at all of Bob, we will forward it to you without delay. However, you may possibly hear before we do. In either case we feel sure that the news will be good news.” The family held on to that hope for fourteen long months, until July 1945—eight weeks after the war in Europe ended—when the War Department officially changed Bob’s status from missing to killed in action, although neither his body nor the wreckage of his plane was ever found.



Uncle Bob: My first hero pilot.

COURTESY OF THE AUTHOR

My grandmother had four children—including my mother—but it was no secret that Bob, to whom she gave birth in the front bedroom twenty-four years before his

death, was special. Relatives and friends shared similar feelings about Bob, who in a short span went from winning swimming and boxing medals in school to flying combat missions over Europe. His was a shining generation, many of whom died before their time in faraway places defending freedom in a global war. But for my family, whose other vets returned from war unscathed, it began and ended with Bob. By all accounts he was our best, most likable and most promising. Everyone could only speculate: What would Bob have done with his life? He was irreplaceable, and his loss unfathomable.

One day when I was in the fifth grade, I created a fantasy about the uncle I never knew. It was one that I would secretly hold for years. The teacher, introducing the topic of world geography, handed out books containing colorful maps. When one reached me, I found the page that I was looking for. I finger-traced a line from Germany to England and saw where the North Sea narrowed between landmasses. It looked to me as if Bob could not have gone down far from a coastline. If he had parachuted from his plane, could he have made it ashore? I figured if he had floated or swam to England he would have been found, but what if he had washed up on the coast of France? I gazed out the bank of windows lining one side of the classroom and daydreamed. What if Uncle Bob had parachuted and made it safely ashore but had lost his memory or been unable to speak? Had he been picked up by friendly locals? Unable to remember his past, had he settled in a small French village after the war? I looked again at the map, studying the possibilities. It became clear what I must do. When I grew up, I would search for my lost uncle. Somewhere, somehow, I'd find him and bring him home to my grandmother, who I never saw speak about her lost son without her eyes brimming with tears. I wanted to find him for myself, too, so I could have the uncle I had never known. That boyhood dream of mine never came true.

Other pilots entered my life. Our next-door neighbor—a naval air reserve pilot—took me up for my first airplane ride at age twelve. Not long after, a Blue Angels pilot at an air show let me sit in his blue-and-gold #3 jet (my lucky number ever since) for a newspaper photo. I was saddened to read years later that the pilot, Cmd. Herb Hunter, was killed landing his crippled plane on an aircraft carrier during the Vietnam War. Then I joined the Navy after a year of college and found another hero pilot on my own carrier, USS *Ranger*—I was an aerographer in the weather office—who was shot down over Laos in 1965 and held in a jungle POW camp until he

escaped six months later. The emaciated but grinning warrior, Ltjg. Dieter Dengler, was flown back to our ship, still operating in the Gulf of Tonkin, and stepped onto the hangar deck surrounded by hundreds of cheering shipmates for a *Top Gun*-like hero's welcome.

All of this is by way of explaining that when I first heard about a band of World War II airmen who flew secret missions at perilously low altitudes on moonlit nights over Nazi-occupied France to parachute munitions and spies to the resistance forces in the lead-up to D-Day, it stirred strong emotions in me. At the same time that Allied planes were swarming the skies of Europe to bomb targets in Germany and elsewhere, these flyboys had a much different task. The underground resistance groups needed the tools and expertise to effectively sabotage and ambush German reinforcements that would be expected to rush toward the coast of France to repel the planned Allied landings. The only practical way of getting it to them over closed borders was by air.

To that end, a new U.S. Army Air Forces operation was activated in late 1943, code-named CARPETBAGGER, a novel and top secret partnership between airpower and military intelligence. The Office of Strategic Services (OSS)—precursor to the CIA—and the British Special Operations Executive (SOE) recruited and trained the agents to organize and fight alongside the partisans, and the flyers delivered hundreds of them and thousands of tons of munitions and supplies. Flying their covert missions late at night in specially modified B-24s, painted a dull matte black to blend into the dark sky, the American flyers took off on solo missions across the English Channel to hidden locations in France where partisans awaited, ready to light their drop zones with lanterns and bonfires. Danger was never far away. On the ground, enemy patrols relentlessly hunted the partisans and antiaircraft artillery units aimed their guns skyward while German Luftwaffe radar-equipped night fighters owned the skies. The odds of a plane going down were increased by bad weather and the necessity of flying low and slow to make the parachute drops. When they did crash, surviving airmen suddenly went from aiding the partisans to needing their help to stay alive. Some of them—unable to find a way out of Nazi-occupied France—joined the resistance forces to fight on the ground in a very different kind of warfare.

The more I learned about these clandestine missions, the more I wanted to know about the men who flew them. And what of the agents—men and women—who

leapt from the black bombers into the dark void behind enemy lines? What were their missions? Their fates?

For a half century, these operations remained secret. The American airmen were ordered to “forget everything you saw and did” in the war. Not until the 1990s was the veil of secrecy lifted as the wartime records of the Carpetbaggers were declassified. At that time, a British reporter opined: “Only fiction in its wildest flight of fancy vies with the dramatic role played by those flyboys.”

Bruce Henderson
Menlo Park, California

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ONE

"WHERE THE HELL ARE WE?"

Eugene "Gene" Polinsky, born to Russian Jewish immigrants in Manhattan in 1920 and raised in New Jersey, grew up wanting to be a stage actor. After his June 1941 graduation from Rutgers University, where he majored in drama and music, he joined a touring stock company. The handsome six-footer with matinee-idol looks sang and danced in the chorus, played drums, and had a few lines in stage productions.

Then came December 7, 1941.

With the nation suddenly at war after the Japanese attack on Pearl Harbor, Gene's road show folded overnight. He hopped on a bus to New York and volunteered for the Army Air Corps in February 1942 but wasn't called up until September due to the crush of enlistments. Waves of young Americans saw themselves soaring in the wild blue yonder, as the number of personnel in the air forces expanded in the first year of war from 354,000 to 1,597,000.

That fall, Gene took a train with other New York-area recruits to a classification center in Nashville, Tennessee, where their transformation from civilians to aviation cadets began within thirty minutes of their arrival. First they stripped off their civvies and placed them in canvas bags, then they entered a bank of showers, where signs implored them to "Wash Thoroughly with Soap and Use Foot Baths." The line of naked men followed footsteps painted on the floor to stations for examinations. At one station, two strings were placed along each man's backbone to see if it was straight. Records were to be kept on every cadet throughout his training with a view to correcting minor ailments by specialized exercises. They then came to stations at which their measurements were taken and they were issued clothing including khaki uniforms, two pairs of oxfords, a winter coat and a cap with a blue band around it that would be replaced with an

Air Corps insignia when the cadet became a commissioned officer, which would not be for nearly a year. For several days they were tested physically and mentally. If a cadet did not pass the minimum physical requirements for aircrew training, they were classified “GDO” (ground duty only). Aptitude tests determined which aircrew assignment best suited a cadet. Some would leave for pilot training, others to specialized schools to become navigators or bombardiers.¹

Gene got what he hoped for and was soon on his way to Eagle Field in Dos Palos, California, for nine weeks of preflight training—the first step to becoming a pilot. To his disappointment, however, it involved no flying. They had an hour a day of athletics and another hour for close order drill, which meant formation marching “to improve military carriage and teach discipline.” The rest of the day was devoted to classroom studies, such as mathematics, physics, military law, equipment, armament, command, administration and defense against chemical attack. Upon completion of the course, cadets went thirty miles up the road to Merced Army Flying School for primary flight training.

Somewhat seasoned and well-drilled, and now with a fair idea of what military life was about, Gene was eager to fly. But before flight instruction began, there was more classroom work. Ground school covered aerodynamics, flight systems, engine and propeller operation, radio communications, and procedures for takeoff and landing. The courses at Merced were more advanced than at Eagle Field, especially the mathematics. The textbook, *Practical Mathematics of Aviation*, covered algebra and geometry and had practical problems to solve. Example: “Finding Wind Corrections to Course and Ground Speed—In order to make graphs useful for planes of all cruising speeds, it is necessary to compute them for wind velocities and ground speeds based on percent of air speed. To adapt them for use with your plane...”

Gene and his cadet class were briefed as to what was in store for them as “dodos,” a flightless extinct bird and a moniker they were stuck with until they made their first solo flight. Before any of them would be sent on to advanced flight training, where they would fly different types of military aircraft, they had to prove to their instructors here that they had the “inherent ability to fly a plane.” That included soloing after going aloft with an instructor for eight or ten hours of “dual instruction.” After that: “You’ll take your ship up alone and bring

it down countless times,” they were told. “You’ll have gone up alone and fought back your uneasiness and done slow rolls, loops, chandelles, lazy eights, and snap rolls. You’ll put your ship into spins and stalls and bring it out. Here is where you prove you have what it takes to become a pilot. Some won’t reach that goal because you’ll wash out due to a lack of inherent flying abilities.”

One morning, as a hot wind blew off the ruler-flat San Joaquin Valley, Gene and several other cadets who formed his group marched down to the flight line to meet their flight instructors. They passed rows of Stearman biplanes, their brilliant yellow fuselages glistening in the sunlight. Designated as PT-17s, they looked like throwbacks to the days of the Red Baron, but they were newer than that and were among the 8,000 Stearmans produced by Boeing since 1935 as primary trainers for the Army and Navy. With an air-cooled, radial piston engine that generated 220 hp, cruising speed was about 100 mph. The Stearman could reach an altitude of 10,000 feet, but it took forever—more than seventeen minutes—to do so. The slow biplanes weren’t idiotproof and did have their quirks, yet they were easy enough for beginners to fly. With fabric-covered wooden wings, sturdy landing gear and a welded steel fuselage, they were well suited to the stresses trainee pilots put on an airplane.

Gene and his instructor—an experienced civilian pilot—conducted a walk-around inspection of their plane. Then Gene climbed into the open cockpit and sat in the rear tandem seat. The instructor stood on the lower wing and pointed out the main controls and instruments: “the stick” that the pilot straddled, which controlled climbs and descents; the throttle, controlling the power output of the engine; the altimeter, showing the altitude of the plane; the tachometer, registering the rpm of the engine; and a rudder bar for the foot operation of the central cables leading to the plane’s tail rudder, which controlled the yaw, or the side-to-side motion of an aircraft’s nose. Rubber tubes fit into the earholes of Gene’s soft helmet. To the consternation of every “dodo” who heard this for the first time, his instructor said matter-of-factly: “You can hear me talk, but you can’t talk back.”

The instructor settled into the front seat. After a few spins of the propeller, the engine caught with a backfire and plume of smoke. When the motor was running smoothly, the instructor had Gene inch the throttle forward and start

taxiing in S-turns, which were done to give them better visibility ahead, since they were seated lower than the nose of the plane. They practiced up and down the taxiway before coming to a stop at the end of an active runway. The instructor said he'd handle the throttle for the first takeoff, while Gene was to put forward pressure on the stick as they gathered speed, then ease it back when told to do so. Down the runway they rattled, gathering speed, the stiff wind blowing hard in their faces, which were only partially protected by goggles. When he hauled back on the stick, Gene felt a slight sinking sensation as they were lifted airborne as if by an invisible force from underneath. He concentrated on keeping back pressure on the stick.

"Not so steep," the instructor barked. "Take it easy."

The ground dropped farther away as they climbed. When they reached their planned altitude, back pressure on the stick was released. Now it was time to focus on the myriad things for straight-and-level flight.

Left wing too low.

Pull 'er nose up.

Watch that tachometer. She's revving too high.

Ease back on the throttle.

Hold a little right rudder.

Correction after correction came through the earholes of Gene's helmet until the instructor's monologue became a steady drumming. But when they landed an hour later, Gene couldn't wait to go up again. And they soon did. Over the next two weeks, he was getting the feel of the plane for simple maneuvers and maintaining a desired course while improving his takeoffs and landings. But a student's progress was subjective and at the discretion of his instructor. While other cadets were soloing in eight to ten hours, Gene's instructor held him back, assuring him that no two students learned at the same rate.

Then they started having winter weather to contend with, and his flights started being scrubbed due to heavy overcast and ground fog. Once, when they did get up, his instructor took over the controls and performed a series of advanced aerobatics, including Immelmann turns comprising an ascending half-loop followed swiftly by a half-roll, resulting in level flight in the opposite direction at a higher altitude. It was a complex maneuver used in combat after

making an attack on an enemy aircraft to quickly get in position to make a second attack. They hadn't done anything like that before, and the gravity-defying maneuvers were disorienting. But Gene, loving the thrill of it, grinned widely through all the stomach-churning and head-spinning. It occurred to him only later that his instructor may have been trying to scare him into dropping out of flight school, for in a few days he was informed that since he had accumulated more than twelve hours of dual time without soloing, it had been decided he "lacked inherent flying abilities." It was a bitter disappointment for Gene. The reason he had not soloed, he believed, had to do with the bad weather more than anything he had done or not done. He loved flying and hadn't been the least timid about practicing stalls and spins, as had some cadets who washed out.

There was no appealing the decision. However, Gene's high test scores qualified him for navigation school, and upon successful completion of that training he'd be assigned to a bomber crew. He wouldn't be the pilot, but... *he could still fly.*

Off he went to the Army's largest air navigation school, in Hondo, Texas, where some 14,000 navigators learned their craft during the war. Though Gene's math abilities were strong, he found the fifteen-week school challenging. He soon understood why navigation school had earned a reputation for being more difficult than pilot training: it involved a great deal more studying to become proficient. By nature he was not detail-oriented, yet details were critical to plotting an accurate course, keeping track of his plane's position, ensuring that they were headed in the right direction, and doing so in all weather conditions. The pilots and other crewmen could be great at their jobs, but with a careless slip of a coordinate or wind velocity or countless other computations, the navigator could lose them all. Imbued with the responsibility they had to an entire crew, the cadets worked hard at learning and practicing the four basic methods of navigation.

Pilotage: Consulting maps and charts that showed geographic references such as rivers, mountains, and cities that they should pass over when flying from one point to another.

Dead reckoning: Determining position by the direction of travel and speed using a compass, airspeed indicator and drift meter to determine whether the

winds aloft are slowing the plane or increasing its ground speed or pushing it to one side or the other of its intended course.

Celestial navigation: Fixing a position by use of a sextant to measure the angle between the celestial bodies and the ground.

Radio navigation: Using radio frequencies to determine a position relative to the known position of a transmitter.

One method was rarely used to the complete exclusion of the others, Gene learned. Weather could make it impossible to see the ground, or the radio might not be working, or an overcast precluded a celestial fix. When one way didn't work, the navigator had to use all his skills and ingenuity to bring the plane safely to its destination by any combination of navigational methods.

For every five hours in the classroom, students spent one hour in the air. These flights themselves were an education. The training planes—twin-engine Beechcraft AT-7 Navigators—flew as far as a thousand miles away. There was a pilot in the cockpit, and a navigational instructor and three cadets in the cabin. Each student had a small desk—similar to the one he would work from in a bomber—with a flexible light, and his own compass, drift meter and circular slide rule. An interphone communication system connected each of them with the cockpit so they could give the pilot a course to follow. Shared cabin equipment included an aerial sextant, wind calculator, maps, charts, altimeter, airspeed indicator and radio direction-finding equipment. An astrodome—a hemispherical transparent dome—was installed in the cabin roof to see the stars so as to guide the plane at night by celestial navigation.



Navigator Eugene “Gene” Polinsky.
U.S. ARMY SIGNAL CORPS

When Gene graduated from navigation school in September 1943, he was commissioned a second lieutenant in the Army Air Forces. His flight log showed he had flown 111 hours as a navigator, including 32 hours at night. Entitled to a leave, he took the train to New York to visit family and friends. The day before he was to return to duty, he wandered into Sardi’s in the heart of New York’s Theater District for a drink. Dressed in his new officer’s uniform on which was pinned a shiny Navigator’s Badge—a celestial sphere centered between two wings—Gene was enjoying the caricatures of stage and screen stars lining the Italian restaurant’s walls when he recognized some real-life Broadway luminaries sitting at a nearby table: leading lady Kitty Carlisle, playwright Moss Hart and director Garson Kanin. They smiled at the young officer and a friendly conversation ensued. Stagestruck Gene told of his love of performing and his short gig in the road show that was interrupted by the war.

Hart, whose last hit play, *The Man Who Came to Dinner*, ran at New York’s Music Box Theatre for more than seven hundred performances, told Gene he had written a new musical called *Winged Victory*, about Army Air Forces recruits struggling to make it through pilot training.

Gene had to laugh. *Boy, could I tell ’em a thing or two!*

“How’d you like to be in my show?” asked Hart. Everyone in the cast was in the service, he added, and the Army Air Forces were fully cooperating.

Gene was speechless. A Moss Hart play! He’d once have scaled Mount Everest barefoot to get into such a show! It could have been a big break and a sure pathway to a theatrical career. *Now of all times*, he mused. *How damn ironic*. In his heart, he knew the right thing to do.

“Mr. Hart, Uncle Sam has spent a fortune making me a navigator on a bomber. Can you please give me a rain check until after the war?”

Hart smiled and said they had a deal.^{[II](#)}

Two weeks later, Gene met his crew at Lincoln Army Air Field in Nebraska. The pilot was Neil Ellis, twenty-four, from Fayetteville, North Carolina. He had been a grocer before the war, and looked to Gene to be a good man with steady

nerves. Everyone on the crew hailed from a different state. West Virginia. Texas. Florida. Utah. Illinois. Oklahoma. North Carolina. New Jersey. The youngest was their teenage radio operator, Ray Orwasky. At twenty-three, Gene was one of the oldest. They were assigned a new B-24 Liberator right off Consolidated Aircraft's assembly line. Most of the crew—including Gene—had not been inside a B-24. They began daily flights to become familiar with the plane and one another.

Lincoln Field had been a training air base since mid-1942 and was now one of eleven in centrally located Nebraska. Here, the flyers of bombardment squadrons melded as functioning crews before they headed to combat in either the Pacific or European Theater. Also at the sprawling base, some 25,000 aircraft mechanics were trained for war.

After two months, the Ellis crew received new orders, and the wives of two married crewmen came to see their husbands off. To Gene's astonishment, his father, Abraham, who operated a dressmaking factory in New Jersey, and his mother, Ida—neither had ever taken a long train trip—showed up in Nebraska to bid a touching farewell to their only son.

Departing Lincoln, the crew flew nine hundred miles to Alamogordo Air Field in New Mexico for a month of training that had nothing to do with high-altitude bombardment like most B-24 crews were doing in the war. Gene worked on honing his navigation skills, and the pilot and copilot practiced bringing the big bomber through the narrow, pitch-black passes of the rugged mountains east of the airfield. They returned from one flight with shrubs caught in the plane's undercarriage. It was a strange way to prepare for high-altitude bombing, they agreed. Or did the Army have something else in mind for them?

In early December, they were ordered to Morrison Army Airfield in Florida. Only then did the crew know to which warfront they were being sent. Not the Pacific, as some had bet, but Europe. They would be flying across the ocean via the "Southern Route" to avoid the stormy North Atlantic in wintertime. A few days later, they flew to Belém on the Brazilian coast, landing at one of the largest and best-equipped U.S. military airfields in the world, which had become an important refueling and servicing stop for planes prior to crossing the ocean. They laid over at the port city and gateway to the lower Amazon for a couple of

days. Gene saw his first jungle and observed how bananas were grown. In a letter home to his folks, Gene tried to let them know where he was in a way that could get past the military censor. Hoping they would decipher his code of capitalizing the first letters of relevant words, he wrote: “Being Really Astute Zealous Intelligent Learned, you might know where I am right now.”

To cut five hundred miles off the ocean crossing, they flew a thousand miles farther down the coast of Brazil to an airfield at Fortaleza. Working with his charts, Gene plotted the course and map coordinates to their next destination: Dakar, Senegal, on the coast of West Africa. Such a long journey over water gave Gene a queasy feeling that aerobatic spins and dives at flight school had not. There were often geographical references over land, but navigating across a very large ocean was another matter.

Assuming no in-flight mechanical problems, a B-24 was more than capable of the 2,000-mile flight. Sans bombs and cargo, its “ferry range” was more than 3,000 miles with a full load of fuel (2,300 gallons) and maintaining a cruise speed of 215 mph. But those numbers came from the manufacturer’s manual, and they varied with flight conditions. For example, a stiff headwind would slow them down, causing the plane to use more fuel.

On their departure day they waited until darkness to take off in order to time their arrival off the coast of Africa after sunrise the next morning. During a light meal, everyone tried to appear relaxed, when in fact the entire crew was anxious to get in the air.

Taxiing to the end of the runway, the pilots finished the checklist for takeoff, then revved the engines, held full power and released the brakes. The big bomber lumbered at first but soon was shaking and rattling down the runway. As they lifted off, Gene logged the time.

After the sun went down, darkness came fast because the earth was facing the new moon’s dark side. From his station at the nose of the plane, Gene was surprised to see that the ocean was darker than the sky. If he stared long enough, he could make out the difference between the two, but it was nearly imperceptible. The blackness was not a hinderance to navigation, as there was nothing to see on the ocean anyway but plenty of stars for celestial navigation, which was the best way to cross the ocean given there were no checkpoints.

Gene had worked hard over his charts before takeoff, and once airborne he kept them on a small table in front of him so he could check them periodically under a dim light. He had given the pilot an initial course of 81 degrees, which would change during the flight based on drift and prevailing winds. At 10,000 feet altitude they were above the clouds, and he was able to shoot Sirius and Procyon with his sextant. He recorded the precise time for each shot and compared that with the next shot he took in order to compute their distance traveled and exact spot on the sea.

Some hours into the flight, they passed the “Point of No Return.” From then on, it was farther back to South America than on to Africa.

Gene realized he was the only crewman not sleeping. The plane was on autopilot, so even the pilots were snoozing in their seats as the four engines droned along. He knew the pilots would spring awake at the first sound of anything amiss, but still, it was a bit unsettling. Gene became more tightly wound by the hour and chewed packs of gum until his jaws ached. He checked and rechecked his calculations—airspeed, compass, winds aloft—all night. On him alone rested the responsibility to take them to the west coast of Africa.

It was a short night traveling east toward the sun at more than 200 mph. As the dawn came, the drowsy crew stirred as streaks of sunlight shone into the cabin. The pilot called Gene on the interphone asking for an update on their position.

“Working on it, Neil,” Gene replied.

Gene peered out the bubble canopy and saw only ocean in front of them. For the hundredth or thousandth time, he rechecked his numbers.

Sounding calmer than he was, he called back, “My ETA is up.”

In other words, *We should be seeing land anytime.*

They had been cautioned to let down early in their approach to the coast of Africa in order to be below any dense haze. To continue on top of the overcast could mean they might not see land beneath them. Everyone on board felt the ship start its downhill run as the pilot reduced power and brought them down to 1,000 feet.

Gene knew from his charts and maps where they were *supposed* to be, but what if he had miscalculated? He couldn’t shoot any stars because dawn had

blotted them out. He had done his dead reckoning from the coast of Brazil, heading for the big bulge of the African continent north of the equator. They were following that same course with only minor corrections as they skated low through a rain shower over the calm sea.

Gene wouldn't put into words the dreadful question he was now asking himself: *Where the hell are we?* Had they veered off course at some point? Were his wind calculations and midcourse corrections wrong? If so, they could fly around over the ocean until they ran out of fuel.

Then what? Very few land-based bombers had ditched at sea without injuries to the crew. Gene had an idea Neil Ellis would take her down while the last of the fuel was feeding the engines and he still had control. He'd glide onto the water with the landing gear retracted, trying for a clean belly flop at a slow-enough speed to keep the airframe intact so it would stay afloat longer. And if they survived that, they'd be ten men floating around in two rubber boats off the coast of Africa. Still lost at sea.

Everyone near a windshield was looking ahead for land.

The interphone was strangely quiet, absent any bantering.

Likely no more than a half hour lapsed, but those were the longest minutes of Gene's life. He had left his navigator position and was now standing directly behind the pilots, studying the horizon through the windshield. The pilots were discussing their fuel level with the engineer and had throttled back on the engines to conserve.

Gene was the first to see what first looked like a black funnel in front of them. Perhaps a waterspout, which were common at this latitude. It grew larger as they drew closer, and then he saw trees on the object. Trees did not grow on water!

"Land ho!" he hollered. Other shout-outs and cheers quickly followed.

The coast of Africa.

Right where it's supposed to be.

Gene could breathe again. He hadn't killed them after all. They'd be okay now. He had done what he'd been trained to do, and it felt good.

Circling the port of Dakar on the Cap-Vert peninsula a short time later, they received clearance to land at Mallard Field, built by the Army six months earlier as the primary landing field for four-engine aircraft arriving from Brazil. Two days

later they took off for Tindouf, Algeria, landing at a desert airfield used as a refueling stop. Security was so tight that they had to spend a cold night sleeping on the plane. Refueled if not rested, they took off the next morning for Marrakech in French Morocco. The good news they received upon landing was that they could fly from there directly to England. That last leg took them over neutral Spain and the Bay of Biscay. They arrived over England in a fog that obscured the ground but were guided in by a radar control station.

One by one the crewmen deplaned from the aircraft that had brought them on a journey of more than 10,000 miles, all the way from Nebraska, but was destined to be flown into combat by others. Bound for a replacement depot, they would soon get orders to join a B-24 squadron already in England.

“Welcome to the war!” someone on the tarmac shouted.

Two bottles of Kentucky whiskey appeared out of thin air.

The exhausted Ellis crew agreed the war could wait a while longer.

I. To recruit ample flyers to meet the huge increases in U.S. aircraft inventory required for the two-front war in Europe and the Pacific, pilot standards were soon changed, reducing the minimum age from twenty to eighteen and eliminating the requirement of at least two years of college. Some 193,000 new Army pilots were successfully trained during the war. Some 124,000 trainees washed out of flight school—about a 40 percent failure rate—although many of those ended up being sent to other schools to become navigators (49,000) and bombardiers (43,000) to meet bomber aircrew needs.

II. Moss Hart’s *Winged Victory* opened at the 44th Street Theatre in New York City on November 20, 1943. It was a huge hit, playing to over 350,000 people in 226 performances. The Broadway run ended only so the entire cast could travel to Hollywood to appear in the film version released in 1944. Among the soon-to-be notables in the cast: Lee J. Cobb, Mario Lanza, Red Buttons, Karl Malden, Barry Nelson, Edmond O’Brien and John Forsythe.

TWO

SWORN TO SECRECY

In September 1943, two squadrons of B-24 Liberators based in England were suddenly relieved of their duties patrolling the Bay of Biscay hunting for German U-boats approaching or departing their fortified submarine pens along the coast of France.

In limbo for weeks awaiting new orders, the grounded Army flyers assumed they would soon join the strategic bombing campaign that was bringing the war to Hitler's doorstep. But something else was in the works for them, and the first to find out were the two seniormost officers in the 22nd Antisubmarine Squadron: commanding officer Lt. Col. Clifford J. Heflin and operations officer Maj. Robert W. Fish.

Physically and temperamentally, "Cliff" and "Bob," as they called one another, couldn't have been more dissimilar. Heflin, twenty-eight, a big-boned, six-foot-one Californian who had played college football, was a head taller than Fish, twenty-six, a compact Midwesterner. Whereas the affable Fish was easy to converse with, Heflin could "go days without really talking," one of his daughters said years later.

One squadron pilot, Robert L. Boone, described Heflin as a "big, robust, quiet officer—unless provoked," and a "tough, duck-huntin', deer-shootin', poker-playin', cigar-smokin', two-fisted man's man." Heflin was "truly in command" and expected his men to "achieve superiority," said Boone. "He told us he was going to make us the best damn flying squadron in the Army: 'You guys are really going to be pilots when I'm done with you.' He just flew our tails off day and night in all weather."



Carpetbaggers commanding officer Cliff Heflin.

U.S. ARMY SIGNAL CORPS

There were stories aplenty attesting to Heflin's determination and grit. He was once fishing in Alaska when a grizzly bear appeared on the riverbank behind him. Refusing to move from his spot in the river, Heflin kept casting his fly line. Then there was his hotel bachelor party, after which Heflin entered the hallway and summoned the elevator. When the door opened, he stepped inside. But the elevator car was stuck on a higher floor, and he fell fifty feet down the empty shaft, grasping at the cables to slow his descent. When the door opened on the ground level, he picked himself up and strode through the lobby and across the street to the hospital with a broken pelvis. The wedding ceremony went ahead the next morning, but with a venue change to his hospital room.

Bob Fish, seeking adventure after graduating from high school in Ohio, joined the Civilian Conservation Corps and was sent to Oregon to work on rural construction projects. Two years later, he enrolled at Ohio State University, where he studied electrical engineering before joining the Army Air Corps in 1939. He graduated from flight training and received his sterling silver pilot wings in June 1940.

Eighteen months later, he had his baptism of wartime command when he was the O.D. (officer of the day) one quiet Sunday morning at Davis-Monthan Army Airfield in Tucson, Arizona. He was having a late breakfast at the officers' club when a waitress rushed over to tell him the Hawaiian Islands were being bombed by Japanese planes. That was difficult for him to believe, but she brought him to a radio that was broadcasting news of the attack on Pearl Harbor. Fish hurried to the administration building, where he hoped to find his squadron commander, but he was gone for the day. His wing commander

wasn't around either, and his group commander was on leave in Kansas. Fish telephoned the Tucson chief of police and requested that his officers order all military personnel they saw in town to return to the base immediately. He next called the local radio station and asked for a similar on-the-air announcement. Then he went into his group commander's office, sat down, put his feet on the colonel's desk, and waited for a wiser and more experienced officer than he to arrive and take charge. His quick actions turned out to be laudable, because by midnight his squadron was on the move, flying their aircraft to California to help guard the coast against a possible Japanese invasion.

Heflin and Fish, who had worked together for more than a year by the fall of 1943, were alike in some other ways. Both superb pilots, they were respected by their men for their fairness and loyalty. Another leadership trait they shared: they did not believe in assigning missions they wouldn't fly themselves. Their common goal was to have a squadron that worked hard, played hard and did it all together. "The success of our unit," said one pilot, "was because of their personalities and leadership."

Heflin and Fish were summoned to a meeting on October 4, 1943, at the Royal Air Force (RAF) base at Bovingdon, twenty miles west of London. They made the jeep drive together. Neither had any idea what the meeting was about or the nature of their squadron's next assignment. After what seemed like overzealous security checks, they were shown into a room where a number of high-ranking officers were seated. They were introduced to three colonels from U.S. bomber command, an RAF captain, and a Col. Haskell and a Maj. Brooks from the Office of Strategic Services (OSS). Like most Americans, Heflin and Fish had never heard of the OSS, America's first permanent intelligence service, which had been established in June 1942. The clandestine activities of the OSS were among the nation's most closely guarded secrets.

One of the OSS officers noted that anti-submarine squadrons were not experienced in strategic bombing, the primary mission of the Eighth Air Force, which commanded all the bomber squadrons in the European Theater. Strategic bombing involved large formations flying at high altitudes with navigating to the target being the responsibility of the lead plane and everyone else following behind. Hunting enemy subs was the opposite kind of flying: solitary planes on

long patrols with crews that did their own navigation and then dropped to very low altitudes to attack their targets. Their squadron's experience flying those missions, the officer said, qualified them for a different job.

Before describing what that new assignment would be, the OSS colonel swore Heflin and Fish to secrecy. Then he commenced with a short history lesson for their benefit. When France surrendered to the invading Germans in June 1940, there was no organized French resistance movement. The British, through their Special Operations Executive (SOE)—established that same year to coordinate and conduct espionage, sabotage and reconnaissance in Nazi-occupied Europe—went to work creating local resistance circuits. This required identifying, organizing, training and supplying patriotic civilians willing to put their lives on the line to oppose the German occupiers. By 1942, the SOE had established its own air arm to parachute agents, saboteurs, munitions and supplies to the partisans. Now an influx of U.S. aircraft was needed to help mobilize and equip a growing number of French resistance fighters known as the Maquis—estimated at 25,000 to 40,000 members by fall 1943—before the long-anticipated Allied invasion of France. Ahead of what would become known as “D-Day,” the Maquis needed to be well-equipped and strong enough to “harass, disrupt and divert” the German army’s defenses against the Allies as they drove inland.¹

The colonel explained that the OSS—the U.S. equivalent of the SOE—had just received approval from Washington to set up its own air arm. The OSS would designate the targets, package the munitions and supplies into droppable containers, and train agents and saboteurs. He told them their top secret operation, code-named CARPETBAGGER, was to be patterned after what the British had pioneered. The American crews would train with British crews for several weeks, learning how to locate designated drop zones in fields and forests, make contact with the receiving parties on the ground and fly low and slow in the dead of night to safely parachute spies and supplies.

Though neither of them showed it, Heflin and Fish were both taken aback by the unusual assignment. They were also surprised by how quickly it all came together. The anti-submarine squadrons were immediately deactivated and their personnel transferred to two new Carpetbagger squadrons. Heflin and Fish were

each given command of a squadron: Heflin the 406th and Fish the 36th. “Later on if traffic warrants,” the OSS Special Operations Branch in London advised OSS director William J. Donovan in Washington, “two additional squadrons will be put into operation.”^{II}

The two anti-submarine squadrons had arrived overseas months earlier with a minimum of twelve B-24s each and enough aircrews and ground support to keep them operational—a total of about 350 officers and enlisted personnel per squadron—but those numbers had since dwindled. They now had to build up each squadron to at least sixteen planes. The Eighth Air Force was ordered to make available to the OSS additional aircraft and aircrews. New crews soon started arriving from replacement depots in England, along with transfers of crews from other commands.

In early December, a group of the aircrews assembled inside a windowless concrete building at RAF Cheddington, located in Buckinghamshire, in southeast England. They had waited close to a week to find out why they were there, having as yet been told nothing.

That job fell to Bob Fish, who stood before them on a raised platform at the front of the room. “I’m going to give you a few things to think about,” he said. “You’ll be leaving in the dark and returning in the dark. You’ll learn to fly four hundred feet above the ground at ten miles per hour over stalling speed. You’ll do it alone in single-ship missions behind enemy lines with no fighter escorts. Crews will be responsible for their own navigation and their own defense.”

Pilot George Johnson, who had been transferred along with his crew from a daylight bombing group, heard the “intake of breath in the room... we were all dumbfounded.”

“That’s it for now,” Fish said. “You have five minutes to think it over. Any of you who don’t want in on this can walk out now and forget what you’ve heard. It won’t reflect against you. You’ll be assigned as replacement crews to high-altitude bombing groups.”

Checking his wristwatch, Fish took a seat in the front row.

The anti-submarine crews had not been given such a choice, although it was apparent that after two months of long and boring patrols over the Bay of Biscay their pilots and crews were eager for something more exciting, which they were

about to get. But the Army was giving the new crews coming in from the States or transferring from other squadrons in England the opportunity to volunteer—or not—to fly the secret missions for the OSS, itself an all-volunteer intelligence agency. (At its height in 1944, the OSS employed nearly 13,000 men and women in its intelligence-gathering operations, approximately half of them serving overseas and the rest in Washington, D.C.)

The room stayed stony silent. Details had been sparse and there had been no chance to ask questions. These B-24 flyers knew their aircraft inside and out, and what they'd just heard was not what their planes were built for, nor was it the type of mission for which they had trained.

The four-engine B-24 Liberator was a bear to fly under the best conditions, even though its design incorporated aerodynamics and technology that were five years more advanced than the B-17 Flying Fortress. It had four Pratt & Whitney engines rated at 1,200 horsepower apiece, each with a turbo supercharger. The propeller blades were as large as a man. It had two bomb bays, each of which could match the B-17's single bay for capacity, and roll-up bomb bay doors, which eliminated buffeting caused by standard doors that opened below the plane into the airstream. Although the B-24 could carry a payload of 12,500 pounds—two times that of a B-17—it was also the fastest U.S. bomber with the longest range. But it performed poorly at slow speeds, with stiff and heavy controls. Its detractors saw it as a slab-sided monster—bulky and hard to handle. The narrow walkways and cramped spaces made it difficult for a crew to exit during an emergency. On the plus side, a B-24 could roar through angry storms of shrapnel and bullets and emerge pockmarked but still airworthy. It finished the war as the most produced U.S. military aircraft in history—a record it still holds eighty years later—with 18,500 built. With its top speed slightly more than 300 mph, a maximum ceiling of 30,000 feet and an extended range of 2,800 miles carrying a full bomb load, the B-24 became a workhorse of the U.S. bomber fleet. “The B-24 has guts,” said the Army instruction manual for pilots. “It can take it and dish it out. It can carry a bigger bomb load farther and faster, day in and day out, than any airplane that has passed the test of combat.”

Since January 1943, the U.S. had been sending massive formations of B-17s and B-24s on long-range daylight raids into Germany to bomb shipyards,

railroads, bridges, oil refineries and manufacturing plants. Packs of enemy fighters swarmed the formations in waves, and those bombers that made it through were pounded by flak from antiaircraft guns on their runs to the targets. When the bombers finally turned for home, the fighters again pounced. Sending aircrews into such aerial valleys of death was deemed so hazardous that the Army decided completing twenty-five combat missions constituted a “complete tour of duty” due to the “physical and mental strain.” After that number was reached, a flyer would be reassigned to a stateside training command, unless he volunteered for another combat tour. While that number of missions was a tall order when it was set, it gave men a measure of hope for making it out of the war alive.^{III}



Carpetbagger B-24 at Harrington.

U.S. ARMY SIGNAL CORPS

The missions described by the major would come with some of the same risks as high-altitude bombing, as well as new ones. Flying a heavy bomber at slow speeds and low altitudes at night was not for the faint of heart. They would face the perils of weaving through mountain passes and dodging hillsides in the dark. With flaps down to reduce speed, the aircraft would be close to stalling, which happens when there is insufficient airlift on the wings to support the plane’s weight. One mistake, and the aircraft could suddenly dive and the pilot might not be able to regain control before colliding with the ground. Flying low, slow and alone could also make them easy pickings for enemy fighters from above and German radar-controlled antiaircraft guns from below.

Altitude and airspeed are a pilot’s best friends because they can be forgiving. It’s an old aviation axiom: if something needs to be done quickly to stay safe and you’re at low altitude, climb higher first, which is best accomplished when a plane has adequate airspeed. When a plane is low to the ground, the window of

time from everything being okay to not being okay is brief. Even routine maneuvers could be deadly. In a banking turn, for example, a pilot had to be careful not to slip lower and strike the ground with a wingtip. At only a few hundred feet of altitude in the dark, the collision hazards would include hillsides and even tall forests.

In the still hushed room, men looked around to see who was staying or leaving. Crews eyed their pilots for any signs of their intent.

In the front row, Fish didn't dare look back. He knew if a pilot stood up to leave, his entire crew might follow. Bomber crews were that bonded. Would the departure of even one crew trigger an exodus?

Individual crews were seated together on backless benches: pilot, copilot, navigator, bombardier, flight engineer, radio operator and the gunners who manned .50-cal. machine guns at several positions on a B-24. Some crew members weren't yet old enough to vote, and those in their mid-twenties were considered the "old man" of their respective crews. Most of the crews had been together for well over a year. They were no longer casual flying buddies but best friends who lived, worked and risked their lives together. Everyone knew everyone else's story: where they were raised, names of wives and girlfriends, plans and dreams for after the war. Each man, by doing his own job as he'd been trained, bore a heavy responsibility for the lives of the entire crew. Yet, while no one was jockeying to be a dead war hero, they all possessed an eagerness to mix it up in the skies with the foes they called "the Jerries." Sprightly, spirited and fearless, the last thing these flyboys wanted was to miss any action.

No one left the briefing room.

When five minutes were up, Fish stood and returned to the platform. What he said next would long be remembered by those present.

"Gentlemen, you will be taking part in top-secret covert operations. That means you won't be writing home or talking to outsiders at pubs or anywhere else about our missions. Men and women who are risking their lives to rid their country of Nazis will be greatly endangered by careless leaks of vital information. Anyone who jeopardizes this operation will be court martialed and spend the rest of the war in the stockade."

Those airmen not already scared half to death were about to be.

Fish drew open a heavy green curtain to reveal a wall map of France and parts of western Europe filled with red circles, which he explained were the locations of active resistance networks. “These are the brave folks we’ll be working with. Their efforts to sabotage and disrupt the enemy are vital to the success of the Allied landing on the French coast planned for next year. They’re not only fighting the Nazis but also operating escape lines for our downed crews. We’ll be delivering by parachute the weapons, ammunition, explosives, radios and whatever other supplies they need. We’ll also be dropping agents and spies.”



Robert Fish.
U.S. ARMY SIGNAL CORPS

Fish described a typical mission. They would fly during favorable lunar periods when the moon was out so they could better identify the rivers, lakes, towns and railroad tracks from their maps. Takeoff times would be staggered, starting a couple of hours before midnight, with lone planes headed to different drop zones. Finding a field marked by lanterns or small fires placed by the partisans wouldn't be easy. They'd approach the drop zone upwind, with half flaps, and throttle down to slow from about 200 mph to 110 mph, then drop to 600 feet for the agents to jump, and lower—400 feet—to release the supply containers. The reduced speed and altitude were necessary for several reasons. The opening shock on the parachute canopies would be less at a slower speed, and the low-level drops would lessen the chances of the parachutes being spotted by the enemy and help to ensure the agents and the supplies landed on target.

In training, when pilots practiced stalls and stall recoveries, they first raised the nose of the plane to reduce their airspeed enough to stall the plane and cause it to begin to fall earthward. Then they practiced quickly recovering from the stall by pushing the nose down to increase airspeed, leveling the wings and adding power. But a B-24 could lose 1,500 feet recovering from a stall, and everyone in the briefing room knew that at a few hundred feet aboveground there would be insufficient altitude to keep from crashing. If they stalled the big bomber, they'd drop to earth like a twenty-ton boulder.

Fish uncovered another wall map that had the latest-known positions of enemy antiaircraft artillery (AAA) batteries in France. There were too many tiny black circles to count—hundreds at least. Communications with the underground had gotten to the point that if the Germans moved a battery, within twenty-four hours it would be known in London at OSS headquarters, he explained. "That information will be relayed immediately to us so we can plan our flight routes to avoid them."

When the briefing ended, the men filed quietly from the room. Some milled about outside. Matches were passed and smokes lit. It was their first opportunity to speak freely.

George Johnson saw that his own crew, veterans of bombing missions over Germany, were "not fond" of what they had just heard. "They weren't looking for an exotic adventure," he later remarked.

Another pilot asked Johnson why he didn't stand up.

"Why didn't I stand up?" Johnson shot back. "Why didn't you?"

"Didn't want to be the first."

With that, everyone "busted out laughing," realizing they had participated in a game of chicken and had "volunteered by default."

"Fellas, we're all in now," said Johnson.

I. In the beginning, the rural guerrilla bands were composed of young, mostly working-class men who had escaped into the mountains and woods after the fall of France to avoid capture and deportation to Germany as forced labor. Their name came from the kind of terrain in which they initially hid in southeastern France that was covered with a scrub growth called *maquis* (scrubland).

II. William J. Donovan (1883–1959) was one of America's most decorated heroes from World War I, during which he commanded an infantry regiment. In October 1914, near Landres-et-St.-Georges, France, he led the assaulting wave in an attack upon an enemy stronghold, "moving among his men in exposed positions, reorganizing decimated platoons, and accompanying them forward in attacks." When he was wounded in the leg, he refused to be evacuated and continued with his unit until it withdrew to a less exposed position. For his endurance and audacity, Donovan earned the lifelong moniker "Wild Bill," and for his acts of valor in combat he was awarded the Congressional Medal of Honor. Months before the U.S. entered World War II, Donovan, then a well-connected Wall Street lawyer and occasional diplomatic emissary, was selected by President Franklin Roosevelt to organize and lead the OSS, precursor to the CIA (established in 1947). Although Donovan never headed the CIA, he is regarded as its founding father, and a statue of him stands in the lobby of the CIA headquarters building in Langley, Virginia.

III. Actor-turned-Army-pilot Jimmy Stewart deployed to England in fall 1943 as the commanding officer of a B-24 squadron. Stewart flew more than twenty combat missions. After the war, during the 1946 filming of *It's a Wonderful Life*, he broke down in a scene with Donna Reed near the end of the movie. His display of raw emotion transformed the scene into one of the most impactful moments of his long film career. When director Frank Capra asked him to do it again for a better camera angle, Stewart said, "Please don't make me go back there again." Stewart rarely spoke of his war experiences, but years later he confessed what had brought up the powerful emotions that day on the set was his thinking about the men in his squadron who had not made it back home.

THREE

TRAINING AND TRAGEDY

Cliff Heflin and Bob Fish relinquished command of their two squadrons on December 4, 1943, to take on the larger roles of commanding officer and operations officer, respectively, of a newly formed bomb group encompassing all the air and ground operations of the Carpetbaggers.

Throughout a dry and mild November into a foggy and cold December, the U.S. flyers underwent training at Tempsford, an RAF base in eastern England. Crewmen were matched with the corresponding member of an experienced British crew to learn their responsibilities for the upcoming missions. Everyone attended lectures on navigational aids, map reading and radio communications. Pilots, navigators and bombardiers were required to fly along with experienced RAF crews on two missions over western Europe for indoctrination in night navigation and low-level parachute drops. Not surprisingly, Heflin was the first to finish his orientation flights, and Fish the second.

The Americans discovered how much of what they had previously been trained for they did not need, such as close-formation flying behind a leader to ensure no one became lost or fell back en route to a target. On the single-ship OSS missions, not only were they to be on their own to find the drop zones, but the aerial gunners got the message that without the combined firepower of other planes in a formation, their own guns were their only defense. Every crew's gunners practiced in classrooms for hours on end with dimly lit light boxes to strengthen their night vision, looking above, below, and to the side of silhouetted targets to pick them up in various levels of darkness. Locating a target in a light box, of course, was a world apart from hitting an enemy fighter with gun blazing in the night sky.

The flight crews weren't the only ones pushing to get ready. There was round-the-clock work for the mechanics, armorers, welders and other ground personnel, who practically lived with their assigned aircraft parked inside hangars and outside on hardstands. The B-24 bomb bay racks were adapted to carry a dozen steel torpedo-shaped supply containers that held up to three hundred pounds each. Once they were loaded aboard, a packed parachute was secured to a metal O-ring. When the containers were released like a rack of bombs, the chutes were pulled open by static lines attached to the plane.

Heflin assigned Capt. Robert Boone, one of the original anti-submarine pilots and the newly appointed commander of the 36th squadron, the all-important job of overseeing the modifications to their B-24 Liberators. "Modify them to suit our needs," ordered Heflin.

A tall, square-shouldered former rugby player at the University of California, Berkeley, Boone, twenty-seven, towered over most of his men but spoke softly and had a friendly countenance. This combination of attributes and personality made him a natural leader. Taking along a trained engineer from his squadron, Boone went to a nearby RAF maintenance base at Burtonwood and set up shop. To his surprise, he discovered the Carpetbaggers had one of the highest priorities of any Army Air Forces group in England, and whatever they needed soon arrived.

Boone oversaw the removal of the machine-gun "ball turret" on the underbelly of the planes in order to fashion a hole from which a parachutist could drop through. That alteration took some ingenuity, and the maintenance crews "worked their fannies off making it right... those guys are smart, nothing stumps them for long," Boone wrote in his journal. "They engineered the thing beautifully, and designed a smooth metal shroud for the hole and hinged a plywood door over the opening."



Robert Boone.

COURTESY OF THE BOONE FAMILY

The machine-gun position in the nose of the planes was also removed, leaving a smooth Plexiglas bubble through which the sky and ground were clearly visible. The machine guns in the waist positions on either side of the center cabin were taken out to make room for supplies and parachutists. One of the waist gunners was removed from the Carpetbagger crews and the other was now the designated dispatcher, who, acting as a parachute jumpmaster, made sure that the agents dropped safely and on time. A second gunner was dropped from the crew due to the removal of the ball-turret machine gun.¹ The other gun positions remained: the top turret and the tail turret, each with twin .50-cal. machine guns. In truth, stealth would be a solitary bomber's best defense over enemy territory. The planes were painted a black matte so they would be difficult

to detect by searchlight, and flame dampeners were installed on the engines to reduce the fiery glow of their exhaust.

Boone knew the missions would be practically all instrument flying at night, and often at low altitudes. Installed in the planes was an absolute height altimeter, which was a radar altimeter that gave the precise distance between the aircraft and the terrain. They also had a barometric altimeter for their height above sea level. As the flights would leave and return in the dark, Boone had changes made so the key gauges were easy to find without cockpit lighting. “You’ve got to fly ‘em,” a technician told Boone. “If that’s what you want, that’s what you’ll get.”

Notwithstanding the alterations, the B-24 Liberator was the ideal aircraft for the OSS missions. Its capacious fuselage, heavy payload capacity, long range and cruising speed made it the envy of British aviators, who had to fly older, obsolete planes on their missions to drop supplies and agents because the newer RAF bombers were striking deep inside the Third Reich. The B-24’s high-wing design was another plus for the missions. With wings fixed above the fuselage, the crew had better visibility below than did the crew of a low-wing plane like the B-17, which conversely had better visibility above. To further improve the pilots’ line of sight to the ground when flying low at night—when ground collisions were a hazard—blister windows that could open were installed on either side of the cockpit.

Nonessential equipment was stripped from the planes, including the tanks, bottles, brackets, regulators and flowmeters for the oxygen system. They would not be flying high enough (never above 10,000 feet) to need supplemental oxygen, nor would they have to don the insulated flight suits that kept bomber crews from freezing in the unheated cabin at higher altitudes, where temperatures often fell well below zero. Armor plates welded to the inside of the fuselage as protection from bullets and shrapnel were considered unnecessary weight. “It seemed such a waste to yank out the oxygen equipment, armor plating and extra machine guns,” wrote Boone, “but the more we lighten the aircraft the more speed we will pick up when needed and the more maneuverable we will be over the drop zone.”

Interior lighting throughout the plane was removed or converted to a low-intensity red, and a blackout curtain was installed around the navigator's place in the nose of the plane so he could work under a flexible lamp without light leaking out. Flying a few hundred feet off the ground in the dark required intense concentration by the pilots as well as the bombardier, also positioned in the nose of the plane on a swivel seat in front of the navigator, where he could look out the clear Plexiglas nose and call out landmarks, which helped the navigator fix their location on his maps.

On an overcast day in November, the king and queen of England—with a small entourage—paid a visit to Tempsford. Heflin and Fish were introduced to them, and in turn they introduced the royals to six exemplary crews of Carpetbaggers standing by their planes.

King George was full of questions for the American flyers.

How long have you been here?

How do you like England?

How many aircrews do you have?

How did you get picked for this job?

The queen—fur stole slung over her shoulders and hat at a jaunty angle—reached out a gloved hand to firmly shake hands with each man. “Where is your home?” she asked the men before thanking them personally for “the wonderful work you are doing.”

Of course, for the Americans the real work had yet to begin, but they were impressed with the royal welcome, after which Heflin, Fish, Boone and a hundred other Carpetbagger officers and enlisted men adjourned to the mess hall for tea with the royals. “The king reminded me of dad,” Boone wrote to his wife, Victoria. “Very gracious, awfully nice, and asked personal questions. The queen was wonderful, too.”

As some crews continued to work on modifications for the aircraft, others tested the equipment and themselves on cross-country flights during the day and—most importantly—at night, when all of England was in blackout conditions to make cities less of a target for German bombers. They duplicated the real thing as best they could, including finding a rural drop zone and dropping containers and dummies with parachutes.

One lesson the Americans learned from the British crews who had flown SOE missions was the importance of memorizing the route to the drop zone. The most successful missions, they were told, came after crews had spent hours studying their routes in and out of Europe, memorizing landmarks and literally map-reading their way to the target.

Precise navigation would be the difference between inserting agents into the right location or leaving them lost and at risk of capture. And misdrops of munitions, radios and other supplies were not only a waste but could end up in enemy hands and cost partisan lives. Locating a small drop zone in a field was difficult under any conditions, but at night the degree of difficulty was greatly increased. At the time, the art and science of night navigation was more the former than the latter. However, some new navigational electronics were installed in the B-24s, including a Mark V drift sight—a tubular device to measure the wind speed and calculate its effects on an aircraft’s course—fitted in the navigator’s compartment. Another new instrument: a “Gee Box” radio-signal homing device developed by the British for obtaining fixes throughout England and over western Europe. It received signals from a master transmitting station and several other stations around England. By triangulating the signals, an aircraft’s navigator could locate an airfield in foggy England, but it was less help finding a location on the continent because the long-range radio signals from England were easily jammed by the Germans. The planes were also equipped with a “Rebecca” receiver, a homing device with a cathode-ray tube that displayed an S-shaped wave when the plane received a signal from a “Eureka” transmitter on the ground. The range was no more than fifteen miles, so it was useful for final course corrections as they neared the drop zone. But the party on the ground had to have a transmitter, which wasn’t always the case. Also, an S-phone—a UHF radiotelephone system—was installed for the radio operator to speak to the party on the ground on the ground. But again, the partisans had to be equipped with the suitcase-size transceiver for the duplex system to work.

Before the first Carpetbagger planes began to roar down the unlit runway minutes apart, headed on missions lasting up to ten hours, the procedures for an intricate thirty-six-hour cycle of planning were ironed out. It all started the day

before a mission, when local resistance networks sent their requests for specific arms and supplies—along with the coordinates of their drop zones—by secret wireless transmissions to OSS headquarters at 77 Baker Street, an unmarked building in London that hummed day and night with intelligence activity. The reception fields where the parachute drops were made were given code names: forenames such as BOB, HENRI and LUKE, trade names such as LAWYER, CARPENTER and SALESMAN, or equine names such as RUMP, BRIDLE and SADDLE—and numbered 1 to 300. They were flagged on a huge wall map.

On the morning of a mission, the locations of reception fields—along with “grocery lists” of requested items—were dispatched to the Carpetbaggers, after which Heflin and Fish assigned crews to specific missions. Navigators and bombardiers then began poring over topographical maps showing the heights and shapes of mountains and hills, roads, railroads, rivers and lakes to determine the best route to the location. Every crew mapped its own course, avoiding enemy airfields and known locations of antiaircraft weapons. Weather conditions were checked. To help crews find their drop zones at night, missions were scheduled between a first-quarter and last-quarter moon, a period of about seventeen days of moonlight per month. Their targets weren’t rail yards, factories or the sprawl of cities like other Allied bombers, but patches of ground in a dark countryside.

Daily, BBC Radio broadcasted a series of seemingly meaningless messages, such as “Henri found two francs.” But listening on hidden radios, partisans—recognizing the code name of their drop zone—knew that a mission was scheduled for HENRI 2 the next morning. That usually gave them about six hours to put together a reception party.

Meanwhile, at a nearby supply depot, loaders spent the day filling the torpedo-shaped steel containers with the requested items: everything from pistols, bazookas, hand grenades and dynamite to medicine, radios and bicycle tires (made in England with French trademarks). Although the containers looked nearly identical on the outside, there were two models. The “H” containers had five compartments inside, which could be quickly unclamped and separated once they landed, and each carried away by one man. One standard “H” load was five Sten submachine guns with fifteen magazines; 1,500

rounds of 9mm ammunition; five pistols with 250 rounds; fifty-two grenades; and eighteen pounds of explosives. The “C” containers were for longer items, such as rifles, machine guns and anti-tank bazookas. Included in a standard “C” load were two Bren machine guns with sixteen magazines and 2,000 rounds of .303 ammunition. The contents were distributed and packed so as to balance the load and improve the chances of their landing undamaged. They were then padded with shock-absorbing materials such as burlap before the containers were squeezed shut. Odd-shaped or more fragile items were placed in a custom-designed bundle and cushioned to withstand the opening shock of the parachute and landing. These were referred to simply as “packages.” The containers and packages were loaded into aircraft being readied for a mission hours before takeoff.

By the end of 1943, the Carpetbaggers had thirty-six B-24s and trained crews ready to go. As preparations were wrapping up, it got more real for the flyers when they were issued survival kits that fit into a leg pocket of their flying suit. They held a variety of currencies, maps printed on silk, needle and thread, a compass, halazone tablets to purify water, and matches. Everyone carried a photo of himself in European attire that could be used on forged ID documents provided to them by the resistance.

The crews assembled for an escape-and-evasion lecture by an Army lieutenant, whom everyone listened to *very* attentively. In the event they crashed or bailed out behind enemy lines, the lieutenant’s advice: bury your life jacket, parachute and other unneeded gear, move away from the crash site, stay off roads and hide in the woods. “Be patient. Think before making a move.” He said it was best to remain out of sight for the first twenty-four hours, when the enemy was most likely to be searching for them, then use their compass to go south toward the Pyrenees range and neutral Spain.

With Christmas 1943 came a welcome respite for the American flyers and ground personnel when they hosted children brought in from nearby villages. They played ball with them, and hard-bitten sergeants gave kids rides on the handlebars of bicycles. Gifts and candy were handed out, but the biggest treat came at the end of the festivities when ice cream was dished up. To the older children, it was a fond and distant memory of the days before wartime rationing.

To the younger ones, ice cream was something of a myth, and their eyes expanded to saucer dimensions after the first spoonful. Only two squadron members were reported to have acquired headaches from the day's events: a pair of young lieutenants who accompanied the trucks that carried the children back to their respective homes. Until a late hour, they were still trying to find homes for a few sleepy and uncommunicative kids. But "with admirable patience and perseverance," the lieutenants solved each case, after which they returned to the base for a well-earned night's sleep.

Hard on the heels of the holiday came tragedy.

In the early hours of December 27, Capt. Robert L. Williams, the popular operations officer of the 36th squadron, and his crew—one of the original anti-submarine crews—were on a navigational training flight in their newly modified B-24. Their route was intended to take them from Taunton in southern England four hundred miles north to Bude Bay, but rapidly deteriorating weather caused them to deviate twenty miles off course.

Residents of Widecombe in the Moor, a village in Devon that encompassed dozens of isolated cottages and moorland farms, awakened to the roar of a low-flying plane, then a loud boom. The B-24 had struck a cloud-shrouded ridge and burned out. All eight crewmen died instantly.

News of the crash didn't reach the base until the next day, long after the dejected ground crew gave up waiting for their overdue aircraft.

Two days later, Capt. Jesse F. Messer, the squadron flight surgeon, took a train to the Torquay railway station in Devon to meet the eight caskets and escort the remains by rail to the Brookwood American Military Cemetery, where they were buried with full military honors. The deaths—the first loss of a Carpetbagger crew in the war—were officially classified not as wartime casualties but DNB—Died Non-Battle.

It was a distinction that was lost on their fellow flyers.

¹ With the elimination of the gun positions, two gunners were dropped from the usual ten-man crews. The enlisted men who were removed were given a final security lecture about not disclosing anything about the Carpetbaggers and were immediately transferred out.

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FOUR

EARLY MISSIONS, FIRST COMBAT LOSSES

Cliff Heflin scheduled himself to fly on the first night of Carpetbagger missions, January 4, 1944. Six B-24s departed from RAF Alconbury, seventy miles north of London, at ten-minute intervals starting around 9 p.m. Under a moon nearly 70 percent illuminated and waxing toward full, each aircraft headed for a different drop zone in France. Between them, their bomb bays held 72 steel containers carefully loaded with some 20,000 pounds of munitions and supplies for resistance forces.

It was close to midnight when Heflin's plane arrived in the vicinity of their drop zone. They circled for fifteen minutes before spotting three white lights in a triangle, and a fourth red one repeatedly flashing in Morse code the letter "A" (dot-dash), the correct letter code that confirmed the reception party was in place. The lights were placed so that the wind was blowing toward the flashing red light and across the center of the triangle, which allowed Heflin to line up his approach into the wind, helping to reduce the bomber's airspeed. After he lowered the landing gear to create more drag to slow the plane and set full 40-degree wing flaps, their speed dropped from 200 mph to a lumbering 120 mph.

From his position in the nose of the plane, the bombardier watched the ground as they approached the drop zone. Just as they passed the first white light, he pushed the release button to drop the dozen containers from the bomb bay all at once.

The partisans waiting below were members of one of the most significant resistance circuits operating in France. Code-named WHEELWRIGHT, it was active in a huge swath of the southwest. The group had already carried out many successful operations, including rescuing from prison some fifty resistance

leaders and helping more than a dozen downed Allied airmen cross the mountains into Spain.

After Heflin gained some airspeed and altitude, bundles of leaflets were rolled out of the open bomb bay by the dispatcher. Scattered to the winds for miles were copies of *Le Courrier de l'Air*, a French-language newspaper printed in London that provided reports on the progress of the war for French citizens eagerly awaiting liberation. The printed matter fluttering to the ground would also provide a plausible explanation for the bomber circling the area if they were seen or picked up on radar,¹ hopefully discouraging the Germans from launching a search before the partisans unloaded the containers and disappeared into the dark woods.

Heflin then turned northwest toward their egress checkpoint near Pointe de la Percée, a stretch of cliffs at the north end of what would be known to the world six months later as Omaha Beach. They left the French coast at an altitude of 6,000 feet, crossed the Channel, passed over Selsey Bill—a headland on the south coast of England—at 2,000 feet and landed at Tempsford at 3:20 a.m. The next day, a coded message was received at OSS London reporting that the drop had been successful.

Of the six planes that flew that night, three returned without having dropped their containers because they hadn't seen any signal lights. Although that meant only 50 percent of the deliveries had been made, Heflin counted the first night as a success because all his crews returned safely.



Carpetbagger B-24: "Miss Fitts."

U.S. ARMY SIGNAL CORPS

Still, the ramp-up to the Carpetbagger operations was painfully slow. Over the next two weeks—when the moon became full and was visible from sunset to sunrise—eighteen flights departed, but half of them didn't find their drop zones and returned with their bomb bays filled with the arms and supplies intended for the partisans. Heflin knew they had to do better. "This work is trickier than bombing," he told his pilots. "You're not following a formation and you're on your own. It takes a lot of practice and flying skill to hit a drop zone on the nose in the dark." Heflin knew it would take some combination of skill, luck, timing and teamwork to succeed. His message to his crews: keep working at it.

In mid-January, a waning new moon darkened the night sky, and the lack of illumination made it difficult to identify the terrain features needed as checkpoints. Carpetbagger flights were halted for two weeks until the next moon period in February. In their second month of operations, the total missions nearly tripled to fifty-three, most to France, and a few to Nazi-occupied Norway and Belgium. In all, they dropped some 70,000 pounds of matériel. "The results for the month," Bob Fish wrote in the group's history, "were a marked improvement over January's efforts."

The newly appointed commander of the Eighth Air Force arrived at the base on February 10. Lt. Gen. James "Jimmy" Doolittle was already an American hero for leading a flight of sixteen land-based bombers manned by Army Air Forces crews that launched from the aircraft carrier USS *Hornet* on April 18,

1942, to strike Tokyo and other targets in Japan nearly 1,000 miles away. After the raid, when his plane ran out of gas over China, Doolittle had his crew bail out and he crash-landed the plane in a rice paddy. He and his crew slipped past Japanese troops with the help of Chinese resistance fighters and made it back to the United States. Several others weren't so lucky. Seven flyers lost their lives—three in crashes or parachuting mishaps; three were executed by a Japanese firing squad in Shanghai after a sham thirty-minute trial; and a fourth died in the Nanking prison camp of ill treatment. The “Doolittle Raid” did only minor damage to military and industrial targets, but it was the first U.S. strike against Japan's home islands. A propaganda victory for the U.S., it raised the morale at home and caused the first serious doubts among Japan's leaders of its military's ability to defend the home islands.

For Heflin and Fish and other veteran pilots, Doolittle was an aviation pioneer for still another reason: his early advancement of instrument flying. He was the first to realize that operational freedom in the air could be achieved only by training pilots to fly on instruments. He helped develop new instruments to facilitate safe flying under conditions resembling zero visibility, then set out to prove they worked. On September 24, 1929, Doolittle climbed into the rear seat of a Consolidated Husky biplane and became the first pilot in history to take off, fly a planned course and land on instruments alone. A safety pilot rode in the forward cockpit, but the entire flight was conducted by Doolittle, who was under a fabric hood and unable to see outside the plane. All he had to rely on were a new application of the visual radio beacon for navigation, an improved instrument for indicating the longitudinal and lateral position of an aircraft, a new directional gyroscope and a barometric altimeter so sensitive it measured a plane's altitude within a few feet of the ground. The dawn of “blind” all-instrument flying took aviation into a new era and soon improved the versatility of military aircraft and the safety of commercial aviation.

Doolittle came to the base shared by RAF and Carpetbagger crews so he could be there to receive the king and queen, who arrived an hour after him for their second visit in three months. King George wore his British army uniform with RAF pilot wings, which as England's sovereign he was entitled to wear although he was not a pilot. Doolittle took the royal couple on a tour of the base

that ended on the flight line, where rows of B-24s were parked. This time, only a single Carpetbagger crew had been selected for their inspection. The eight men of the Wagstad crew—ranging in age from twenty-three to thirty—stood next to their black bomber, which bore the name “Jive Bomber II” painted in script on its nose. The pilot, Capt. Gerald S. Wagstad, twenty-seven, of Minnesota, proudly told the royals, “Today is my crew’s one-year anniversary together.” They had completed their fourth combat mission a day earlier and, despite snowy weather, had located their drop zone and made their delivery to the PAUL circuit operating against the northern slopes of the Pyrenees. That successful drop in mountainous terrain and inclement weather was likely why they were chosen for this honor. The Wagstad crew fielded questions from the royal couple. While the king seemed shy at times, the queen was not, and often was the inquisitor.

The Carpetbaggers had not yet dropped any personnel by parachute, but that was about to change. Requesting and receiving permission for a “test drop” of intelligence agents from a B-24, Heflin scheduled it for March 2 with himself as pilot. He handpicked an experienced crew, with the capable Robert Boone as his copilot.

Later that afternoon, two SOE agents arrived at the base in a car with curtained windows. The men were taken to a “dressing hut,” where any objects that might betray them—such as British money or American cigarettes—were confiscated. They dressed in civilian clothes with the right labels, and in addition to a forged picture ID showing them to be French citizens, they were given items the average civilian carried: a train ticket stub, European cigarettes and what looked to be family photos.

The B-24’s crew was already aboard and at their stations when the agents arrived on the flight line in the same vehicle that brought them to the base. In the event the plane went down and anyone in the crew fell into enemy hands, no one was to know the names of the agents, who were referred to as “Joe” or “Josephine,” depending on their gender. The agents climbed up a short ladder and entered through a mid-cabin hatch. They were directed by the dispatcher to sit on the plywood floorboard installed over the plane’s corrugated metal surface.

Handrails had been installed on one side of the opening through which they would jump, known as the “Joe Hole.”

Takeoff was shortly before 8 p.m. They had just passed Oxford—about halfway to their first checkpoint of Bognor Regis, a seaside town on England’s south coast—when the Gee Box radio-signal homing device for obtaining fixes throughout England and over western Europe stopped working. That meant the navigator and bombardier would have to get them to their target by dead reckoning and map reading. Heflin trusted them to do that, and rather than abort, he pressed on.

They crossed the French coast at Cabourg, a Norman town just north of Caen. When they reached the area of their drop near the Loire River at about midnight, Heflin took them under a 3,000-foot overcast to locate the triangle of signal lights, which they soon spotted. He slowed the plane and dropped down to 600 feet. Up in the nose, the bombardier turned on the red “Action Station” that flashed in the back telling the dispatcher to prepare the agents to jump. A minute later when they were over the lights, the bombardier flipped on the green “Go” light. The agents quickly jumped out the Joe Hole, disappearing into the pitch-black maw one after the other.

The plane had flown low and slow over the drop zone—considered by aircrews to be the most vulnerable and nerve-racking moments of a mission—for only seven minutes. After returning to cruise speed and regaining some altitude, Heflin turned for home. Their load of leaflets went out over the town of Blois, a few miles away.

Now dropped on every Carpetbagger mission, the French-language leaflets included the latest war news, brought up to the hour on field printing presses operated throughout England by the Army’s Psychological Warfare Branch. The hot-off-the-presses handbills were widely read, even in areas under German control, where a death sentence followed discovery that a civilian had possession of such materials. Nevertheless, they were shared and kept for months in shoes, hats, false pockets and other hiding places.



Agent dropping through Joe Hole under watchful eye of plane's dispatcher (left).

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Heflin landed at 2:08 a.m. Total flight time: six hours and thirteen minutes. The crew reported to the map-strewn, smoke-filled room used to debrief returning crews, which took place before they received their two-ounce shot of “medicinal” whiskey from the squadron surgeon, after which they went to the mess hall for a breakfast of fresh eggs instead of the usual powdered variety. In the mission report, Heflin wrote: “Beautiful piece of work by navigator and bombardier in navigating to and from target by pure DR [dead reckoning] and map reading.”

Later that morning, Heflin sent a priority communiqué to Col. Haskell, the London-based OSS officer who had first briefed him and Bob Fish months earlier. “Our airplanes are equipped for dropping personnel.... By agreement with your office, a mission was successfully completed 2 March 1944, in which two bodies were dropped.” Heflin asked for authority to drop additional personnel on operational missions. His request was promptly granted.

In their first two months of combat operations, the Carpetbaggers had not lost a plane or suffered any combat casualties. Their streak of good fortune ended the same night Heflin made his test drop of agents, when the McDonald crew—on its fifth mission—failed to return. A coded radio message the next day from the field confirmed their containers were dropped at MUSICIAN 4 in northern France. It was three months before their fellow flyers learned what happened to their first MIA crew.



Carpetbagger crews being debriefed in the map room by intelligence officers after their missions.

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After being struck by heavy fire from antiaircraft guns mounted on railway cars, the B-24's #1 engine was hit, #2 was on fire, #3 was hit and out, the left wing was ablaze and there were fist-size holes in the side of the plane. The pilot, 1st Lt. Frank McDonald, took violent evasive action to maneuver away from the enemy guns. After losing altitude, they were too low to bail out, and McDonald fought to regain some altitude. But within seconds fire had engulfed both wings. Their only chance was to crash-land. The descent was steep and rapid, and they tore a blazing path through a line of trees, gouging a deep rut in the ground before coming to a grinding halt next to a road. The aircraft by then was a raging inferno. The two pilots leapt from a broken cockpit window and the rest of the crew fought to get free of the burning wreckage. Once they were out, the men

turned back to look for anyone still in the plane. But the intense heat forced them to retreat just before the fuel tanks exploded in a fiery ball.

Of the crew's eight flyers, seven survived the crash; six evaded capture for several weeks before being caught and sent on their way to POW camps in Germany. Only the copilot, 2nd Lt. Frederick Kelly, made it to the Pyrenees and Spain with the aid of the resistance. He returned to base on June 1, 1944, and gave a detailed report of the crash.

The fate of the eighth crewman, flight engineer Sgt. Norman R. Gellerman—last seen through smoke as he dropped down from the top gun turret—was “one of those strange things that happen in war for which there are no explanations,” recalled Sgt. Don Fairbanks of the McGee crew, which bunked with the McDonald crew in a hall filled with cots and footlockers. On the day of his last flight, Gellerman, who wore a small wooden cross around his neck, told the others they could divvy up his belongings when he didn't come back that night. His bleak foreboding came true: he was the only member of his crew to die in the crash.^{[II](#)}

The Carpetbaggers' run of bad luck continued the next night when two aircraft failed to return from the skies over France. First to go down was the Carpenter crew, when their plane was hit at 11:10 p.m. by flak—an acronym for the German word *Flugabwehrkanone*, meaning aircraft-defense cannon—and crashed in the Somme region of northern France. Only the tail gunner, Sgt. John H. Dudley, had time to bail out, and in spite of the low altitude he landed without injuries. The rest of the crew rode the ship down. The copilot, 2nd Lt. Bernard Eshleman, was wounded in the neck and foot. The radio operator, Sgt. Eden Burris, lost his left eye. The engineer, Sgt. Clarence Johnson, suffered a broken ankle. The shock of the crash was especially brutal in the nose compartment. The navigator, 1st Lt. Lonnie Hammond Jr., was killed in the crash. The bombardier, 2nd Lt. William D. Rees, was trapped under heavy metal with both legs crushed. Two of the uninjured, including the pilot, 1st Lt. Wade A. Carpenter, walked to a nearby village to get help. The local doctor and several other men arrived to render aid. Pieces of jagged metal had to be cut away before Rees could be pulled free. By noontime, all the survivors had been taken prisoner by the Germans. Rees was transported to a hospital in Amiens, where

both his legs were amputated the next day. He succumbed to his injuries hours later. For the rest of the crew, headed to a POW camp, their war was over.

That same night, the Wagstad crew—the model crew chosen to meet the king and queen during their visit three weeks earlier—did not return from their mission. Reports from the field indicated they had made a successful drop at PETER 54 in the Eure-et-Loir region southwest of Paris at 1:40 a.m. but were not seen after that. Eight more men were gone; their footlockers were cleared out of personal items sent to families, who were notified that their loved ones were “missing in action.” Those families held out hope for their missing husbands, sons, brothers and uncles until the end of the war.[III](#)

The three crews that had gone down in a twenty-four-hour period all came from the 36th Squadron, whose CO, Robert Boone, sat down to write a personal letter to each missing flyer’s next of kin, promising to send more information as soon as he received any word. Being a new commanding officer, they were his first notification letters, and writing so many of them at once was a heartbreaking duty for Boone, who knew each man personally. Only a handwritten letter to the family from a man’s commanding officer would do, he knew, but it was an awful job. On nights when he wasn’t flying, Boone could be found in the field’s control tower when it was time for his crews to start returning from their missions. Each time a plane landed, he jumped in his jeep and raced to the flight line to greet the crew as soon as they parked their aircraft. He kept watch in the tower until the last one landed, as late as 4 or 5 a.m.



Wagstad crew dining with guests in Baltimore, Maryland, shortly before they went overseas in late 1943. Left to right: Eleanor Connor, copilot Lorimer Petersen; Isabel Connor; navigator Edward J. Martinez Jr.; bombardier Joseph P. Connor Jr.; Mary Harris; and pilot Gerald S. Wagstad.

CARPETBAGGERS HISTORY WEBSITE

The Carpetbaggers' first double-drop mission of supplies and agents was attempted the night of March 6, 1944. Heflin, ever the believer in leading from the front, again scheduled himself as pilot. They departed at 8 p.m. and headed to southeast France, where the FOOTMAN 14 circuit—active for three months—was mobilizing partisans. Several hours later, they arrived at the first drop zone and saw the lights and the correct letter flashing.

Back in the cabin of the aircraft were two SOE agents. Robert René Boiteux-Burdett, born in London to French parents, had been schooled in both countries. When war broke out, his knowledge of France and ability to speak the language like a native attracted the attention of the SOE, which he eagerly joined because “blowing up trains seemed quite an exciting thing to do.” Now in his late thirties, he had previously been a Bond Street hairdresser and a gold prospector in Kenya, where he was the colonial featherweight boxing champion three years running. After parachuting from an RAF plane a year earlier over Lyon, he first had to spring from jail his wireless operator, Robert Sheppard, who had the hard luck of landing on the roof of a police station and found himself in handcuffs before he even trod on French soil. Subsequently, Boiteux-Burdett escaped from a pair of Gestapo agents after slugging it out with them in a dark hallway, after which he went on a wanted list with a 20,000-franc reward (about \$7,000 today) on his head. He secretly trained partisans late at night at the city zoo next to the bear enclosure, whose captive audience watched them,

“very nosy, very interested, as if they wanted to learn,” he reported. Recalled to England in fall 1943, he was picked up in a French cow pasture by a British single-engine Lysander whose short-field landing and takeoff capabilities enabled it to fly clandestine missions behind enemy lines. Originally designed to carry a single pilot and one passenger in the rear cockpit, some were modified for SOE use with a rearward-facing bench for two additional passengers. In England, Boiteux-Burdett was given additional training in explosives, including working in an airplane parts factory for a week to learn the best ways to sabotage a plant. Having earned a reputation as someone who “thrived on narrow escapes,” he was now returning to France to organize resisters in the Marseille area. Jumping with him this night was Benjamin Aptaker, a Belgian-born Jew of Russian parents, who spoke passable French. A trained wireless operator, Aptaker was to transmit and receive messages between London and the resistance. He would have to do so from a new location each time and remain on the air only briefly because the Germans—especially in or near urban settings—had the mobile equipment to track down a radio signal within thirty minutes. At the “Go” green light, Boiteux-Burdett jumped first, followed by Aptaker. A message from the field received in London the next day confirmed their safe arrival.

After the two agents jumped, Heflin turned south toward the next drop zone. At 12:24 a.m., they spotted one red light but only a single white light in a small clearing that was nearly impossible to see until they were right over it. Lights on top of a hill would have been easier to see from the air, but they would also have been easier for enemy patrols to find. For that reason, partisans often located their drop zones in valleys surrounded by hills and forests, making a low-level approach from the air a challenge. Heflin made two low passes before dropping the containers, which meant spending more than twenty minutes over the drop zone. After tossing out bundles of leaflets a few miles away, they cleared the French coast and landed in a foggy England at 4:25 a.m. In the mission report, Heflin recommended against further drops at the location “unless they have better lighting.”

By spring 1944, well over a million German ground, air and naval forces were deployed throughout France, a country the Nazis had turned into a tightly controlled police state. The cruelest regime enforcers were the Gestapo, Hitler’s

infamous secret state police, and the Milice, a French militia created by the pro-Nazi Vichy government headed by Marshal Philippe Pétain.^{IV} Comprising brutal Nazis and hardened criminals, they employed intimidation, torture and murder to infiltrate resistance circuits and hunt down French partisans and Allied agents. By 1943, a number of resistance circuits had been compromised, usually after the capture of a wireless operator and his or her radio set and codebooks, which enemy agents then used to request drops of munitions and agents where they could be seized. It was inevitable that the SOE and OSS unwittingly sent British and U.S. flyers to drop munitions, supplies and spies to circuits under German control, although a full accounting of how often this happened was never made. What is certain, in retrospect, is that the first time a Carpetbagger crew parachuted agents into a Gestapo trap occurred the night after Heflin's inaugural double-drop.

The pilot for that ill-fated mission happened to be Robert Boone, who had flown three missions in two months, far fewer than he liked due to his administrative duties. When his own squadron was assigned its first double-drop mission, Boone scheduled himself to fly it on March 7, 1944, which fell in the middle of that month's luminous-moon period.

In the waxing gibbous phase, the moon—just a few nights shy of full—was 94 percent illuminated when they took off at 9 p.m. This greatly aided Boone's crew in holding their correct course by observing their terrain checkpoints as they followed a series of compass headings preplanned by the navigator. The moonlight was also helpful in locating what they were looking for at the eastern end of the Brittany peninsula: the Daon commune, known for its ancient castles, and a bend in the Mayenne River just east of their drop zone. They soon spotted a triangle of three red lights and at its apex a single white light repeatedly flashing the letter "C" (dash-dot), the correct letter for their drop at BUTLER 12A. The signal lights were dim, but that wasn't concerning to Boone, as the partisans used a variety of signals based on availability, ranging from flashlights and lanterns to small campfires. Showing the correct letter code, however, was crucial. If they hadn't seen it flashing below, Boone would have headed back to England without dropping the pair of agents or the dozen containers stacked in the bomb bay.

Boone decided to make a long approach and drop everything on a single pass. He took them down to 600 feet, slowed to 125 mph and headed upwind toward the target. At 10:58 p.m., the containers left the bomb bay first, then the agents quickly followed down the Joe Hole.

At the relatively early hour of 1:13 a.m., Boone landed back in England. The mission was logged as “completed.” Over the next six months, the Boone crew went on to fly fifteen missions and dropped nine agents, all safely behind enemy lines. Neither Boone nor his crew ever learned what had gone tragically wrong at BUTLER 12A.

The two SOE agents they dropped that night were longtime resistance fighters. Octave Simon, a notable French sculptor before the war, became a resister soon after the German invasion. By 1942, the twenty-nine-year-old was helping to form a new circuit in northwest France. After receiving several nighttime drops of munitions and supplies from RAF aircraft, Simon discovered that his circuit, SATIRIST, and a larger one in the area, PROSPER, had been infiltrated by enemy collaborators. Scores of resistance members were arrested and imprisoned. Nearly captured by the Gestapo no less than four times, Simon made his way to Angers, sixty miles away. In August 1943, he was picked up by a Lysander and flown to London, where he underwent SOE training. He was to return to France with wireless operator Marcel Defence. Their mission: restart SATIRIST.

Born in London to French parents, Defence was recruited by the SOE in 1942, not for his French, which he spoke imperfectly, but for his mechanical aptitude given his prewar employment with Austin Motor Company. His unobtrusive nature and security-mindedness suggested he would make a good wireless operator skilled at codes and cyphers, which was a particular need in order for London and the resistance to keep in close communication. After completing his training, he parachuted from an RAF plane in May 1943 to join a new circuit forming near Paris, which was an especially dangerous assignment since another resistance network in the area had collapsed months earlier. The Gestapo had well-placed collaborators, and soon a new wave of arrests began, forcing Defence to flee to Bordeaux, 350 miles to the south. After an unsuccessful attempt to enter Spain, he crossed the Channel by boat and arrived

back in London in January 1944. Two months later, he volunteered for a second mission and found himself paired with Octave Simon.

The two agents expected to be met at the drop zone by partisans from the BUTLER circuit. But unbeknownst to them—and to the SOE or OSS—a wireless operator with the circuit had been captured months earlier, and the Germans were using his wireless set and codebook to trick the Americans and British into dropping more agents and munitions. When Simon and Defence jumped that moonlit night, the good fortune that had been with them through their earlier escapes ran out. They parachuted into the clutches of waiting enemy forces, who had the field surrounded.

After being held and likely tortured for information by the Gestapo, Simon and Defence were sent to Rawicz Prison in Poland. Thirteen SOE agents held there—Simon and Defence included—were later transported to Germany, where they were shot in the execution yard at Gross-Rosen concentration camp in September 1944 and their remains incinerated in the crematorium.

I. At the beginning of World War II, Germany had progressed further in the development of radar than any other country. Radar was installed on a German warship as early as 1936, and the Germans employed radar on the ground and in the air for defense against Allied bombers. Radar development was halted by the Germans shortly before the U.S. entered the war because they were confident the war was nearly won. At the same time, the U.S. and Great Britain accelerated their efforts, leading to their development during the war of radars with higher frequencies (in the microwave range) that surpassed the earlier radar systems; had greater accuracy, better resolution and less atmospheric interference; and excluded unwanted echoes from the ground.

II. Norman “Ray” Gellerman, twenty-six, a skilled mechanic, was one of nine siblings raised in a seven-bedroom Victorian home in St. Paul, Minnesota. On what would have been his twenty-seventh birthday a week before Christmas 1944, Ray’s wife was notified that his status had changed from MIA to KIA. She eventually was sent his wooden cross, blackened by fire. He is buried at the Normandy American Cemetery in Colleville-sur-Mer. Today, at a rest area on northbound D-925 near where the McDonald crew’s B-24 crashed sits a black stone monument with a French epitaph. The English translation: “In memory of Sergeant American aviator Norman R. Gellerman, who fell at this place, on March 2nd, 1944, during a parachute drop mission for our Maquis.”

III. Inexplicably, the remains of all eight members of the Wagstad crew were already in their graves at Orleans Main Cemetery—sixty miles from where they crashed—buried by locals who had recovered them from the smoldering wreckage of their plane soon after the crash. Learning of this only after the war, some families then had the remains of their loved one reinterred at American memorial cemeteries in France, and others chose final resting places closer to home.

IV. From exile in London, Gen. Charles de Gaulle led the Free French movement, which eventually was able to unify most French resistance forces in their struggle against Germany. After the war, Philippe Pétain was tried by a French court for treason and sentenced to death. De Gaulle commuted the sentence to life imprisonment. Pétain died in 1951 at the age of ninety-five.

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FIVE

CALL THEM JOSEPHINE

Authorized by Winston Churchill to recruit women as undercover operatives, the SOE sent into Nazi-occupied France more than four hundred agents, including fifty female operatives. The British and American aircrews who dropped the women by parachute from low-flying planes on moonlit nights knew them only as “Josephine,” and the public would not know their true identities or learn of their secret missions until years later. Such were the perils that fourteen female agents lost their lives in the struggle to liberate France.

“Some people have suggested that we should never have sent women on these missions,” SOE French Section chief Maurice Buckmaster, an Englishman who before the war headed Ford Motor’s European operations, wrote in 1958. “I cannot agree. Women are as brave and as responsible as men; often more so. From the purely tactical point of view, women were able to move about without exciting so much suspicion as men and were less likely to be snapped up by Germans for forced labor. I should have been failing in my duty to the war effort if I had refused to employ them, and I should have been unfair to their abilities if I had considered them unequal to the duties which were imposed upon them.... In the final analysis, an agent had to rely on himself or herself, upon skill, upon coolness, upon courage, and most capricious of all, upon fortune.”

For Nancy Wake—Kiwi by birth with an Aussie childhood, French by marriage, loyal British subject—volunteering to jump into wartime France was a promise kept.

Born in a weatherboard shack in Wellington, New Zealand, in 1912, she was the youngest of six children raised in Sydney, Australia, by their mother after the

father left on a three-month business trip to America but never returned. Six-year-old Nancy adored her father and could not understand why he didn't come back. Her mother claimed not to know why, and the family received no letter or postcard from him. Eventually, a heartbroken Nancy gave up waiting for her daddy to come home. After that, she began to feel isolated from the rest of the family, and unhappy, she ran away from home twice. At age eighteen, she worked as a nurse in a mental hospital, and a year later used a small inheritance from an aunt to set out to see the world. After short stays in Vancouver and New York, she landed in London. Deciding that being a reporter was a great way to fulfill her wanderlust, she enrolled in journalism courses—as well as typing and shorthand—at Queen's College. A year later, she applied for a job as a correspondent with the Hearst newspapers. In the interview, she was told knowing about Egypt would be a plus.

"*Egypt?*" Nancy exclaimed. "I *love* Egypt! I've been there many times, and I can write in Egyptian!" The truth was that she'd never been to Egypt nor did she speak or write Egyptian. It was the kind of brazen bluff she could pull off that would serve her well during the war.

Her interviewer was impressed. Believing he was putting her to the test, he asked her to take a transcription in Egyptian as he read an article aloud. For five minutes, a grinning Nancy scribbled away in swirls and curls. She was actually writing shorthand backward, but to the Hearst editor, who didn't know shorthand or Egyptian, it looked genuine. He offered her the job, which came with a modest retainer against payment per article, plus all her expenses paid. There was one catch. She wouldn't be working out of the London bureau, but had to be based in Paris.

"Does this present a problem for you?" he asked.

Barely containing her glee at the idea of being paid to live in Paris, Nancy said evenly, "No, I think it should be all right."

She arrived in Paris clutching the book *French for Tourists*, from which she had gleaned some key words and phrases. From there, she learned the language by "trial and error," and her limited vocabulary steadily increased. A dogged reporter, she used her abundant resourcefulness to get to the right people for a good quote, and proved capable of shaping a coherent news story. Her byline

appeared in Hearst newspapers like the *San Francisco Examiner* and *Houston Chronicle*.

The 1930s was a heady time to be young, single and attractive in Paris, and Nancy did not go unnoticed in the circle of expatriate male reporters from papers like the *New York Times* and the *Washington Post* and French scribes from *Le Monde* and *Le Parisien*. A hazel-eyed brunette with a sparkling smile and big personality, she modeled her appearance after Parisian women. She was refined and elegant, but not prim and proper thanks to a rebellious nature and irreverent (even bawdy) Aussie sense of humor. She became a regular for long nights of drinking and storytelling with her colleagues at neighborhood brasseries favored by writers. Her ability to drink any man under the table became legendary.

In 1935, Hitler's Germany passed the antisemitic Nuremberg Laws, stripping Jews of their citizenship and prohibiting them from holding public office and working in civil service, education, the media and finance. Jewish refugees began arriving in Paris, and Nancy interviewed some of them. Hearing their stories of surging antisemitism, she couldn't understand how a government could do such things to its own people. One Austrian refugee reported that Nazi ideology was rapidly spreading and had reached Vienna, long considered one of Europe's cultural, artistic and intellectual magnets. Nancy and several colleagues decided to see for themselves. They took the train to Austria, where they found "strutting men of the *Sturmabteilung*"—brown-shirted storm troopers of the paramilitary wing of the Nazi Party—roaming the cobblestone streets of Vienna's old city center, assaulting Jewish merchants and trashing their storefronts. In the main square, they came upon a shocking scene: Jews tied to large wooden wheels being whipped as they were rolled before a jeering crowd blinded by an ideology of hate. Outraged, Nancy promised herself "then and there" if she ever had the opportunity, she would do everything in her power to "hurt the Nazis" and what they stood for.

It was several years before she got her first chance. By then, she was newly wed to Henri Fiocca, a wealthy steel industrialist. They lived in a luxury penthouse apartment atop a hill overlooking all of Marseille, a port city in southern France, with views from their windows and balcony of its boat-lined quay and the azure

waters of the Mediterranean. Before they met, Henri was a renowned playboy, and Nancy had no shortage of beaux. In each other, however, they had met their match and were very much in love. Of medium height and square-built, with smart brown eyes, Henri was fourteen years Nancy's senior. She found him utterly charming, and her life with him was adventurous and joyful. He happened to be one of the richest men in Marseille, although accumulating money and gaining social status had never been important to her. Yet—and it did surprise her a bit—as Madame Fiocca she lived the life of a pampered French wife and enjoyed what her husband's income afforded them: a household staff; monogrammed Sèvres china favored by French royalty; imported Persian rugs; vacations at Cannes and Saint-Tropez; dining at the finest restaurants; and ordering copious amounts of champagne and caviar.

For Nancy and Henri, the start of the world war that would alter their lives and determine their fates came in September 1939, when France declared war on Germany after it invaded Poland. Henri was called up to serve in the French army on the Maginot Line, a 280-mile stretch of concrete fortifications and obstacles on France's eastern border that was built to be an impenetrable defense against a German attack. Nancy didn't want to be stuck at home. She decided she could put her nursing training to good use and tend to the wounded. Before Henri left for the front, she implored him to have one of his company's panel trucks converted into an ambulance. She'd never gotten around to learning how to drive but taught herself over two days.

When a German *blitzkrieg* [lightning war] comprised of armored tanks and motorized infantry with artillery and air support rolled through Denmark, Norway, Luxembourg, the Netherlands and into Belgium in April 1940, Nancy headed north for the French-Belgian border with a volunteer ambulance unit from Marseille. As they began transporting wounded soldiers and civilians, Nancy's early nurse training proved helpful. Before leaving Marseille, she had purchased a supply of bandages and antiseptics at pharmacies. But some injuries were so grievous there was little she could do. Time and again, she headed south with the wounded, left them at aid stations, then turned around and went back, passing the mangled corpses of men, women and children indiscriminately machine-gunned by strafing German aircraft.

As British and French troops rushed into Belgium to meet the attack, German troops stormed into France through the dense forests of the Ardennes, bypassing sections of the Maginot Line. Nancy prayed that Henri would survive the onslaught. What she saw all around her did not inspire confidence that Hitler's war machine could be stopped. When the volunteers from Marseille realized it was time to head back or be overrun, they loaded their ambulances with refugees and drove them five hundred miles to safety in southern France. Too tired to go another seventy-five miles to Marseille, Nancy spent the night at a tiny hotel in Nîmes. She woke in the morning to the terrible news that Paris had fallen to the Germans.

Nancy, like everyone else, was "stunned, stunned.... We couldn't believe after everything we'd been told about how strong the Maginot Line was that it was over so quickly." Many tears—her own included—flowed that morning, and for days after. With the City of Light under the Nazi boot, not just Paris but all of France faced a bleak future.

Six days later an armistice established a swath of two-thirds of France—including Paris, Normandy, Brittany and its entire Atlantic coast—to be occupied by the Germans. A so-called Free Zone in the south, including Marseille, was to be governed from the capital of Vichy by Marshal Philippe Pétain, a popular commander of the French army in the last war who would soon be reviled as a traitor in the new one.¹

With the defeated French demobilizing, an unscathed Henri returned home in late June. His unit had been assigned to a sector of the Maginot Line that was not attacked, and he was fortunate not to be among some 2 million French soldiers taken as prisoners of war, many of whom were being deported to Germany as forced laborers.

Henri was as distressed as Nancy about the occupation.

"France will be liberated again, Nancy. We must help."

It was exactly what she had been thinking.

Thank God for Charles de Gaulle, they agreed. Rather than submit to the armistice and surrender, the general flew to England and formed Free France, claiming it to be the legitimate French government in exile. From London, he

started making broadcasts into France over the BBC, one of which, on June 22, 1940, greatly cheered Nancy and Henri.

“It is absurd to consider the fight as over,” de Gaulle told his fellow countrymen. “Yes, we have been heavily defeated. A bad military system, mistakes made in conducting the operations, the government’s spirit of abandon, have all made us lose the Battle of France. But we have allies with immense resources... and this war is not a war between France and Germany. It is a world war. Honor, common sense, and the superior interest of our nation command all the free French to continue fighting wherever they are and however they can.... Whatever happens, the flame of French resistance must not and shall not die.”

De Gaulle’s inspirational message was the opposite of one delivered in a national broadcast by Pétain after his meeting with Hitler in central France: “It is in a spirit of honor, and to maintain the unity of France, that I enter today upon the path of collaboration....” It was clear the Vichy government was to function as a mere puppet of the Nazis.

Nancy was appalled. She had no intention of collaborating with the Nazis. She had seen with her own eyes the essence of Nazi evil in Vienna, their “handiwork in the back of my ambulance” and on the bloodstained roads of northern France. All of it had hardened her hatred. They must be *defeated*, not *appeased*. Henri was just as passionate. They resolved to be ready to resist the Nazis whenever the opportunity arose. It soon did.

One evening at the home of friends, they were introduced to a French army commander who, once he ascertained they shared similar views, told them de Gaulle’s group had prevailed upon him and some other military men to remain in France to help organize partisans to strike when the time was right. That there was organized resistance to the German occupation was heartening news to Nancy and Henri. When the officer learned they were visiting Cannes the next weekend, he asked if they would take an envelope that someone would pick up at their hotel. He didn’t say what was inside it and they didn’t ask, even when he cautioned it would be dangerous if they were caught with it. They were quick to oblige, and made the delivery without difficulty. Before long, Nancy was asked to make another delivery, which she did on her own, as Henri was busy with

trying to salvage his business, which had declined during the hostilities. Soon, as a trusted courier for the resistance, she was delivering not just envelopes and packages but even parts of radio transmitters sewn into folds of her coat.

Throughout 1941 and into 1942, Nancy continued her courier work. She also became involved with the Marseille-based Pat O’Leary escape network that was later estimated to have helped more than six hundred Allied soldiers and airmen escape Nazi-occupied France. At first its main evasion route was centered on the Mediterranean coast at Marseille, but eventually it had three main routes—each with a network of safe houses—stretching from northern France through Paris into the eastern foothills of the Pyrenees, where Spanish guides took Frenchmen and Jews fleeing from Nazi oppressors and downed British and American flyers over rugged trails into neutral Spain, then on to Gibraltar, a British territory from which they could get transportation to England and elsewhere. Nancy’s role typically started with meeting people at a safe house in Nice or Cannes and accompanying them on the train to Marseille. Before leaving on the next leg of their journey to freedom, they spent the night at Henri’s factory outside of town, or when the wait was longer at an apartment rented by Nancy and Henri for that purpose.

In November 1942, the Germans took control of the southern portion of France, and overnight the “Free Zone” became the “South Zone.” The *Geheime Staatspolizei* [Gestapo]—the official state police of Nazi Germany—showed up in force in Marseille, making resistance work more dangerous. Another new threat locally was the Milice, the militia created by the pro-Nazi Pétain government, whom Nancy considered every bit as vicious and evil as the Gestapo.

Nancy carried an identity card that was factual in every way except her place of birth, which was listed as Nice. She passed as French because after her years of residency she spoke the language like a native, with no trace of an Australian or British accent. She had taken many dangerous journeys over the past two years and had been able to talk her way out of every situation. She had answered countless questions and stuck to her cover stories at checkpoints, roadblocks and train stations. But her increased activities for the resistance made it more difficult to pass herself off as Madame Fiocca, interested in only the finer things in life. In

fact, by this time she had heard that the Germans and Milice had given the code name *la souris blanche* [the white mouse] to an unidentified partisan woman for her uncanny ability to disappear just when they thought they had her cornered, and they had posted a large reward for her capture. Nancy fit the description perfectly and knew they were looking for her.

In spring 1943, a series of events convinced Nancy that the Nazis at last were closing in on her. She first noticed whenever she picked up the phone that there were strange clicking sounds, as if the line was tapped. Then her neighbor reported that a stranger had been rifling through the Fioccas' mailbox in the lobby. When the proprietor of a café—a friend and partisan—told Nancy she had been followed by a suspicious man that morning after she stopped for an espresso, she rushed home and awaited Henri's return from work.

She had been pushing her luck for more than two years. Marseille was now crawling with German agents, armed Milice and enemy collaborators. Recently, the Gestapo had made a flurry of arrests of people working in the Pat O'Leary line, including its current leader, Albert-Marie Guérisset, a Belgian army officer. Nancy suspected a traitor had led them to Guérisset. Maybe to her as well? She knew it was possible they hadn't picked her up yet because they were hoping she'd lead them to other resistance members.

When Henri came home and heard the latest, he was adamant the only thing for her to do was to leave France. He promised to follow once he sorted things out. Nancy wanted him to come with her now, but he said that was out of the question. If they left together, it would look very suspicious and they'd likely be stopped. Also, he had to find a way to keep the business running in his absence. He had to think of his elderly father in Marseille, whom Henri supported, as well as his employees.

"Just you follow me to England as soon as possible," she said.

They moved swiftly. Spending another night at home—or delaying even an hour—might mean the difference between making a clean getaway or seeing the inside of a Gestapo cell. She knew a safe house in Toulouse where she could spend the night; then she'd try to follow one of the escape routes out of France she had directed many others to take.

It took her all of thirty minutes to change clothes and fill a small bag with essentials, but nothing more in case she was stopped.

Henri gave her a wad of francs, which she stuffed into her bra.

Then it was time to say goodbye. For the benefit of their next-door neighbor, who was a commissioner in the Vichy government, and anyone else who might be listening, they acted as if she were going out for the day. As always, there was a quick parting kiss, and she strode out the door as she said breezily, "*À tout à l'heure!*" [See you later!]

Once around the corner, she cried all the way to the train station.

It took Nancy months and seven attempts before she made it over the Pyrenees into Spain with a group of ten evaders that included an American pilot, a Canadian and several Frenchmen. The weather had been shockingly bad in the mountains and surrounding countryside, forcing them back time and again. She nearly froze in a blinding blizzard, jumped from a moving train as bullets whizzed by, hid under a pile of coal in the back of a truck, talked her way out of a Vichy jail by posing as a runaway wife keeping a rendezvous with her lover, sprinted to the top of a mountain to avoid border guards, walked for five nights straight, and went one eight-day stretch without eating. When she reached Gibraltar, she boarded a ship that was part of a convoy headed to Glasgow, Scotland. From there, she took the train to London, arriving in June 1943.

The grand city she had known no longer existed. German bombs had reduced entire blocks to piles of rubble. Many buildings still standing were structurally unsafe and were boarded up and abandoned. Londoners said the bombing had lessened since the Blitz of 1940 and 1941, but there were still nights when the sirens wailed, sending people scurrying into underground shelters. Yet the indomitable spirit of the English remained intact, and Nancy saw nary a hint of defeatism.

She found a small flat to rent in Mayfair, close to Grosvenor Square, and furnished it as best she could. She bought pajamas, slippers and a dressing gown for Henri, anticipating he'd arrive with no belongings. She also picked up a bottle of champagne for them to celebrate his arrival. As she waited for him, Nancy looked up old friends and new ones as well—people she'd helped through

the escape line. They invited her to restaurants and clubs and to their homes to meet their families.

Months dragged on, and still there was no sign of Henri or any word. That fall she awoke from a terrible nightmare convinced he was dead. For several days she was haunted by the dream. Slowly, she convinced herself it was senseless to allow a bad dream to unnerve her so. But it was difficult to shake. Leaving Henri behind had been such a bitter blow, and she knew any number of things might have happened after she left Marseille. If the O'Leary line had been further compromised and was no longer active, he might not find a way out.

The streets of London were filled with men and women in uniform, from young American soldiers to older, white-haired British veterans of the First World War serving as block wardens enforcing the nightly blackouts. Everyone seemed to be doing *something* in the war, and she wanted back in the fight. She made an appointment to speak to a colonel at the headquarters of de Gaulle's Free France, which had its own intelligence service, the Bureau Central de Renseignements et d'Action (BCRA). She told him of her work with the resistance and that she was eager to go back and do more. For her safety as well as Henri's, she understood her return to Marseille would have to wait until after the war. But she believed she could be useful elsewhere in France because she spoke the language fluently, knew her way around and was deeply loyal to her adopted land. To her surprise, her offer was declined by Free France, most likely because she was a British subject.

A friend with a contact in the SOE's French Section suggested Nancy speak to them. It turned out the British sleuths already knew of her work with the O'Leary line, and after a few more interviews she was offered a role in their organization. She would be trained in sabotage and guerrilla tactics and parachute back into France. Her mission: to organize, arm and train resistance forces for the day when the Allies would launch the long-awaited invasion to liberate France and the rest of Europe.

Nancy Wake was about to go back to war, and she was elated.

Violette Szabo had but one thought when she volunteered to parachute into Nazi-occupied France to help the resistance. Revenge.

Born Violette Bushell at the British military hospital in Paris in 1921 to an English father and a French mother, she attended a Catholic school in Abbeville, France, prior to her family of seven—she had four brothers—settling in a working-class part of South London in 1932. It was the Depression, and her father, Charles, a veteran of the First World War and an army boxing champion, struggled to make ends meet as a lorry driver. Her accomplished mother, Reine, who had been a dressmaker in Paris, helped support them with her sewing and clothesmaking.

Spirited and strong-willed, Violette grew into a slim, dark-eyed beauty. She hated needlework or domestic chores of any kind but was always ready for excitement and adventure and could best her brothers in swimming, skating and cycling. After her father taught her to shoot an air rifle, she was banned from the shooting gallery at the fair because she won too many prizes. Never hesitant to intervene when bullies picked on one of her friends, she often sent bigger boys packing with black eyes and bruised egos. When the classroom no longer held her interest, she dropped out of school at sixteen and went to work in the Brixton Market.

When Paris fell in May 1940, Violette's mother, like many French expatriates, lamented the new reality of their country under Nazi authority and the shocking photographs of swastika flags hanging from the Eiffel Tower. When she heard that de Gaulle's Free French were to march in London's Bastille Day parade on July 14, she told Violette, "Go invite one of those exiles to dinner. At our table, he'll be in a little bit of France."

Violette, who was working as a perfume seller at the Bon Marché department store, returned from the parade with a dashing French Foreign Legion lieutenant named Etienne Szabo. Handsome in his almond-green uniform with a short-sleeve shirt and green-and-red epaulettes, a kepi with its flat circular top and chin strap, a blue sash and belt, and black combat boots, he looked like a character right out of *Beau Geste*. His jacket was decorated with insignias and full-size medals, including the highest French military decoration, the Légion d'Honneur; the Médaille Militaire for bravery in action; and the Cross of

Lorraine, the double-cross symbol of Free France. His 13th Demi-Brigade of the Foreign Legion had fought with the British in Norway, then rushed to Brittany to reinforce the French army. After France surrendered, they were evacuated to England and joined de Gaulle's forces in London.

Etienne was warm and engaging, and he charmed everyone in the family. He told them how his Hungarian parents moved to Marseille because his pregnant mother was determined to give birth on French soil. His father became a *gendarme* [police officer], but he died when Etienne was only four years old. It didn't take Reine long to pick up on what was happening at their dinner table. "Love at first sight on both sides!" she told a friend.

Violette, nineteen, and Etienne, thirty, were wed five weeks later. After a few days at a local Aldershot hotel, their brief honeymoon was over. The following week Etienne left for the war: his Legion brigade attached to a de Gaulle-led Free French force headed to West Africa.

Eager to do her part in the war that Etienne was fighting, Violette enlisted in the Auxiliary Territorial Service (ATS), the women's branch of the British army. She joined a heavy antiaircraft artillery battery comprised of male and female soldiers operating a Vickers 3.7-inch 94mm AA weapon that fired twenty-five-pound shells thousands of feet into the sky. Hundreds of these gun batteries were formed, with women making up two-thirds of the crews that aimed and fired the booming guns that filled the skies with bursts of deadly flak to bring down Luftwaffe planes bombing London in harrowing nighttime air raids.

When Etienne returned to England at the end of August 1941, he had been gone a year. Violette's mother saw it was "like a second honeymoon for them... so madly in love, they were overjoyed, but they also felt let down because they knew they had only one week."

Then Etienne was again off to war. Violette was soon able to write him with the exciting news that she was pregnant. She continued her service with the ATS as long as possible, then received a release from the army and returned to her parents' home to await the birth of the baby. She delivered Tania, a healthy baby girl, on June 8, 1942.



Violette Szabo with her husband, Etienne, on their wedding day, August 21, 1940.

VIOLETTE SZABO GC MUSEUM

Unbeknownst to Violette, at that very moment Etienne's unit was under siege by German field marshal Erwin Rommel's Afrika Korps in the Libyan desert, where his brigade of 1,000 Legionnaires was posted with 2,700 Free French soldiers at Bir Hakeim at the southern end of the British Eighth Army's line at Gazala. In an attempt to turn the British flank, Rommel ordered infantry and armored divisions to attack Bir Hakeim on May 26. He told his staff it should take "only fifteen minutes to crush them." But the French had prepared their defenses, laying extensive minefields and burrowing hundreds of dugouts to shelter men, guns and vehicles when they were under bombardment, then emerge to pound German lines with their own artillery and launch raiding parties into the desert to seize fuel, water, supplies and vehicles. Outnumbered ten to one and entirely encircled, the French turned down offers from Rommel to surrender and held out for two weeks. When their water and ammunition were virtually exhausted, they carried out a brilliant breakout on the night of June 10, reaching British lines the next morning in a collection of lorries, sedans, ambulances and other vehicles, some captured from the Germans. By all accounts, the heroes of the siege were the Legionnaires, who stayed as a rear guard as long as possible. When the first Germans reached Bir Hakeim, they were shocked to find it empty. The siege at Bir Hakeim made headlines as a heroic stand by a small French force against the vaunted Afrika Korps, buoying the morale of Allied troops worldwide.

Etienne survived Bir Hakeim and learned of the birth of their daughter only when a stack of Violette's letters finally reached him. He wrote back how "crazy with joy" he was at becoming a father.

With her mother taking care of Tania, Violette took a job that fall in a factory manufacturing aircraft parts. When Etienne's letters stopped, she wasn't overly concerned at first because there was lots in the news about the British campaign in North Africa and she knew the Legionnaires must be involved. But as more time passed and she still received no letters, she contacted the Free French and the Red Cross. No one was able to provide her with any information about Etienne. The letter from the War Department finally arrived in early 1943, informing her that Etienne had been killed on October 24, 1942, fighting against the Afrika Korps at El Alamein. He was buried where he fell in the arid Egyptian desert because, as was later explained to her, Legionnaires "travel light and die light."

With no words to describe her pain, an inconsolable Violette was unable to work and remained shut away at home. Only slowly did she let herself be convinced there was a world to reenter. She returned to work, began to see some old friends—a few from her army days—and meet new ones. But even as she coped with her loss, she was restless and unsettled. She quit her job at the factory soon after being promoted to section leader because, she told her parents, "I want to do more in this war." She wanted to fight with a gun in her hand, she said, and complained that the army didn't allow women into combat. Her parents agreed she was still struggling. Her mother thought she'd settle down eventually, but her father wasn't so sure. He saw the girl who had always been ready to take on a bully now spoiling for another kind of fight.

A week or two later, Violette received a mysterious letter asking her to appear for an interview at an address not far from Westminster Abbey. It was signed by an Ebenezer Potter. Violette arrived on the appointed day and entered the spacious front hall of a nine-story stone structure that housed the Ministry of Pensions. Violette surmised that must be what the summons was about, as she had been drawing a small pension from the Free French since Etienne's death. After filling out a card with her name and address, she was taken to the fifth floor and Room 531, which was grand in size but starkly furnished, with only a plain table and two chairs. The walls were bare except for a poster about "Air Raid Precautions." The windows were boarded up, and a naked light bulb in the middle of the high ceiling provided the only illumination. Seated behind the

desk was a man in his forties in a tweed jacket. He stood up to greet her and gestured to the other chair for her to have a seat.

“Mr. Potter?” she asked.

He nodded, although that was not his name.

His real name was Selwyn Jepson, and before the war he was a successful writer of mystery stories. In fact, the name Ebenezer Potter was one of his fictional characters. The false name and nondescript room in the Ministry of Pensions were a cover. Jepson was employed by the SOE as the chief recruiting officer for the French Section, and his job was to find individuals who would make good undercover agents. He had scouts in the government and military on the lookout for the right kind of people, men and women. Violette’s name had come across his desk from a contact in the women’s branch of the army. He was especially interested in recruiting women because he believed they were “sensible” and often “very much better than men for the work,” with a “greater capacity for cool and lonely courage than men... [whose] lives tend to be always in the company of other men.” On a practical level, once they landed in France, women were less likely to attract suspicion traveling by bicycle—a vital form of transportation for courier work—with shopping at the market, visiting friends and other day-to-day activities serving as their cover.

Violette asked if she was here because of her widow’s pension.

This surprised Jepson because her ATS enlistment records showed her as single. But no, he said, that was not why she was asked here today.

“Were you married long?” he asked.

“Two years, but we were together for only a very few weeks. He was killed at El Alamein.”

“I’m sorry. How very sad.”

He switched to French and asked about her life before the war. Violette answered in French at some length. The more he heard, the more he felt this young woman would be excellent for the job he had in mind.

She finally asked why she had been summoned here.

“Your knowledge of France and fluency in French might be useful.”

“In what way?”

“Il relève de la rubrique travail dangereux.” [It comes under the heading of dangerous work.]

“Tu veux dire espionner?” [You mean spying?]

“Non, mais à certains égards, les conditions sont similaires.” [No, but in some ways the conditions are similar.]

Her French was perfect. Many people thought they were fluent in French because they took it at university, but school French was definitely inadequate for the SOE's purposes. Jepson had even rejected the son of a French tutor because he spoke French with an English accent. That would likely have earned him a Nazi bullet in the head in France. What the SOE needed were people who spoke French like the French.

He told Violette the work he had in mind called for special training, and would involve parachuting into enemy-occupied territory to conduct special operations.

“En France?”

“Oui, en France.” They were trying to make things as unpleasant and difficult for the Germans as they could, he explained. “Such as sabotage—from blowing up their troop trains to immobilizing their factories. And they don't like it. They react violently and brutally.”

“That would suit me very well,” she said without hesitation.

Such immediate and unqualified acceptance of the risks concerned him, but Jepson detected nothing casual or irresponsible about her.

“Why would it suit you?” he asked.

“If the work you give me is worthwhile in the way my husband's was as a soldier, and if it ends for me as it ended for him, that's all right.”

It saddened Jepson to hear the young woman openly contemplate her own violent death, but she had clarity and motivation. He always made sure anyone he interviewed had a full understanding of the risks they would be taking. Some women—and men, too—quailed at the thought of a nasty death at the hands of the Nazis, perhaps preceded by torture, if they were caught. But not this one. He thought the plucky brunette would make a good field agent if all went well in her training.

Was anybody dependent on her? he wanted to know.

She paused, then answered with a non sequitur.

“Both my parents are alive,” she said.

Violette had her reasons for not mentioning she had a one-year-old child at home. If something happened to her, she knew her parents would raise Tania. In truth, her resolve to do something in the war to avenge Etienne outweighed all else, even motherhood, which she feared could be considered disqualifying for missions behind enemy lines.

“Well, I’d like you to think this over very seriously, and let me know in about a week whether it’s the sort of thing you want to undertake.”

“Don’t need to think on it,” Violette Szabo said. “It’s what I want.”

¹ From 1940 to 1944, the Vichy regime collaborated with the Nazis and deported over 70,000 French and foreign-born Jews to death camps, sent French workers to Germany and tried to crush the resistance.

SIX

HARRINGTON'S WAR

After operating from several RAF bases their first few months, the Carpetbaggers moved to their own permanent home in late March 1944: the newly-built “Class A” Harrington Airfield, designed for use by heavy bombers. During its construction, U.S. Army engineers poured 860,000 square yards of concrete, hauled in 2 million bricks, moved 210,000 cubic yards of soil, and laid six miles of roads. The longest of three runways was 5,000 feet. A boxlike control tower with a 360-degree view sat atop a two-story concrete blockhouse. There were hangars for maintenance and storage, and paved hardstands for parked aircraft. Low-slung masonry buildings were used for administration, operations, a hospital, a large kitchen and spacious mess hall, latrine and shower facilities, a movie theater and two social clubs, one for officers and another for enlisted men. Ready for occupancy were rows of Quonset huts—prefabricated plates of corrugated steel bolted together in the shape of a half circle over a concrete slab and heated by small coal stoves with flue pipes extending up through the roofs.

Situated eighty miles northwest of London, Harrington was located in the agricultural heart of East Midlands. Adjacent to the base was a six-hundred-acre farm. From the air, the entire surrounding countryside was a checkerboard of croplands, farms and fields dotted with grazing livestock. A mile and a half down a winding country lane from the airfield that bore its name was the quaint village of Harrington, with its thatched-roof dwellings, a general store and a popular pub, the Tollemache Arms, where locals had quenched their thirst for three centuries. On a grassy incline overlooking the village was the fourteenth-century Anglican church of St. Peter & St. Paul, and next to it a cemetery with tall, weathered headstones.

The rural location of the new airfield proved ideal for covert operations. At its entrance, white-helmeted MPs guarded what looked like an iron cattle gate with a sign that read: "Closed to the Public." Personnel assigned to the field were made to understand that if they talked about what was going on there, they would be summarily court-martialed.

Still smarting from a recent incident that occurred when the Carpetbaggers were flying from another base, Bob Fish was enthused about having a field exclusively for their own use. One day at Cheddington Airfield—home of the Eighth Air Force Combined Command—Fish had picked up the phone to find an angry Brig. Gen. Edmund Hill demanding that he "teach your men military courtesy." It seemed the general had been riding in his staff car along a line of parked all-black B-24s when they passed an enlisted man who failed to salute. The slighted general had found out the offender's name and rank, and he demanded that Fish demote the master sergeant as punishment until he "learned to act like a soldier." Because Hill was the general in charge of the command responsible for combat training of all the bomber aircrews arriving from the United States, Fish had no choice but to comply. But looking further into what happened that day, Fish found out that the sergeant—a senior line chief responsible for maintenance on their aircraft—was eight feet up on a gantry assisting in the changing of an aircraft engine when the general drove by in the rear seat of his black sedan flying a single-star flag. Intent on his task, the sergeant kept working. It seemed the general wanted everyone to stop working and snap to attention and salute him, regardless of what important tasks might be going on. Fish considered the summary demotion "justice miscarried." He long believed the mechanics and others in the ground crews who toiled outside in the worst conditions keeping their planes operational to be the unsung heroes of the Carpetbaggers. (One B-24 limped home with hundreds of jagged holes in its fuselage from antiaircraft fire and was patched up by metalsmiths and back in the air in two days.) While the general could order the demotion, the Carpetbaggers—now designated the 801st Bomb Group—were authorized to make their own promotions. A month later, the general called back. "That sergeant has probably learned his lesson," he said. "I'd have no objection if you restored him to his former rank." Fish thanked the general for his call and did

not bother to mention that the master sergeant's rank had already been restored weeks earlier.



Administration building at Harrington.

U.S. ARMY SIGNAL CORPS

Fish, now a lieutenant colonel, and Cliff Heflin, recently promoted to colonel—at twenty-nine, one of the youngest colonels in the Army Air Forces—worked out an operational schedule for their two squadrons and established secure communications with OSS London. Along with the autonomy of having their own airfield would come added responsibilities. Whereas before they had been able to leave the day-to-day running of a base to others, Heflin and Fish now had to oversee the various units necessary to operate the base. These included military police, ordnancemen, radar and control tower operators, special services, chemical corps and other personnel. Help arrived when the thousand-man 328th Service Group showed up and started putting in place the necessary services in advance of the move to Harrington in late March.

On moving day to the new base, nothing went right for 2nd Lt. Edwin Canner's crew in "The Leading Lady," about to become the first and only B-24 Liberator to fly into but never out of Harrington Airfield. After loading all their personal belongings into the plane, Canner got three engines going, but it took several attempts and about thirty minutes before the fourth one turned over. Then, not long into the short thirty-minute flight at about 1,000-foot altitude, the troublesome engine failed. Normally, that would not have been a problem, as

a B-24 could maintain altitude and even climb on three engines. But something else went wrong, because even as Canner and his copilot kept their right rudder pedals fully depressed to overcome the asymmetric thrust and drag due to the lost engine, they could not hold altitude. Canner was relieved when he saw on the horizon the main north–south runway at Harrington, but by then they were only a couple hundred feet off the ground. He delayed lowering the landing gear because it would add drag and cost them altitude, which might mean crashing short of the airfield. Then he had a new problem: they couldn't turn the plane. Lining up for a final approach to the runway was not possible. They were headed for the grassy infield between runways, and that would have to do. Canner notified the Harrington tower, then keyed his mic and told the crew to buckle themselves in for a rough landing. He ordered the navigator, Gerben “Dutch” Coehoorn, to come up out of the nose. Coehoorn answered that he was shutting down his equipment.



Top Carpetbagger commanders: Robert Fish (left) and Clifford Heflin.

U.S. ARMY SIGNAL CORPS

In the cockpit, Canner waited until the last moment to drop the landing gear. But he cut it too close when he finally did, and they hit the ground a few seconds before one wheel locked into place. It just folded up, and the plane tore into the infield turf nose-first, instantly killing the navigator, who had waited too long to leave the nose compartment. A wing snapped off and burst into flames, then the plane rolled over and over, breaking up as it did. When it stopped, the cockpit section—only about twelve feet long, but crammed with five people inside—was upside down. Canner released his lap belt and fell on his head. When everyone was out, he hurried to the broken-off aft portion, where two men were trapped inside. It was very close to the fire, and when he got to it, the .50-cal. rounds for the machine guns started to explode. The emergency crews

arrived in time to pull the two injured men from the tail section. Canner was stretchered to the hospital, fitted with a plaster cast for a broken back, and was soon on his way to an Army hospital stateside. Only two of his crew escaped serious injuries that day, and eventually they were added to other Carpetbagger crews.

Containers quickly began arriving at Harrington in convoys from a new supply depot that blended into the English countryside and was well hidden from the air. The joint U.S. and British packaging and storage facility for the Carpetbaggers' mission to arm and equip partisan forces was located near the village of Holme, about forty miles away. After a container was packed there, it was stenciled with a serial number to ensure it was delivered to the correct resistance circuit that had radioed its "shopping list" to Special Force Headquarters (SFHQ) in London, a new unified command between the British SOE and American OSS. The containers were loaded onto trucks and driven to Harrington, where some went into storage, but most were wheeled to the hardstands. There, they were loaded into planes assigned to fly that night. Armorers snapped parachute packs onto the containers and used hydraulic lifts to raise them into the modified racks of the dual bomb bays, six to each side.



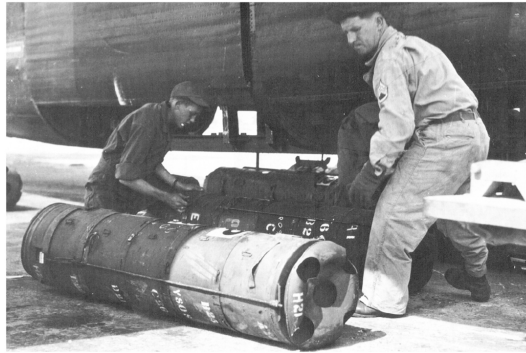
Field of containers.

U.S. ARMY SIGNAL CORPS



Loading filled containers onto lorries.

U.S. ARMY SIGNAL CORPS



Loading containers into aircraft.

U.S. ARMY SIGNAL CORPS

Even with the distraction of the impending move to the new base, the Carpetbaggers delivered to the resistance in March some 140,000 pounds of matériel—twice as much as in February—and dropped six agents (all “Joes”) behind the lines. Kicking off a new month at their new field, the inaugural missions from Harrington were scheduled for the night of April 5, 1944. The first of seventeen B-24s took off at 8:23 p.m., and thereafter one took off every few minutes.

One of the last planes to depart was flown by 2nd Lt. William W. Nicoll’s crew on their first mission together. They went wheels up at 10:01 p.m., bound for STATIONER, an SOE circuit operating around Châteauroux, approximately 120 miles south of Paris. The circuit was headed by one of the French Section’s best agents, Maurice Southgate, an RAF officer recruited by the SOE because he was born in France (to British parents) and attended college in Paris. Southgate had parachuted into France four months earlier and now commanded some 2,500 partisans—many of them from the Francs-Tireurs et Partisans (FTP)—who were conducting widespread sabotage. That month,

Southgate's fighters had used two pounds of plastic explosives to bring to a standstill a Dunlop tire factory at Montluçon that had gone back into production making tires for German trucks and planes after Allied bombs damaged it seven months earlier. Making more drops to STATIONER was vital to the resistance effort in central France.¹

After crossing the Channel at 500 feet to sneak under the screens of enemy radar stations on the French coast, Nicoll brought their B-24 up to 1,200 feet and proceeded inland. As they overflowed the Calvados region, they were about 160 miles from their drop zone—a little less than an hour's flight time. Only two nights shy of a full moon, the ground was brightly illuminated, revealing a mix of woodland and pasture common in Normandy.

The bombardier, 2nd Lt. Thomas F. Davis, watching the ground from the nose section, bellowed over the interphone: "Hard right!"

But there was no time for the pilot to evade the antiaircraft battery they were flying over before the first blast of flak blew off the plane's tail section, taking the tail gunner, S/Sgt. Ralph L. Kittrell, with it and sending the aircraft into a sudden dive. Seconds later, more flak hits shattered the nose section and peppered the fuselage.

Again came the bombardier's voice, weaker now. "*Get out—*"

The bomb bay doors he controlled opened for the crew to bail out.

The aircraft was in flames. The pilot sounded the bailout alarm that clanged ominously through the cabin. Next to him, the copilot, 2nd Lt. Adolphe "Duffy" Kalbfleisch, flipped on the autopilot, hoping it would buy him and the pilot a few extra seconds to get out of the cockpit.

The first to jump was dispatcher Sgt. Joseph E. Porter. From his position mid-cabin, he leapt through the open bomb bay. As he floated down under the silk canopy he heard bullets whizzing past. Given how perfectly silhouetted he was against the moonlit sky, the fact that he wasn't hit could be attributed only to the errant aim of those shooting up at him. Upon landing, he unbuckled his chute and life vest. With rifle shots ringing out all around, he took off running without looking back.

After he left the cockpit, Kalbfleisch dove into the radio compartment, where there was no sign of the radio operator. He found his way through heavy smoke

to the narrow catwalk above the open bomb bays. Nicoll was behind him, trying to buckle his chest-pack chute. Kalbfleisch, who was already wearing his chute, ducked under the catwalk. Just then the aircraft tipped violently to one side, sending him careening through the bomb bay. Quickly pulling the rip cord because he knew they were very low, he didn't swing even once under the canopy before slamming into the ground next to a creek. Dazed, he was trying to get to his feet when the plane impacted with the ground no more than one hundred feet away. A wave of supercharged heat singed his hair and eyebrows and burned the fur collar of his bomber jacket. Standing on wobbly legs, Kalbfleisch spotted a short distance away a communications station ringed by antiaircraft artillery batteries. Had this complex been on their map, they would have plotted another course. Faulty intelligence or bad luck had brought them directly over the guns that blew them out of the sky.

Kalbfleisch and Porter were reunited at a French doctor's house a week later. They had both been fortunate to make first contact with farmers who passed them off to partisans and not to the Germans, or French Milice, or collaborators eager to collect the rewards offered for Allied flyers. Only then did they learn the fate of the rest of their crew.

Five bodies were found in the wreckage of their plane, the doctor told them. A sixth body was found one hundred yards away, his canopy snagged in a tall tree. He was badly burned and had chest injuries. Witnesses saw the Germans cut him down, but an officer did not permit anyone to render him aid or even give him water. Instead, the German tried to interrogate the injured man. When this was unsuccessful, the officer took out his pistol and shot the American flyer in the head. After the Germans left, the French carried out a solemn burial service, and a priest said a blessing over a common grave, risking his life to do so.^{II}

In the three months since he guided his crew on the long flight across the South Atlantic in December 1943, Gene Polinsky, the New York stage actor who became a navigator after washing out of pilot training, had learned what he called the "modus operandi" of the Carpetbaggers. They simply didn't talk

about the planes that went down or the missing men. Their fellow flyers weren't forgotten, but they weren't talked about either. Friends were made and lost in war, and a short memory was called for. Best to get back in the air and concentrate on finishing the job they were here to do.

Whether in practice or in combat, flying in a bomber was inherently dangerous for any number of reasons, as Gene was reminded in March 1944 on his second of two orientation flights. Along as an observer with an experienced Carpetbagger crew, he stood on the flight deck, just behind the two pilots. Gene's own pilot, Neil Ellis—the unflappable grocer from North Carolina—was in the copilot's seat. As they approached the drop zone and tried to lower the bomb bay doors, there was a sudden banging. The dispatcher came on the interphone to report that one of the doors was broken and slamming against the fuselage. So much for slipping in and out undetected, Gene thought. What sounded to him like “the biggest noise in the world” was enough to alert every enemy patrol for miles. The pilot asked Gene to go back and see if he could do something. From the catwalk above the bomb bay, he saw that the roll-up door on one side had come off its track. Hoping a few well-placed kicks might free the door, he dropped down from the catwalk and kicked at it several times before it came loose and dropped off into the night sky. At that instant, Gene, who was not wearing a parachute, lost his balance and was on his way out the bomb bay, too, when a strong tug on his belt held him back. He was quickly bear-hugged from behind by a stout sergeant called “Moose” who brought him back from the edge of the precipice. A close call, for sure, but Gene could later laugh about the absurdity of it. In all his training, he told his buddies, he'd never once been warned a navigator had to be careful not to fall out of the bomb bay.

The first mission for Gene's crew was scheduled for the night of April 10—the third night of Carpetbagger operations from Harrington. With the moon at 95 percent illumination, twenty-two B-24s were loaded with some 83,000 pounds of munitions and supplies for nineteen drops in France and three to resistance fighters in Belgium.

At their intelligence briefing that morning, the pilots, navigators and bombardiers of the crews flying that night were directed to take the Selsey Bill/Cabourg route. After takeoff, they were to fly to the familiar headland on

the south coast of England, then across the Channel toward Cabourg—a village on the Normandy coast—a route that kept them south of Le Havre, a major German naval base. From there, the crew of each B-24 was to set their own course for their assigned mission.

Upon receiving the coordinates of their drop zone in southeast France, Gene huddled with Neil Ellis and their bombardier to go over charts showing the latest-known locations of anti-aircraft batteries, radar installations, and enemy airdromes, all to be avoided. Their course to the NEWSAGENT circuit near Saint-Étienne was not a straight line but rather a series of course corrections at various checkpoints. They studied topographical maps for fixed points of reference, such as rivers, lakes, mountains, and railroad tracks, which should be visible from the air.

As usual, the takeoff times that night were staggered, with the first plane leaving shortly after 8:30 p.m. The Ellis aircraft was one of the last to take off an hour later for what would prove to be a long night.

Once airborne, Gene and the bombardier, seated back-to-back in the cramped nose section, worked as a team. Gene faced toward the rear of the plane behind a blackout curtain, seated on a retractable stool at a tiny desk with a small light. From his own dark space, he couldn't see out of the plane other than through a small transparent dome above him to shoot the stars for celestial navigation. He unrolled the maps that he had placed in a specific order after their briefing session. The first one had a long red line that ran southeast to Selsey Bill, then into the North Sea. The next one showed their route over the water, with the red line ending on the edge of the map at Cabourg. Other maps had the route to their target marked in red. From his leather navigator's case, which never left his side, Gene took out his compass, slide rule and other vital tools of the trade. Only a partial bulkhead separated the nose compartment from the flight deck, where the pilots sat, and at eye level Gene could see the feet of the pilots. Behind him, the bombardier faced toward the front of the plane, squatting behind the glazed nose bubble so he could watch for and call out their visual checkpoints.



Ellis Crew. Standing, left to right: Neil G. Ellis, pilot; Glen L. Stanislaus, copilot; Eugene Polinsky, navigator; Herbert Goff, bombardier. In front, left to right: Ray L. Green, engineer; Raymond A. Orwasky, radio operator; Pedro Pereda, tail gunner; and Cecil M. Waters, dispatcher.

U.S. ARMY SIGNAL CORPS

Things started to go wrong not long after they entered French airspace. They began missing visual checkpoints, which the bombardier either didn't see or failed to recognize. Identifying fixed points of reference on the ground was a primary responsibility of a Carpetbagger bombardier because he had the best view in front of them. Gene worked out their position on his Gee Box homing device to obtain a fix of their position, but with the missed checkpoints they ended up "meandering and zig-zagging" around too long before arriving at the NEWSAGENT drop zone. There were no signal lights below, just a blanket of darkness. They circled for half an hour for any sign that partisans might still be in the area, with any crewmen who had a view below keeping their eyes peeled. An unidentified aircraft suddenly appeared above them at ten o'clock high. They knew no other Carpetbagger plane was supposed to be in the area, but no one could tell if it was a German night fighter. Ellis didn't wait around to find out. He dove for the deck, pulling out of the dive at nearly treetop level, then poured on the power for home.

They landed back at Harrington an hour after sunrise.

The Ellis crew was surprised to find themselves scheduled to fly again that night. After a few hours' sleep, they started the mission cycle anew. Taking off shortly after 10 p.m., they headed for southern France to supply an SOE circuit disrupting German troop and freight trains running from Marseille to Lyons and Toulouse. The flight was a repeat of the night before. Running late again at

their primary drop zone, Ellis turned to an alternate, PIMENTO 50, not far away, but they saw no signal lights there either. Missing all those checkpoints was too much for Gene.

“Dammit, do your job!” he barked at the bombardier.

After dropping six bundles of propaganda leaflets over villages in the Aveyron region, they headed for home, crossing Selsey Bill at 8 a.m. With Harrington fogged in, they diverted to RAF Shipdham, landing at 9:30 a.m. after twelve long hours in the air. “Missed checkpoints on the way,” Ellis wrote in the mission report, even though “visibility was very good.”

The crew was dismayed at being “skunked” two nights in a row, and on their first missions at that. They felt they were better than this, and wanted to prove it. When a plane returned with containers still in its double bomb bays—logged as an “incomplete” mission—they had to be unloaded and the vital matériel needed by partisans went into storage.

Gene and Ellis spoke about what did and did not happen the last two nights. They agreed that finding a drop zone hidden by woods or obscured in a valley—as most had to be to keep enemy patrols and collaborators from stumbling upon them—meant placing a lot of reliance on map reading and dead reckoning. Gene handled the maps, but identifying the visual references needed for a dead reckoning fell to the bombardier, who in their crew was a weak link. “Neil, we’ve got to get somebody who can do the job,” implored Gene.

No missions were flown the next ten nights, as the moon entered a dark period. When they resumed, the Ellis crew had a new bombardier.

During the hiatus, Carpetbagger crews were given short leaves of three to five days. Some visited neighboring towns and cities. Kettering, a market and industrial town eight miles away that had seen an influx of U.S. servicemen from nearby bases, had a lot more pubs than Harrington. Northampton, population 100,000, was fifteen miles to the south. The largest city in the East Midlands, Nottingham—the legendary home of Robin Hood—was sixty miles to the north. London was a three-hour train ride through enchanting English

countryside. Fourteen crews left Harrington on April 16, and when they returned, fifteen more crews left on leave.

Those who went to London found the capital battered but resilient after more than four years of war. The streets were filled with people in uniform from bases all over the island nation. Not just Americans and British, but French, Dutch, Polish, Czech. After stepping off the train at Waterloo Station, the Carpetbagger crews that had come this far together split up, with the officers usually heading off to the USO for cocktails—there were always hotshot pilots at the bar swapping flying stories—and a haircut and shave before dinner at the nicest place they could get into, and maybe a movie in a smoke-filled cinema or a live stage production, which Gene Polinsky favored. At the Adelphi Theatre on the West End, he enjoyed “one of those musicals that would never translate to the American theater”—the Welsh composer Ivor Novello’s *The Dancing Years*. He also took the opportunity to attend the Royal Ballet to see the English ballerina Margot Fonteyn dance.

The enlisted men usually hightailed it to the Rainbow Corner near Piccadilly Circus. Run by the American Red Cross, it was designed to give a young man the feel of home away from home. In the basement was a replica of a small-town drugstore with counter Cokes and burgers off the grill. Upstairs was a grand ballroom with a live band of army musicians and volunteer hostesses eager to jitterbug with Yanks. In a lounge there was a smaller dance floor, where couples could sway to romantic songs like “That Old Black Magic” and “Taking a Chance on Love” on a jukebox that didn’t have to be fed coins. Men could get up games of pool or Ping-Pong, read newspapers from home, get a haircut and shoeshine, and book an inexpensive hotel room for a night or two.

When darkness fell, London turned into a maze of blacked-out streets teeming with folks finding their way by flashlight. Although there had been a long lull in enemy bombing of the city, searchlights still swept the sky for bombers, which antiaircraft artillery crews stood at the ready to shoot down. False alarms sent sirens wailing almost nightly, but these days fewer people stopped what they were doing to head to an underground shelter.^{III}

The war—and one’s own uncertain future in it—unleashed inhibitions in men and women, civilians and military alike. Kindred spirits looking for the

company of the opposite sex could easily be found. English pubs closed relatively early, but there was always someplace to keep drinking and dancing, such as the private clubs, where there was hard liquor to buy by the bottle. It was no joke that for some G.I.'s their hangover lasted longer than their leave in London.

Even with half the crews still on leave, operations at Harrington resumed on a limited basis on April 21, 1944—a dark, moonless night. Six aircraft took off to test whether drop missions could be completed in the darkness. Everyone was surprised that the six planes scored a rare perfect score, finding all of the drop zones through the skillful use of the Rebecca-Eureka homing devices and the S-phones for radio communication with the ground. On four out of the next five nights, more “dark ops” were conducted. Nine planes flew on the night of April 23, with eight successes; on April 24, eight planes with four successes; April 25, six planes with two successes. The 65 percent rate of completed missions on moonless nights was a credit to the pilots and crews for being more adept at flying night missions and more proficient with the navigation and fixed checkpoints required to find drop zones. Going forward, the Carpetbaggers would regularly fly on dark nights instead of being grounded for ten days during the lunar cycle each month.

This change of tactics dovetailed with concerns in the highest military and political circles in Washington and London. With D-Day looming on the horizon, there was a new urgency by the Allies to get greater amounts of arms, explosives and supplies to the estimated 50,000 French who were reported to have organized into guerrilla groups. With the Joint Chiefs of Staff in Washington and de Gaulle in London pushing for increased deliveries of matériel to the partisans, Gen. Dwight D. Eisenhower, Supreme Commander of the Allied Expeditionary Force in Europe, reported that the U.S. had thirty-two aircraft flying those missions since January, while the British had been supporting the resistance for much longer with twenty-two planes, although at the direction of Prime Minister Winston Churchill the number of their available planes was about to triple. Eisenhower, who wanted a strong resistance as a “force multiplier to harass, disrupt and divert” the enemy, ordered an increase in “the U.S. permanent allotment of aircraft,” with a commitment to reach—by

the end of June—280 tons (more than a half-million pounds) of matériel dropped monthly from American planes to French resistance forces.

The tempo of flights multiplied as more planes were assigned to the operation. Two additional B-24 squadrons joined the Carpetbaggers; one was already in England flying daylight bombing missions and the other was winging its way across the South Atlantic. A U.S. bomber squadron comprised sixteen to nineteen aircraft, with twelve to fourteen planes kept “operationally ready” at all times, and the remainder being serviced, repaired or held in reserve. The new squadrons would double the number of aircraft at Harrington to sixty-four and increase the base’s manpower to 2,600 men, including flying and ground support personnel.

Prior even to the arrival of the new squadrons, the number of completed Carpetbagger missions in April was double that in March. In April alone they flew more missions (155) than the previous three months combined (140). Of those, eighty-two were completed, resulting in the dropping by parachute of some 290,000 pounds of matériel—much of it automatic weapons, ammunition and explosives—along with nine SOE agents, including their first “Josephine.”

The first full-scale effort on a dark night was launched on April 27. Twenty-one B-24s took off at staggered times for French resistance circuits that had not as yet received drops of matériel. Despite the earlier success of the trial missions on moonless nights, a dozen aircraft returned with full loads after not locating the drop zones. The Rabbitt crew made its drop at LACKEY 5 but limped home with part of a wing missing after hitting a tree on a pitch-black hillside that on a moonlit night the crew likely would have seen. The night’s low results turned dismal when the Ambrose crew, assigned to LACKEY 3A, failed to return.

When 2nd Lt. William “Bill” Ebner learned in the morning that the Ambrose crew was MIA, it hit close to home. Two weeks earlier, he had gone pubbing in Northampton with its pilot, 2nd Lt. George Ambrose, and navigator, 2nd Lt. Arthur Pope. They had just flown their first two combat missions and were eager to tell Ebner, copilot of the Ward crew, which had not yet flown a mission, what to expect. Ambrose, twenty-four, a hail-fellow-well-met type from Springdale, Pennsylvania, told of dodging puffs of light flak at about 3,000 feet over

Beaucaire in southeastern France, then running into heavy ground fog as they neared the drop zone, which they never found. After that incomplete mission, they were back in the air the next night and made a successful drop in France despite the reception committee starting a large bonfire on a hill that filled the air with smoke, making the signal lights hard to make out. When they finally saw the correct code letter, they dropped to 400 feet and delivered the containers on target. On the way back, they received scattered machine-gun fire from the ground between Loire and the French coast. “Made for a night,” drawled the soft-spoken Pope, a native of Fulton, Georgia.

After that night in town, Ebner, twenty-one, of Canton, Ohio, visited the Ambrose hut a few times to shoot the breeze and listen to records. Someone kept playing Glenn Miller’s “Moonlight Cocktail” over and over.

*Couple of jiggers of moonlight and add a star...
Mix in a couple of dreamers, and there you are...*

In one of those improbable coincidences that happened in war, a boyhood friend of Ebner’s was the radioman on the Ambrose crew. Ebner had gone to St. John’s grade school in Canton, Ohio, with Sgt. James “Jimmy” Heddleson. Now, as Bill Ebner realized he might not see his friends Jimmy, George and Art again, he knew that popular hit song would always remind him of their camaraderie. He entered the Ambrose crew’s cold, empty hut before their personal possessions were gathered up to go into storage, found the Glenn Miller record and took it with him.

A week later, Capt. Robert Thayer of the OSS called Harrington from London and spoke to Bob Fish. Thayer said he was in touch with agents behind the lines and had received “information from the field” about a plane that went down the night of April 27 in the vicinity of Saint-Cyr-de-Valorges in the Loire region of central France. According to a note in French, Thayer went on, the aircraft arrived over a drop zone and made three descending circles. On the third circle, it struck the ground a quarter mile away, crashed and burned. Another aircraft had already made a drop nearby, and the partisans had to quickly gather up that load and hide it before the Germans arrived to investigate the crash.

“They sent one man to the crash site,” said Thayer. “For a time he couldn’t get close due to exploding ammo. When he was able to approach the wreckage, he found a piece of the airframe with a serial number.”

“What’s the number?” Fish asked.

“42-40997. Is that yours?”

Fish knew it was but checked the missing aircraft report on his desk before answering. “Yes,” he said softly. “That’s one of ours.”

42-40997 was the Ambrose crew’s B-24D named “The Worry Bird.”

I. In addition to the Francs-Tireurs et Partisans, created by the French Communist Party, other major resistance organizations in France included the Armée Secrète (AS), a group loyal to de Gaulle, and the Organisation de Résistance de l’Armée (ORA), a non-Gaullist group. De Gaulle was eager to unite the resistance, and in May 1943 eight of the largest resistance groups formed the Conseil National de la Résistance (CNR). Eventually, most of the French resistance circuits worked together as the Forces Françaises de l’Intérieur (FFI) under Eisenhower’s Allied command.

II. Fifty years after they died, a roadside memorial honoring the six lost flyers—*À la Mémoire de 6 Aviateurs Américains*—was dedicated outside the village of Bernières-le-Patry in the Calvados region of Normandy. The names etched in gold on the polished marble: 2nd Lt. William W. Nicoll, pilot; 2nd Lt. William G. Harris, navigator; 2nd Lt. Thomas F. Davis, bombardier; Staff Sergeant (S/Sgt.) Richard C. Bindel, engineer; S/Sgt. Warren A. Brewer, radio; S/Sgt. Ralph L. Kittrell, gunner. According to a French database, *Mémoire & Database*, the bombardier, Thomas Davis, of Louisville, Kentucky, was the injured crewman who was reportedly killed by “revolver shots.”

III. The hope that enemy air attacks were a thing of the past was dashed three months later when the first German missiles dropped on London. Over the next nine months, 6,725 V1 “Buzz Bombs,” which flew until they ran out of fuel and then came crashing down, struck England. In September 1944, the first of 1,358 bigger V2s were launched against England, with 517 striking London. The pilotless V-weapons were deployed by Germany as “revenge weapons” (*Vergeltungswaffen*) in a bid to terrorize British civilians and undermine morale. The random strikes inflicted more than 30,000 civilian casualties and left hundreds of thousands homeless.

SEVEN

RETURN TO FRANCE

After signing the Official Secrets Act and promising not to reveal her SOE activities under threat of imprisonment, Nancy Wake was sworn in as an ensign in FANY (First Aid Nursing Yeomanry), an all-female charity active since the First World War. FANY members were not in the Army but wore military-style uniforms and traditionally served as nurses, drivers and motor mechanics. FANY also secretly provided SOE female agents with “complete cover” for their real work.¹

Nancy’s training started at a remote manor outside London, where she was one of four women in a class of thirty recruits. Most of the men came directly from the military, but a few civilians had been recruited and now held the rank of an Army second lieutenant. Told to expect a period of “uncomfortable and arduous training,” the SOE recruits would be tested physically and mentally over the next week. Those who made the grade would advance further in their training, and those who did not would be returned to their units with no slur on their record.

Each of them was taken individually to an obstacle course. There were trees, walls and a fifty-foot rope ladder to climb; more ropes to swing across wide gorges; and a tall platform from which to jump and catch a rope six feet away to slide down. Every obstacle was marked with a point value; eighty-five points was possible with fifty needed to pass. A recruit could elect where to start on the course. When Nancy was asked which obstacles she wanted to try, she said, “None of them.” In her two years of resistance work, she had never needed to climb a tree or slide down a rope or jump off a platform. But she took off running and passed the course.

The next day they were assigned to teams and taken to another obstacle course, which demanded a high degree of cooperation and enterprise. To succeed, everyone on a team had to finish, with no one left behind. Nancy was delighted to be grouped with five “irrepressible men,” and together they maneuvered heavy objects over obstacles, crossed ponds that looked uncrossable, scaled an electrified fence, and passed the course with flying colors.

Maurice Buckmaster, the SOE French Section chief, who held the rank of a British army colonel, often scrutinized the goings-on from the sidelines, looking for a “rugged honesty and singleness of purpose” in a recruit. He wanted to see something he called “essential guts,” which went to a person’s character. The SOE wanted natural leaders, people who obeyed instructions not blindly but intelligently; who were instilled with confidence and passionate in the mission; who tackled problems with imagination and resourcefulness; and who carried on however difficult or hopeless the situation. They had to be able to bluff their way out of trouble when necessary while projecting appropriate body language and the correct nuance in their voices. Some of these things could be taught, but others could not. Buckmaster believed strong self-reliance was vital given that their tenuous radio links with London might fail at any moment. Once they landed in France, there would be no holidays, no leaves, no Sundays off. Every day, round the clock, they would pit their wits against the German army, the Gestapo, enemy collaborators and the French Milice. If they let down their guard and lost the battles of wits, it could cost lives, their own included.

A close watch was kept on the recruits by their trainers. Did they give evidence of any obvious English mannerisms that would preclude them from passing as French? Everything they did had to be done in the French manner, whether it was answering the telephone or summoning a waiter or leaving their knives and forks on their plates after a meal. Did they talk in their sleep? If so, in what language? (This obsession with a French makeover extended to having a dentist remove any English silver fillings in their teeth and replace them with more Gallic-looking gold ones before they went into the field.) In the evenings, when strong drink was offered, their reactions under its influence were tactfully noted. Did the alcohol loosen their tongues? Did they keep their emotions in check? Were they indiscreet? Did they remain aloof?

The final hurdle was a psychiatric evaluation. Nancy sat in the waiting room until the recruit in front of her finished. When the inner door opened, another woman trainee came out and whispered to Nancy that she'd be shown "hundreds of blots" and asked what they look like.

"What do they look like?" Nancy asked.

"Blots! But say corsets or butterflies and things like that."

Nancy had never been to a psychiatrist, and had already thought she wasn't going to like talking to a shrink. Now she was sure of it. As soon as she took a seat in the psychiatrist's office, he launched into a series of questions that had nothing to do with resistance work in France and were quite prying and off-putting. She felt free to amuse herself.

Were her mother and father happy together? "Very." (Her mother, of course, had been abandoned by her husband and raised their six children alone.)

Was her childhood a happy one? "Perfectly." (If you didn't count the two times an unhappy Nancy ran away.)

Did she ever draw attention to herself by lying? "Never." (A lie.)

The inane questions and her disingenuous answers continued.

Then they came to the ink blots she had been warned about. As each one was shown to her the psychiatrist asked which object she associated with the image. None looked like a corset or butterfly. One after another Nancy offered the same observation. "Blot. Blot. Blot. Blot..."

"Surely you can see *something*?" the doctor said.

"Certainly. Someone's broken a bottle of ink."

When that was over, the doctor told her he would say a word and she was to respond with another word she associated with it.

Roses. "Red."

Sugar. "Sweet."

Soda. "Whiskey."

Their word-association game went on for only a short while, after which the doctor jotted down a note. Then he pointed to a pile of blocks on a tabletop and suggested that she build something.

Nancy didn't move. "You're not English, are you?"

The doctor shook his head. "New Zealander."

“Don’t you think you’d be more useful fighting the Japanese in the Pacific defending your country than mucking about here with all these ridiculous blots and blocks? Because if you don’t, I do.”

“Perhaps.” He smiled. “Well, that’ll be all for now. Thank you.”

Nancy left the room without another word.

The psychiatrist likely got more psychological insight into Nancy than ink blots or block building would have revealed. He wasn’t put off because the contrarian ones revealed as much about themselves as did those who were either compliant or overanxious to please. He was satisfied with Ensign Wake’s mental toughness, he wrote in his report, and concluded she had the right aptitude for a successful field agent.

Nancy advanced in her training and was sent to what was billed as a “toughening school” on the northern Scottish coastline at Inverie Bay for six weeks. She was the lone woman in a class of thirty-seven. Many of their military trainers were Dunkirk evacuees who had fought against the German army and were there to pass along what they had learned.

The first week, the recruits were taught how to disassemble, reassemble and shoot an arsenal of weapons, including the Sten Mark II submachine gun. Made from forty-seven parts but weighing only 3.2 pounds, the Sten was the main assault weapon being supplied to the resistance.^{[II](#)}

The next week they began hand-to-hand combat training. The instructor, W. E. Fairbairn, was a legendary SOE trainer and a former Shanghai police commissioner who had spent years on the rough-and-tumble waterfront beat. Although nearing sixty and not a large man, the Englishman was lean and moved with catlike quickness.

“These silent killing methods you’re about to learn are drastic in the extreme,” he explained. “They have been selected to enable a person of only average strength to overpower a much stronger opponent. If it is necessary to revert to the grim brutality of the Stone Age, remember that you are dealing with an utterly ruthless enemy who has clearly expressed his intention of wiping our nation out of existence. There is no room for scruple or compunction about the methods to be employed in preventing him from doing so.”

Nancy and the other students practiced until the moves became instinctive and automatic. They learned the “Edge of the Hand Blow,” for example, delivered by the outside edge of the hand to the side of the neck—two inches below the ear, where the spinal column is most vulnerable. And if a larger opponent’s chin was too high to reach? “A knee to his testicles will bring his chin forward and down,” said the instructor.

At five foot seven and 135 pounds dripping wet, Nancy was never going to generate a lot of brute power in a fight, but she learned that if she hit the right spots she could be lethal. There was a time she would have thought herself morally incapable of killing a person, but that time had passed. She had seen too much savagery by Hitler’s miserable crowd of tyrants. If the choice was between killing a Nazi or being captured and tortured and then dying in a concentration camp, it would be an easy decision. She practiced hard to be ready if that day ever came.

In between attending order-of-battle classes, where they learned types of German planes, tanks, weapons, divisions, regiments and badges of rank, they hiked and ran, scaled cliffs, swam in the frigid ocean and bicycled. They were taught how to pass silently through undergrowth and use nature’s background to move unobserved. They lived off the land for a week and with the guidance of a skilled poacher trapped small game and learned to clean and prepare meals over a small fire. They practiced ambushes and were taught to toss grenades with a stiff-armed overhead throw. As much as possible, they were getting a taste of life with the fighting Maquis.

They moved to an airfield in Manchester for parachute training, which Nancy had been dreading. She knew the day would come when she’d have to jump from a plane over France. She hoped she’d be able to close her eyes and do it when the time came. But to *practice* doing it seemed downright cruel. As a little girl, she had tried to prove her fearlessness to her brothers by climbing onto the roof of the house to jump off. “Don’t do it!” they yelled. “You’ll break your leg!” Defiantly, she jumped and broke her leg. That put in her a fear ever after of heights.

After a day of ground instruction, they loaded into a transport plane for the first of two required jumps. Everyone was unusually quiet as they sat in two rows

facing each other with the wind whipping through the open cabin doorway. When they reached altitude, the instructor had them stand and hook up their static lines to a cable that would pull open their chutes seconds after they jumped. Nancy was in the middle of the line of jumpers and moved with them to the open door, then stepped out. After the canopy blossomed open, she started breathing again. She landed on her feet, which was her best memory of the experience. The next day was very foggy and all planes were grounded. So for their final jump they had to leap from a static balloon from which they couldn't see the ground. It came up so suddenly and unexpectedly she landed face-first and was knocked out, but got credit for completing her jumps.

After finishing their training, many in her class were selected for specialty courses. Those who showed an aptitude for sending Morse code signals went to radio school for six weeks to become wireless operators, of which there was a shortage on the ground in France. Those who were to become instructors went for more arms training, and others to commando training or explosives school. Nancy was picked for the latter and found herself in a finishing school for saboteurs, where she was soon learning how to make bombs from ingredients that could be bought at hardware stores or pharmacies without raising suspicions.

"The secret of making your own explosives lies in being absolutely accurate in your weighing-out," explained the instructor. "The slightest fraction too much or little of any one ingredient and there'll be no bang!"

Sitting next to Nancy on the floor, bowls between their knees, small scales beside them, was Violette Szabo. The only woman in the class, they agreed they had an advantage over the men because they had experience measuring out ingredients in the kitchen. All morning long they weighed out concoctions of surprisingly simple ingredients to make powerful explosives. Then they went outside and blew them all up in just a few minutes. But even that came with lessons. Such as: calculating how much explosives were needed to bring down something as small as a chimney or as large as a locomotive without unintended collateral damage.

Sharing a dormitory-style room, Nancy and Violette became fast friends. Both free spirits, they discovered they shared a love of the cinema, music and

dancing. Nancy was nearly ten years older than Violette, and she found the younger woman's energy and gaiety captivating and easy to be around. Late at night in their room after a day of blowing things up, they spoke quietly of their lives as they seldom did with others: Violette about the pain of losing her husband, Etienne—the dashing Foreign Legionnaire—in North Africa, and Nancy about fleeing Marseille and having to leave dear Henri behind.

Violette admitted she almost didn't make it this far in her training. She had only barely scraped through the initial evaluation at the manor, where she received a middling intelligence rating of 5 (out of 10) and an overall score of D (poor). Her first evaluation report read, in part:

A quiet, physically tough, self-willed girl of average intelligence. Out for excitement and adventure but not entirely frivolous. Has plenty of confidence in herself and gets on well with others. Plucky and persistent in her endeavours. Not easily rattled.... She could probably do a useful job, possibly as a courier.

Coming from a working-class background in England and France, Violette's upbringing was the opposite of those from the higher strata of English society and education, with which the ranks of the SOE and British military were filled. When the evaluations were done by Oxford and Sandhurst graduates, other trainees from backgrounds similar to Violette's had fared no better in their early lukewarm assessments—and yet many went on to be effective agents. The board making the final decision as to whether Ensign Szabo stayed in the SOE for more training had decided there could be a role for her.

It was when Violette began her paramilitary training in Scotland that she shined. Reminiscent of the days she was banned at the shooting gallery at the local fair because she won too many prizes, her skill with firearms earned her what was believed to be the top score ever achieved on the SOE range, which was comprised of a series of long alleys with life-size metal silhouettes at one end. And she excelled in the rough-and-tumble courses like hand-to-hand combat. But concerns about her lingered, and her assessments were mixed. She was seen at times as being “too fatalistic,” and there were still some questions about her

motives for volunteering. She made no secret that she was there to avenge the death of her husband, which was understandable. But would that make her too willing to take chances in the field? A reckless agent could not only endanger the lives of other agents but threaten an entire circuit. One trainer thought she might lack the “ruse, stability and finesse” to work behind enemy lines. But in addition to her superb physicality, there was her excellent French, accented from the northern region, where she had lived and gone to school as a young girl. Her fluency, combined with how well she blended in with the rural and working classes, made her exactly the type of person sought by the SOE for its clandestine missions in France. No one would peg her as a British secret agent.

On their free nights, Violette and Nancy often went to London together and “did the town,” going to movies, clubs and bars. Men in the class fell “madly in love” with the movie-star-beautiful Violette, and the two women had no shortage of escorts.

Back at school, Nancy and Violette seldom lost an opportunity to stand their ground against their male classmates, who pulled pranks on “those ruddy girls”—like the one who gift wrapped three condoms and handed them to Nancy in the mess hall, expecting her to be embarrassed. Unfazed, she slipped them into her shirt pocket and went on with her lunch.

At the conclusion of the explosives course, Nancy and Violette decided to retaliate against a boorish instructor who often targeted them with his ungentelemanly wisecracks. Using stealth and their new martial arts skills, they dropped him to the ground. He resisted but was no match for them, and they unceremoniously “debugged” him, leaving him standing before the entire barracks in his blue-striped underwear. Nancy triumphantly waved his trousers aloft like a regimental battle flag, and within minutes the liberated trousers were flying from a flagpole.

A raucous party was thrown in the barracks their last night, and in the morning goodbyes were said by all. Everyone was free to go on leave but told to call in daily to find out if they had an assignment. To a man and woman, everyone hoped to hear they would soon be leaving for France.

Nancy and Violette headed to London—Violette to see her daughter and parents, and Nancy to check on her flat she still kept. They had a final night on

the town together with some friends from their training class. They left the Astor nightclub on Park Lane at four o'clock in the morning and did parachute rolls along Piccadilly—landing with feet together and rolling onto their sides as they had been taught—all the while singing at the tops of their voices a stanza from a popular American paratrooper song, “Blood on the Risers,” to the tune of “Battle Hymn of the Republic.”

*Gory, gory, what a helluva way to die,
Gory, gory, what a helluva way to die,
Gory, gory, what a helluva way to die,
He ain't gonna jump no more!*

Returning to Nancy's place, they all slept it off until midmorning. As people departed there were hugs and farewells. Nancy felt sad because they had all become so close as they trained and aimed for a common goal. Violette was the last to leave.

“Au revoir, Nancy.”

They kissed on the cheeks, *faire la bise*.

“Au revoir, mon ami,” said Nancy.

Nancy watched Violette stroll up the street, light and balanced on her feet, prepared for whatever was about to be thrown at her. So strong and ready, she thought, but also so young—too young to be a widow. She hoped her dear friend would find the retribution she was seeking.

Nancy was summoned in April 1944 to Orchard Court, which looked like many mansion blocks across London when completed in 1930 but had taken on a secret wartime role. Inside an unmarked flat was the hub of operations for the French Section. Among those assisting Maurice Buckmaster here was Vera Atkins, who, in addition to other duties, was responsible for the female agents in their preparations before being sent into France. Born in Romania to Jewish parents, Atkins, thirty-six, had studied at the Sorbonne in Paris before immigrating to England in 1937. A couple of inches shy of six feet, she favored tailored skirt suits and often stayed late into the night chain-smoking in the

signals room awaiting the transmissions of coded messages sent by her agents in the field.

After Nancy was brought up by a stoic doorman in a dark suit and tie through the gilded metal gates of the lift to the second floor, she was shown into a cramped office, where Buckmaster came around from behind a desk to greet her. He was a head taller than her, and although now in his forties, he still had his slender, athletic build from his days when he captained the Eton soccer team. She had seen a lot of “the Colonel,” as everyone called him, over the past few months when he dropped by to observe their training. She always found him exuberant and welcoming, and had enjoyed their interactions. He now gave her a hearty handshake. She sat in a straight-backed chair, and he perched casually atop the desk, long legs swinging.

“Nancy, I’ve looked at your report and it’s very good indeed.”

“Yes, I know—” she said before catching herself.

“You know? How could you possibly know what’s in your report?”

Could she speak the truth and trust him not to kick her out of his section? Something told her she could. She confessed to breaking into the training commander’s office in the wee hours, opening his locked files and reading her report just before the end of the course.

“You *what*?”

His volume startled her. “You needn’t shout at me, sir. After all, I was taught at the school how to do it. You should be proud of me.”

Nancy had done so because she was anxious to learn if she was going to make it through training. Much of the report, both good and bad, she could have written herself, it was so true. It read, in part:

Attracted by adventure and excitement. At times appears to lack a proper sense of seriousness and responsibility. She is, however, essentially loyal and reliable, has a marked sense of humour, and is persistent and determined. She has abundant energy.

Breaking into the commander’s office was such a breach of security it would have meant a court-martial in any other branch of the military, but she was right

in saying to Buckmaster that it was exactly the sort of skulking about that SOE agents were trained and expected to do.

Buckmaster's mien was unreadable, then he burst into a big laugh. "We must get you out of the country straightaway. You're a menace!"

He told her that based on her progress, experience and his own intuition, he believed she was ready to be sent back to France. "I'm sure you'll do well, Nancy."



Nancy Wake. "She is the most feminine woman I know, until the fighting starts," said one French resistance leader. "Then she is like five men."

WIKIPEDIA COMMONS

Seated back at his desk, he commenced to brief her on a mission that he said could happen as soon as next week. She would be dropped into central France

near the town of Montluçon, some 150 miles northwest of Lyon. It was an area Nancy had visited during her travels as a journalist, and she knew Montluçon was linked with surrounding regions and towns via several main roads and a railway that went through to Paris. A notable act of resistance had occurred here in early 1943 when a mob of citizens overran guards supervising a massive deportation of men to Germany in accordance with the *Service du Travail Obligatoire* [Obligatory Work Service] plan that sent able Frenchmen to fill vacancies in German factories during the war. All the local men who were to be deported managed to escape into the countryside, evading the forced industrial service awaiting them in the Reich. Many of them headed a hundred miles south into the Massif Central, a highland region consisting of mountains as high as 6,000 feet and plateaus covered in thick forests accessible only by back roads. The region—known as *la forteresse de la France* [the fortress of France]—was an ideal location from which groups of partisans were able to operate, leaving to strike enemy targets, then melding back into the woods.

Buckmaster said she would be accompanied by Maj. John Farmer, who had been a latecomer to her training class. She knew that Farmer, a twenty-seven-year-old champion sprinter and hurdler with a passion for rugby, had been personally recruited by Buckmaster from British special forces. Born in London and educated in Germany, Switzerland and Belgium, he was multilingual but spoke French like an Englishman. Farmer was to organize a new circuit, FREELANCE, and Nancy would serve as his courier, which involved traveling between and speaking with resistance members. Their wireless operator would be Capt. Denis Rake, who had been one of their radio instructors during training. While she and Farmer were to parachute into France, the forty-three-year-old Rake had injured a leg on an earlier parachute jump and was medically unfit to jump. Volunteering to join Farmer and Nancy on the mission due to a shortage of wireless operators, Rake was to fly with his radio set on a Lysander plane and land in a field some fifty miles away, then join them a few days later.

Buckmaster explained there were several thousand Maquis in the region. Her team's mission was to identify and contact their leaders, assess their requirements for arms, supplies and money, and set up by radio nighttime airdrops to get them everything they needed. In addition to “coordinating

subversive and sabotage activity,” their orders were for the team to “initiate action against the enemy, if necessary.”

Nancy had listened spellbound. It was a classic French Section operation in which she was to have a crucial role, and she could not have been more thrilled. This was what she hoped to be doing when she volunteered for the SOE, and what she had been working toward these past months.

The next few days flew by with final preparations. Nancy was given forged IDs and other documents. She and Farmer were provided with elaborate cover stories to memorize—including fictitious relatives from grandmothers to great-uncles—then went through intense interrogations to try to shake their recollection of names, dates and other details and find inconsistencies. They memorized their contacts, safe houses, radio codes and a long list of targets for demolition: railway junctions, bridges, underground cables and factories, even specific ones that were to be hit only after the Allied landings on D-Day.

When the day came for Nancy and Farmer to be driven to the airfield north of London, everyone inside the Orchard Court flat lined up to say goodbye, with manly handshakes for the major and cheek kisses for Nancy. She thought everyone looked a little glum, perhaps understanding the uncertainty of what they would soon be facing in France. She lightened the mood with a quick joke. “You’re just jealous,” she laughed.

Nancy was dressed very much like herself. Her dress bore a French label, and she wore silk stockings, stylish flats and her favorite camel-hair coat. The coat had one minor alteration. Secreted in the second button on the cuff of the left sleeve was a cyanide pill guaranteed to provide a quick death if she ever found herself in a situation where that was preferable to what lay ahead.^{III}

In a small backpack she had several changes of clothes and two embroidered nightgowns she’d insisted on bringing with her. On her arm was a handbag with her favorite red Chanel lipstick, tightly packed articles of feminine hygiene and tens of thousands of dollars’ worth of French francs to finance the Maquis until more money began arriving in airdrops. She had in her purse a last-minute farewell gift from the Colonel, who must have known she always liked to look her best. He gave her a silver compact makeup case.

They were driven to Harrington Airfield in a black Chevy sedan with tinted windows, passing through the front gate at about 6 p.m. After a snack in the mess hall, they were taken into what was known as the “dressing hut,” where they were helped into padded jumpsuits that went over their regular clothing. Inside multiple zippered pockets were a revolver, a dagger, silk maps, a small flashlight, a first-aid kit and two days of rations. A rubber cushion was placed in the seat of the jumpsuit and a rubberized wrap wound around their ankles and feet. For further protection from the shock of landing, they wore a helmet and knee-high rubber boots over their shoes. Finally, they were fitted with a backpack parachute, which, given the bulging jumpsuit, was accomplished after much effort. They would not have a reserve chute. At the low altitude from which they were to jump, if the main chute failed to deploy, there wouldn’t be time for a reserve to open before they hit the ground at more than 100 mph.

Now ready to head to the aircraft, Nancy felt like a grotesque, top-heavy Frankenstein’s monster as she shuffled forth from the dressing hut. They squeezed back into the black sedan that had brought them to the base and were driven to the flight line and let out next to the huge shadowy figure of a four-engine bomber, whose crew was already aboard. Unbeknownst to the agents, they were to be dropped into France that night by the Van Zyl crew. Likewise, Nancy had no inkling that she was about to become the Carpetbaggers’ first “Josephine.”



Two agents being fitted with their jumpsuits at Harrington.

U.S. ARMY SIGNAL CORPS

They loaded through the Joe Hole near the rear of the plane. Nancy got a boost from someone on the ground and was pulled up by a pair of strong arms belonging to the dispatcher, Henry “Hank” Hettinger, twenty-three, of Sterling, Colorado. He showed them where to sit on the bare metal floor and dropped a piece of plywood over the hole.



Van Zyl crew. Standing, left to right: Harold R. Van Zyl, pilot; Clifton G. Clark, copilot; Lawrence Rivkin, navigator; William E. Elkouri, bombardier. In front, left to right: Udell W. Olson, radio operator; Harold L. Qualls, engineer; John F. Zsadanyi, tail gunner; Henry R. Hettinger, dispatcher.

U.S. ARMY SIGNAL CORPS

“We never dropped a woman before,” Hettinger marveled. A true gentleman, he handed her a Spam sandwich and a tin of lukewarm coffee.

Soon, the first engine sputtered and roared to life, then the others, with the deafening volume and vibrations multiplying with each one. Then they were taxiing to the runway, where they sat for a time. As they suddenly began the takeoff run with full power, it felt to Nancy like all hell was breaking loose. Just as she thought the plane might split at the seams, they started rising. Her stomach went in the opposite direction.

The time was 10:19 p.m., and the date April 29, 1944. Fourteen Carpetbagger planes took off on what was the last night of operations for the month. It would turn out to be a good night, with nine completed missions dropping 30,000 pounds of matériel to six French resistance circuits. Van Zyl’s plane was the second to last to depart, and the only one carrying agents.

For two hours in the cold, rattling cabin, Nancy fought to hold back nausea as the Spam and the coffee were going around and around. She was also fighting back anxiety. She had gone through life—even parachute training—without conquering her fear of heights. She now realized how crazy it was that she’d never flown in a plane from which she hadn’t jumped.

The engines quieted as the power was decreased and the plane slowly began descending. The dispatcher pulled aside the plank of plywood, exposing the circular hole in the cabin floor about four feet in diameter. The wind pulled at their overalls as the two agents and dispatcher gazed into the howling abyss below. Would there be signal lights? Or a bonfire? They finally saw a faint red light, though not very well through a layer of haze. Apparently it was good enough for the pilot, because the plane began a long loop to come back around, Hettinger told them, to the best upwind line for the drop. The two agents had decided Farmer would jump first, followed by Nancy. Then the plane would make another pass to drop its load of containers.

To ensure Hettinger didn't accidentally fall out of the plane—like other crewmen, dispatchers did not wear bulky parachutes during flights—he was attached to a movable roller by a safety belt mounted in the upper center of the fuselage. He connected the static lines to their chutes—the other ends were bolted to the ceiling—then had the agents slide over near the opening and wait for the signal to jump.

As soon as the green light came on, Hettinger motioned Farmer forward. Without a moment's hesitation, the British officer dropped into the dark hole and disappeared. Within seconds, the static line that pulled open his parachute snapped taut like a fishing line, signaling that Farmer's chute had deployed.

The dispatcher motioned to Nancy to move up to the opening. When he gave her the signal to jump seconds later, she found herself unable to do it. Trying to keep from vomiting, she had gone white in the face. She froze like a statue; for how long, she didn't know. Thirty seconds?

The dispatcher finally held up the palms of his hands. Too late.

He pulled the static line from Farmer's chute back through the Joe Hole while speaking to the cockpit on his headset, then to Nancy over the sound of the engines. "If you're afraid, ma'am, we'll take you back."

Nancy knew she faced a decisive moment in her life. If she went back to England, her chance to do something in the war would be over. After all the training and hard work, she would be drummed from the SOE. She had to jump even if it killed her, which she figured it might well do. "Look," she yelled back, "I want to get out of this bloody plane!"

Hettinger smiled. "Okay, we'll make another pass."

Nancy asked him for "one little bit of help" when it was time, and Hettinger agreed. As he later recalled, "She wasn't going to back off. She was very brave. But she asked me to get behind her and give her a big shove at the right moment."

And that's how Nancy parachuted into wartime France.

The sudden rush of cold air caused her to forget about her fear of heights. Before she could count to three, the silk canopy snapped open and there was a strong tug on her parachute harness, as if someone had applied the speed brakes. Looking down, she was startled to see treetops only a couple hundred feet below. If they were jumping into an ambush at a drop zone that had been overrun by the enemy, this was when she would be most vulnerable: a floating target in the sky with no place to hide.

She saw the bonfire that lit the drop zone, but she was drifting farther away. Crashing through the branches of a tall pine, she came to a jolting halt when the canopy snagged in the upper limbs, leaving her dangling ten feet off the ground. There were distant voices that were coming closer. She felt no great relief that they were speaking French because she knew from bitter experience about the dreaded Milice and the traitorous French collaborators in cahoots with the Germans.

Then, beneath her: a Frenchman's voice that was too kind and laced with humor to belong to someone who might shoot her in the tree.

"I hope all the trees in France bear such beautiful fruit this year."

"Cut the French bullshit," Nancy ordered, "and get me down."

Her sweet-talking savior was Henri Tardivat, a handsome, thirty-something former math teacher and rugby player from the town of Montluçon who was one of the leaders of the local resistance. He had also collected Farmer, and he brought them both to an automobile parked in the woods. As his men worked on unloading the containers in the field and transferring the loads to lorries, he drove the agents to a nearby farmhouse, where their hosts were waiting to put them up for the night. Assuming the pair were a couple, the agents were shown to a room with one bed, which caused Nancy a moment of consternation. But

they were exhausted and neither wanted the wooden floor, so Nancy curled up under the bedclothes and Farmer slept atop them.

Over the next few days, the agents went around the region to meet other resistance leaders, some of whom were disappointed with the agents for arriving without a wireless set and with no way to arrange for the immediate delivery of the war supplies they so badly needed.

More than a week passed. Then, as Nancy was sitting on the wall of a local cemetery, contemplating how she and Farmer would get a radio when they couldn't even send a message to London asking for a replacement, their missing wireless operator pulled up in a dusty Citroën. Ever the wit, Denis Rake climbed out and asked if she was picking a suitable grave.

“You darling!” Nancy exclaimed. “Where have you *been?*”



SOE wireless operator Denis Rake.

SPECIAL FORCES ROLL OF HONOUR

Nancy and Farmer had already scouted a large plateau at the 5,000-foot level in a Massif Central range of mountains outside Chaudes-Aigues, a spa town in south-central France famous for its hot springs. The level ground surrounded by a fringe of woods was ideal for a drop zone. Now they quickly coded their first message to London. To evade the sophisticated mobile detection equipment deployed by the Germans to hunt for Allied transmitters, Rake had to be exacting in his work. London listened for their coded messages for only a few minutes at a specific time each day. According to their transmission schedule, they were expected to be heard from at 6:53 that night. If they missed that time, they had to wait until 5:32 p.m. the following day. For their first transmission, Rake sent the message "A frog is croaking in the mountains." When decoded in

London, it confirmed their team was in place and ready to get to work. The coordinates of the drop zone on the plateau followed. Their message was received in a country manor in Kent, where some five hundred men and women worked in shifts around the clock handling coded radio messages from and to agents in the field.

Two days later, Rake received confirmation that their first drop was on for that night. Farmer and Nancy headed out with about fifty armed partisans. When they reached the location, they set up a security perimeter, built a bonfire and set out the signal lights. All faces then turned expectantly toward the west, from where the plane would come.

Just after midnight, the faint drone of aircraft engines was heard. The signal lights were quickly turned on, marking the field, and soon parachute canopies filled the sky above them. When the heavy containers landed with thuds, men excitedly raced into the field after them—looking for all the world, Nancy thought, like children scurrying forth on an Easter egg hunt. Opening their prizes, they unloaded an assortment of new automatic weapons packed in heavy grease, and packages of explosives and detonators, along with copies of an illustrated manual in French, *Comment Utiliser des Explosifs Puissants* [How to Use High Explosives]. The empty containers were hidden in the forest.

With Nancy helping to code and decode the messages, Rake communicated daily with London, and for the next six nights the skies rained arms, explosives and cash to be distributed to the resistance. Word of this military bounty spread throughout the area, and hundreds of new recruits flowed in to join the patriots risking their lives to kick the Nazi invaders from their land so they could all return to their homes and families in peace and pick up the threads of their lives.

Nancy Wake was back in the fight.

I. More than half of the some 5,000 FANYs who served in World War II held top secret jobs in the SOE as trainers, coders, signalers, forgers and dispatchers. Of the fifty female intelligence agents sent by SOE into France, thirty-nine were FANY members.

II. British factories cranked out millions of Sten submachine guns during the war, which cost only \$11 each to manufacture, compared to the American Thompson submachine gun, which cost \$200 apiece. Chambered in 9x19mm and equipped with a thirty-round detachable box magazine, the Sten had an effective firing range of 100 yards. It was used extensively by British and Commonwealth forces and was

distributed widely to the resistance throughout Europe. According to SOE records, 197,480 Stens were parachuted by U.S. and RAF planes to partisans in wartime France.

III. In October 1942, Hitler had issued the *Kommandobefehl* [Commando Order], stating that all captured Allied commandos, spies and saboteurs were to be executed without trial. OSS and SOE agents taken prisoner, along with other special forces, were turned over to the Gestapo and transported to concentration camps for execution, which was often preceded by interrogation and torture.

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EIGHT

THE SIMON CREW

On the night of May 5, 1944—three days before a full moon—twenty-one Carpetbagger planes departed Harrington on missions to France.

The Simon crew was one of three assigned to make a round trip across nearly the breadth of France to drop zone MARKSMAN 27A. Five more B-24s were set to make their drops at three other nearby locations on the same circuit. MARKSMAN was one of the largest resistance networks in France, operating in a 10,000-square-mile area from Lyon to Lons-le-Saunier to the Swiss border. Its organizer was Richard Heslop, thirty-seven, a British army officer. Born in Cierp-Gaud, France, to English parents, Heslop was considered one of the French Section's top agents. The reason his group was to receive an extraordinary eight planeloads in a single night—nearly 30,000 pounds of rifles, machine guns, mortars, ammunition, explosives, petrol and other matériel—had to do with the assignment London had given him. As soon as Allied troops stormed the beaches on D-Day, his several thousand trained Maquis were to begin killing “every German and ending all rail transport” in their area.

Second Lt. Murray Simon was in the pilot's seat that night for his eleventh mission, but only his fourth as command pilot. He clearly recalled how he had felt on his first mission: 90 percent curiosity, 10 percent fear. Since then, knowing all that could go wrong, it was the reverse. More so, he understood the success of each mission sat squarely on his shoulders and that he was accountable for the lives of his seven crewmen.



Simon crew. Standing, left to right: John A. Reitmeier, navigator; John B. Mead, bombardier; John A. Lucy, pilot observer; French M. Russell, copilot; Murray L. Simon, pilot. In front, left to right: Phillips B. Latta, radio operator; Graham S. Hasty, tail gunner; Leo F. Dumesnil, engineer; and Homer G. Collier, dispatcher.

U.S. ARMY SIGNAL CORPS

Taking on responsibility, however, was nothing new for Simon, the youngest of four children born to Russian Jewish immigrants. Not long after his family moved from Brooklyn to a modest home they purchased in the Richmond Hill neighborhood of Queens, his father, David, a partner in a furrier business, died suddenly of kidney cancer, leaving the family with no wage earner. Murray's mother rented out one level of their two-story house to help pay the bills, but it was not easy. That first winter on their own was a frigid one, and Murray, then thirteen, sold fruit from a homemade pushcart before school. In 1935, he and his older brother, Sidney, then seventeen, jointly decided to drop out of high school—Murray was in his junior year and Sid was a senior—to help support their mother and sister, Jeannie, an aspiring pianist. (Another sister, Mary, had died in 1925 at age twelve from rheumatic fever.) Murray went to work in a dental lab making implants, and Sid sold retail products for a large paper mill.

In 1939, seeking travel and a break from his “mundane existence,” Murray enlisted in the peacetime Army and arranged for his mother to receive a monthly allotment from his pay. After the U.S. entered the war in December 1941, he was promoted to sergeant in a medical unit of the 1st Infantry Division. In fall 1942, his division was preparing to ship out to North Africa when he saw a recruiting poster with bombers in flight over a billowing U.S. flag—“Keep 'Em Flying... Young Men 18 to 26 Years of Age for Air Crew Training as Bombardiers, Navigators and Pilots.” In a snap decision that was to change his life, Murray

applied for pilot training even though he knew it was a long shot. Army aviators were commissioned officers—usually with at least two years of college—and he was an enlisted man and a high school dropout at that. What chance did he stand? Also, his infantry outfit was leaving for overseas any day. To buy himself time, Murray had a friend drop a heavy trunk on his foot. His bruised and swollen appendage gave him the reprieve he had sought. After a battery of tests, he entered flight training as an aviation cadet. He was told if he washed out he'd be back in the infantry, but it was as if Murray Simon had been born to fly. First going up with an instructor in a two-seat biplane, then soloing after eight hours of dual instruction, and eventually learning instrument flying, he handled each stage of his training with proficiency and confidence. He found his academic classes more difficult, and studied long hours to grasp the principles of navigation and mathematics. But he made the grade, graduated from advanced flight training and received his commission. His graduation picture he sent home to his mother showed him in a sheepskin-lined leather jacket, scarf, goggles atop a soft leather helmet, and wearing a proud smile.

Meanwhile, his brother, Sid, was on a journey of his own that would take him into the skies of a different theater of war. By the time he enlisted in the Army in August 1942—he also arranged a monthly allotment for their mother—Sid had gone to night school to get his high school diploma, and attended electrical courses offered by the U.S. Office of Education while working full-time. Accepted as an aviation cadet, he went to navigator training at Selman Field in Louisiana, graduated in fall 1943 and was soon navigating on bombing raids against Japanese strongholds in the western Pacific.

The years had not been easy on their mother, who had lost her second daughter, Jeannie, to leukemia in 1941. But Anna Simon was not a complainer, and when she wrote to her sons overseas, her closing message always had the same refrain. *I am fine. Don't worry about me. Take good care of yourself.* Like many mothers who were seeing their sons off to war, she was proud and worried in equal measure.

Seated next to Murray in the copilot's seat as they prepared for takeoff from Harrington Airfield the night of May 5 was 2nd Lt. French M. Russell, twenty-six, a taciturn Oklahoman from Pawnee County. This was Russell's sixth

mission. As copilot, it was his job to watch the gauges, help with the controls when needed and take over flying the plane if anything happened to the pilot.

Directly behind the cockpit was Technical Sergeant (T/Sgt.) Leo F. Dumesnil, twenty-six, born in the bayou country of southern Louisiana but now hailing from Shelby, Mississippi, where his wife, Jean, awaited his return. Slim, a bit chatty and given to wearing his ball cap askew, he laid claim to this being his “lucky 13th mission.” Dumesnil usually stood rather than sat at his assigned station, where he had an array of gauges and engine controls to monitor. He’d quickly go up a few steps into the top turret to man the .50-cal. machine guns if they came under attack by an enemy plane. Always good with his hands, he’d been a carpenter in civilian life, but the Army made him a flight engineer. His main job was chief mechanic for the four 1,200-hp Pratt & Whitney air-cooled radial engines as well as the hydraulic system that powered nearly everything else on the plane. If they got shot up—fuel tanks punctured or a severed hydraulic line or an engine flameout—Dumesnil was the guy they’d count on to save their big tin ass and figure out a way to get them home. He had a couple of other skills no one in the crew hoped they’d ever need: Dumesnil was of French and German descent, and spoke both languages.

Now, as they prepared for takeoff, Russell called out the items from a preflight checklist. Murray then started the four engines in the required sequence: #3 always came first because it provided power to the rest of the plane, then the others followed. Each one sputtered, smoked and backfired before their three-bladed props roared to life.

When they taxied to the end of the runway and were cleared for takeoff, Murray pushed the four throttles through the turbo supercharger safety stops. They lumbered down the runway so slowly, at first it seemed impossible the heavy bomber would attain the necessary speed to become airborne, but the crew was accustomed to the uncomfortable sensation, as a fully loaded B-24 always struggled to leave the ground.



Cockpit of B-24 Liberator.
U.S. ARMY SIGNAL CORPS

Russell called off the speeds in increments of 10 mph.

Without a full load, the plane would have easily left the ground at 110 mph. But weighed down with two tons of supplies, Murray held forward pressure on the control wheel, keeping the nose down, until they reached 130 mph. By then, they had used up 4,000 feet of the 5,000-foot runway. Only then did he ease back on the control wheel and let the aircraft become airborne.

“Gear up,” Murray told Russell. “Flaps neutral.”

They were off at two minutes before 10 p.m. on their journey to MARKSMAN 27A in the heart of France. The English weather was lousy again. After a few glimpses of the patchwork farmlands of Northampton, they were on instruments crossing the fog-shrouded Channel. Flying blind over the frigid sea produced a silent, helpless, enduring terror for the men. Man-made perils were preferable, against which they could defend themselves; it was all-encompassing work that tended to crowd out fear because there was little time to think. Foul weather and zero visibility were different curses that they could do nothing about except hope and pray to find their way safely through them.

Located just aft of the cockpit at his station in front of the black boxes of his communications gear was the radio operator, T/Sgt. Phillips B. Latta, twenty-nine. Born and raised in Durham, North Carolina, Latta was quiet and detail-oriented. He had worked as a mechanic in civilian life, and during his Army training he took to all things technical and electrical. Among the equipment he operated during the flight was the Rebecca homing device to direct them to the drop zone from about fifteen miles away. In their briefing for the mission, they

were told that the reception party did not have an S-phone radiotelephone, so there would be no voice communication with the ground tonight. The plane's call sign included the last three digits of the aircraft serial number: "Easy 798." But they would be using their call sign only when communicating with air traffic controllers when leaving or returning to England. Latta was to maintain complete radio silence at all other times except in an emergency.

Farther back in the plane's cramped midsection there was so little headroom that all but the shortest men ducked to avoid hitting the overhead. The racks above the bomb bay doors were filled with the torpedo-shaped steel containers, leaving limited room to maneuver.

Aft of the bomb bay was S/Sgt. Homer G. Collier, at thirty-two years of age the undisputed "old man" of the Simon crew. He was also on his thirteenth mission. A rancher from Cottonwood, North Dakota, he had been trained as a B-24 waist gunner, but when those guns were removed from all Carpetbagger aircraft he became the designated dispatcher, responsible for ensuring the smooth drop of supplies and agents. Now he was perched next to the cramped bomb bay, checking and rechecking the heavy straps securing the containers, each one tethered to a cable connected to a packed chute.

The only crew member stationed farther back in the aircraft was S/Sgt. Graham "Gray" Hasty, a twenty-three-year-old sharpshooter from Georgia with a rail-thin frame that made him a good fit to be the tail gunner. His post was at the tapered tail of the sixty-four-foot plane, where he was practically pinned into the revolving turret with no room to spare. With nothing but an angled plastic windshield between him and the outside, his position was crucial for spotting enemy fighters approaching from the rear. It was a formidable defensive station: faced with attackers on the bomber's tail, he had an unimpeded line of fire and could really give the enemy aircraft hell with his twin .50-cal. machine guns. At the same time, he was a sitting duck if a German pilot coming up from the rear was a good shot.¹

As soon as they were over the Channel, Hasty test-fired his machine guns. If they failed to fire or became jammed, it was his job to disassemble the pieces, fix the problem and put the gun back together, something he had been trained to do while blindfolded. Better to find out there was a problem now than later.

Given his perch at the tail—he was looking backward almost all the time—he was the only crewman who could watch as they flew past the drop zone to see if all the parachutes opened. At the debriefing that followed every mission, Hasty alone reported on the success or failure of the chutes. Having previously flown with two other Carpetbagger crews, he had made it so far through the war without incident. In fact, this was his twenty-third combat mission—once they landed back in England he'd need just two more to complete his tour. As he had written his fiancée, a nursing student named Mickey Long, he'd soon be on his way home to her.

As they approached the French coast, Murray slowly gained altitude. The whoosh of strong winds buffeting the aircraft was a familiar melody. They soon cleared the overcast and found it was beautiful and clear in the light of a nearly full moon. Murray knew at this altitude they could be picked up by German radar and become a juicy target for a prowling night fighter looking to get lucky, but that was a chance they'd have to take. It beat trying to navigate halfway across France, hugging the terrain under low clouds while dodging hills and mountainsides. When the altimeter hit 8,000, he leveled out, throttled back the engines and held their speed at 200 mph.

After three hours—cold, uncomfortable, watchful hours for everyone, given they were in hostile skies—Murray began descending toward their target coordinates. The constant drumbeat of the engines was accompanied by the rattling of the airframe riding the turbulence. The usual smell of high-octane fuel and hydraulic fluid wafted through the plane.

Seated in the nose compartment, the bombardier, 1st Lt. John B. Mead, twenty-four, of Jacksonville, Florida, was peering through the plastic dome. He was in total darkness inside the curtained-off nose to assist with visual recognition of the terrain and to call out the signal lights on the ground. But right now he couldn't see past the solid mass of cloud cover beneath them.



Tail gunner Graham "Gray" Hasty.

U.S. ARMY SIGNAL CORPS

Tucked in the nose compartment behind Mead was 1st Lt. John A. Reitmeier, twenty-five, of Palmyra, New Jersey, at his navigator's drop-down table covered in maps. As he had just reported to the cockpit over the interphone, he was sure they were on course, thirty minutes from the drop zone. When they had risen above the overcast, he had quickly "shot the stars" in the clear skies with his sextant. This was his fifteenth mission, and he knew what he was doing at the navigator's table. He had gotten them this far with his maps and calculations, but to complete the drop his "nose buddy" Johnny Mead needed to see the lights of the reception committee on the ground.

About fifteen minutes past midnight, Mead identified the "terrain as briefed" when he spotted a bend in the Saône River near Saint-Didier-sur-Beaujeu, about twelve miles northeast of Roanne. Murray brought them down lower, and they circled once. When Mead saw the signal lights, he sent the load of containers on their way to the resistance fighters waiting below.

Back in the tight quarters of the tail turret, Gray's trained eyes stayed in constant motion, scanning the night for enemy aircraft or AAA fire. Only a minute or two after they made their drop came what sounded like a "giant metal baseball bat" being slammed against the plane's aluminum exterior. It was a terrible noise unlike any he'd heard before. Gray never saw what hit them, but suddenly a string of hot steel slugs was stitching across their tail section and punching into his turret.

Up in the cockpit, all hell broke loose. The electrical system started crashing and Murray lost rudder control. He watched the dials as he and Russell tried to stabilize the plane.

"Damage?" Murray asked over the interphone.

"We're on fire!" someone yelled.

Murray shot back: "Fight the fire and hold on, boys!"

In the cockpit, Murray was struggling to get the plane back into the clouds, zero visibility below now being a friend. Then they were hit again. More hot-lead projectiles—popping like loud fireworks—punched through the fuselage and right wing.

When the electrical system failed and the interphone stopped working, Murray had Russell go back and check on the damage and the crew. The copilot came back to report the men were fighting fires fed by severed fuel and oil lines. The munitions and petrol they were carrying would blow if the heat and flames reached them. Meanwhile, Murray struggled with unresponsive flight controls. The right wing was ablaze, and the two engines on that side had lost power. Two years of training flashed through his mind. *Fire. Loss of flight controls. Engines gone.* Shuddering and slewing as they lost altitude, the plane was coming apart. They were going down and it was time to hit the silk before it was too late.

Murray activated the bail-out alarm that wailed through the plane, then stayed at the controls to give the crew time to jump. Everyone scrambled for their parachutes and escape kits, and rushed toward the nearest exit. None of them had made practice parachute jumps as the Army once intended for bomber crews because it was decided they would lose too many men that way. Instead, they would get one chance to do it perfectly the first time, and today was the day for the Simon crew.

Back in the shattered tail section, Gray had lapsed into unconsciousness. When he came to, he was on his back on the blistering-hot deck. He had no memory of leaving the turret, which was now ablaze. Somehow, he'd been thrown clear. He had a stabbing pain in his right thigh and hip; reaching down, his hand sunk into a bloody, mushy hole. He staggered to the bomb bay, grateful to find the doors were still open. He grabbed a spare parachute on the way because his own was inside the wrecked turret. With the flames threatening to engulf him, it was jump now or die. While still trying to hook up the parachute pack to his chest harness, Gray dropped out the bomb bay into the dark void. By the time he secured the pack to the harness, he had rolled inverted and was dropping headfirst. When he pulled the D-ring the canopy popped open with such force that he was yanked upright. After one wild swing that nearly flipped him over again, he settled into a swaying descent.

He looked up to see the plane burst into flames from wingtip to wingtip. It then went into a spiral, dropping straight toward him. He desperately yanked on the shroud lines, trying to maneuver the canopy out of the way. The bomber kept coming, and he was sure it would hit him. But he felt only intense heat and

a vortex of wind as it hurtled past. From his bird's-eye view, he watched the plane smack into the ground. It exploded in a tremendous fireball. His night vision lost by the brightness of the burning aircraft, Gray couldn't see where he was heading. Suddenly, a tree was in his path. He stuck out his arms to try to cushion the collision, but his chest slammed into the thick trunk, knocking the wind out of him. He quickly unbuckled his harness and dropped about ten feet to the ground, landing painfully on his injured hip. Finding a hedge to crawl under, he lay there to catch his breath. As he had seen no other parachutes, he had no idea if anyone else had made it out of the plane.

Oddly, he now remembered the letter in the leg pocket of his jumpsuit and took it out. It was from Mickey. Airmen were warned not to fly with personal letters in the event they went down and were captured. But he had received it earlier that day, and he thought he'd have time during the fight to reread how excited she was about his imminent return home. He tore it up, dug a hole and buried it. Just when he thought he'd beaten the odds...

Still hours before sunrise, Gray knew he must have help soon for his wound or he'd bleed to death. Barely able to put weight on his leg, he struggled through a wooded area into a plowed field. Deciding to take a chance, he approached a small farmhouse. He guessed it was about 3 a.m. He knocked several times and waited. A middle-aged man came to the door, with a woman standing nervously behind him.

"Me American," Gray said. He raised his right hand and flew it through the air like a plane. Then he said, "Boom-boom," and let his hand flutter down. He turned to show his bloody backside. Alarmed, they invited him in and, seeing that he couldn't sit down, the woman spread out a sheet and blanket on the floor for him to lie on. The man left to get help and returned with a neighbor who spoke a little English. He looked at Gray's wound and shook his head. "Bad." He promised to return and drive him to a hospital for treatment.

An hour later, Gray was stretched out in the back of a panel truck en route to a French hospital about twenty-five miles away. When they arrived, he was taken into a room where he was examined and told he would go to the operating room right away. A German officer would be waiting to take him away after that, he was told. Gray said he understood. He was left with a young, pretty nurse. She

followed him into surgery and stayed with him the entire time as he was given shots of painkillers and the doctor cut, dug, cleaned and stitched. She held his hand, other times patting his cheek and even placing her cheek next to his. All the while, she spoke softly in the most delicious French, of which he didn't understand a word. It didn't matter one bit. He never knew her name but thought what a lovely stand-in she was for the nurse waiting for him at home.

Mickey's given name was Margaret, and she was a brown-eyed brunette nursing student at Emory University in Atlanta. They had met before the war when she came into the grocery store where Gray worked. When he went into the Army and was based on the East Coast, they saw a lot of each other. Things had turned serious and they talked of marriage, but when he received orders to go overseas they decided to wait. Since then, they had been writing faithfully to one another. His last letter to her was dated a week earlier, and, reflecting on it, he realized how dumb it had been to count his chickens before they hatched. *For the first time since I've been over here, I'm feeling close to finishing my tour and coming home. Does it make a difference to you what month we are married? I like June. But it may have to be July. And you better not change your mind about me.*

That same day he was being operated on in a French hospital, Mickey was writing him her latest letter. "My dearest Gray. This may seem silly to you, but I'm going to tell it anyway. One night this week I dreamed you had come home. I didn't know you were coming and I was down in the country at the lake, but you came down there. I could see just as plain as if you were there. One thing I noticed in particular you had your hair cut real short and I was heartbroken because your pretty wavy hair was gone. Anyway, it was a grand and glorious dream." She kissed it shut and posted it that afternoon, but it was a letter Gray never received.



Gray Hasty's fiancée, Margaret Long.

COURTESY OF THE LONG FAMILY

It turned out he was the first American flyer shot down in the area, and word spread throughout the hospital among the French doctors, nurses and staff. He was brought cookies and cubes of sugar, and when it was time to leave he was handed a sack of more baked goodies and a set of clean clothes. When he was

rolled down the corridor on a stretcher, people were lined up on both sides. Flowers and kisses were thrown at him all the way to the elevator. The U-shaped hospital was three stories, with outside corridors on each level overlooking a parking lot. When he was rolled to a waiting ambulance, he looked up. People were standing on every corridor, waving goodbye.

He was taken to a hospital staffed with Germans in Lyon, where he stayed two weeks. The patients were Russians and Germans; he was the only American. After that, he was taken to a hospital on the Seine River, where he stayed for another two weeks. The Americans were bombing that area heavily now, and many downed U.S. airmen were arriving horribly burned, wrapped head to toe in gauze like living mummies. As there was a shortage of beds, as soon as patients were able to travel they were discharged to make room in the wards.

Gray and fourteen other Americans were sent by train to Frankfurt, Germany. They were escorted by four German soldiers, including an English-speaking corporal. When the train pulled into a bombed-out station, one of the guards went to the stationmaster standing nearby to find transportation to the main station in the heart of town, where they had to transfer to another train. He was obviously upset by what he was told. When he came back, it was clear they would be walking.

Frankfurt was a panorama of damaged buildings and rubble. Almost nothing was left except shells of buildings. Gray couldn't conceive how people continued to live in makeshift shelters on slabs of concrete. As the POWs walked through razed neighborhoods, people yelled and spat at them, then started throwing rocks and chunks of concrete. This reception continued into the town square. It was the same square, the corporal told Gray ominously, where ten American flyers were hanged and their bodies burned the day before. *My God*. Back in England, Gray had heard rumors of German civilians carrying out brutal reprisals against downed airmen. And he had no reason to doubt the corporal, who had told them he was from Frankfurt and that his girlfriend still lived here.

Gray looked toward the station where they were headed and saw dozens of people waiting for them. An SS trooper was in the middle of the group, inciting them. The POWs had to walk through the crowd, but they didn't get far before the screaming mob started pushing, hitting and kicking not only the Americans

but the soldiers escorting them. Gray was slammed face-first into a wrought-iron fence and felt something graze past him. Spinning around, he saw it was the hobnailed jackboot of the SS trooper, which had just missed his bad hip.



Bombed-out Frankfurt, Germany, 1944.

U.S. ARMY SIGNAL CORPS

The corporal escorting them chambered a round in his submachine gun and pointed it straight at the SS trooper, then swung the barrel around, aiming at the front row of the unruly mob. He yelled something in German, and the crowd stopped pushing forward.

The corporal barked to the Americans, “Get over that fence!”

They all clambered over the six-foot barrier. Their escorts followed, and they rushed up the track to board a train.

When they arrived at a prisoner interrogation center, the Americans were placed in concrete cells, six or seven men in each one. They were not fed, and spent the night fitfully on the cold floor. In the morning, they were called out by name one at a time. Gray sat at a table across from a civilian interpreter whose mannerisms and horn-rimmed glasses pegged him as a teacher or professor.

“How are you?” the German asked in impeccable English.

Gray told him about his injuries, and about the mob in Frankfurt.

“Suppose we turn this around,” said the interpreter. “German planes bombing your cities daily the way you and the British are bombing and

destroying our cities. How would you or your family feel if a German plane was shot down and a crewman bailed out? What would you do?”

Gray did not answer. But he mused, *We did not start this terrible war.*

The interpreter asked a few questions that Gray did not answer about his military unit and mission. The interpreter acknowledged he was within his rights not to do so under the Geneva Convention. His capture, he was told, would be reported to the International Red Cross.

“Your family will soon know you are a prisoner of war. You will have your picture taken here and a prison number assigned. Then you will be transported to a Stalag Luft camp. Do you have any questions?”

Gray did have one question, although he didn’t expect the answer he got. “Could you tell me what’s going on in the war?”

“It happened this morning,” the interpreter said evenly. “What the whole world has been waiting to happen for a long time.”

Gray Hasty knew then that today was D-Day. The date: June 6, 1944.

¹ Postwar statistics revealed that tail gunners had the shortest life expectancy of any B-24 or B-17 crewman, with a median casualty rate of 46 percent.

NINE

ESCAPE AND EVASION

On March 30, 1944, a flight of nineteen B-24s from the U.S. Army's 5th Bombardment Group, Thirteenth Air Force, took off from Bougainville Island, New Guinea, on the first long-range high-altitude strike against a major Japanese airfield on Truk Atoll. The weather en route was the worst 2nd Lt. Sidney Simon had seen in months. He and the other navigators in the formation kept checking with one another during the 985-mile flight to make sure they agreed on their location and course over the featureless ocean.

When they broke into the clear twenty-five minutes from their target, only ten planes were left in the formation. The others had apparently become separated in the heavy weather and turned back. With good visibility at last, the remaining B-24s were able to hit their targets on Truk: hangars, buildings and parked aircraft. After the last bomb fell, they turned for home. That's when they were jumped by a swarm of enemy fighters.

Sid stood between the pilot and copilot, alerting the nose-turret and top-turret gunners over the interphone to incoming targets. He knew their .50-cal. machine guns splashed three Mitsubishi A6M Zeros for sure, but the enemy fighters had inflicted damage, too. With its rudder and aileron control cables severed, the B-24 skidded dangerously close to the other bombers. It was apparent their plane was a collision hazard, so they pulled out of the formation. Seeing the wounded straggler, the enemy swooped in with cannons blazing as the lone bomber dove for the protection of a cloud bank 5,000 feet below. By the time the Liberator emerged from the overcast, there were no signs of other aircraft, friendly or enemy.

Assessing the damage—critical control systems damaged, one engine out, the remaining engines burning more fuel than usual even as the wing tanks leaked

fuel—it was clear they wouldn’t make it all the way back to Bougainville. Hoping to get them as close as possible before they had to ditch at sea, Sid plotted their position every fifteen minutes and gave the pilot adjustments to their course as well as the latest coordinates to the radio operator in the event he could repair his shot-up transmitter.

The crew threw out equipment and gear to make the plane lighter so it would stay afloat on the sea longer. As they dropped precariously close to the water, all the men except the pilot and copilot were huddled together in the midsection, braced for impact with their packed parachutes as cushions. Belly flopping onto the wind-tossed sea, the plane plowed its nose underwater and flipped, breaking apart in several places. The wrecked fuselage began filling with seawater. Two rafts were released, and the men hurried to inflate them and collect food and potable water and other essentials for what might be a long stay on the ocean.

Sid assisted the injured pilot—bleeding from a bad hand wound—into the raft and administered first aid. The men were exhausted and most fell asleep within an hour. One of the rafts leaked and needed to be pumped up about every half hour. Sid took on that responsibility and stayed awake the entire night checking the measurements of the stars. By morning, he was able to tell the men how far they had drifted from where they went down. Given their location, the prospects of being seen by a convoy seemed good, Sid said, which helped keep everyone’s spirits up.

A week after receiving the War Department telegram that Sid was missing in action—but not yet the notification that he had “returned to duty”—Anna was surprised and greatly relieved to read about his rescue in the *New York World-Telegram*:

10 BOMBER CREWMEN ADRIFT 3 DAYS FIGHT SHARKS WITH OARS

After battling sharks with oars for three days while floating in the Pacific in three rubber boats, 10 crew members of a Liberator bomber of which Lt. Sidney Simon, 26, of Richmond Hill, Queens, was the navigator, were

recently rescued after drifting within 15 miles of a Jap-held island, the United Press reported today. After a 45-minute air battle with Zeroes over Moen Island, near Truk, machine gun bullets hit their gas tank and tore away their rudder controls, and they were obligated to pancake at sea. The plane sank in 13 minutes. Sharks bumped at the rubber boats but were driven off by Lt. Simon and the other unwounded men. Lt. Simon is one of two sons of Mrs. Annie Simon, a widow, of 118-04 107th Ave., Richmond Hills. His brother Murray, 23, is a pilot with the Army Air Forces in England.

The day after Sid received his mother's letter telling him about the article in the local paper, he wrote her back. "Mom, I was hoping you wouldn't learn all the details, thereby saving yourself a great deal of anxiety. I might as well start from the beginning." He told her about the mission, the attack by enemy planes and ditching at sea. "Not a very encouraging picture, is it? But I'm proud there wasn't a whimper or a moan from anyone. We just got busy." Once they were in the rafts, "We weren't really worried, because we knew where we were, and had food and water for a month. I figured it wouldn't be more than two weeks before we got picked up."

After they were picked up by a U.S. Navy ship, he wrote, "They couldn't do enough for us. We had steak and potatoes for breakfast, cold cokes all day, good books to read. They had men waiting on us hand and foot. What a time. I'll never forget it. It was a real South Pacific cruise. Don't worry about me, Mom. Take good care of yourself. Love, Sid."

Then, two weeks after receiving Sid's letter and days before Mother's Day, Anna received a Western Union telegram expressing the secretary of war's "deep regret that your son, Second Lieutenant Murray Simon, has been reported missing in action since 6 May over France. If further details or other information are received you will be promptly notified."

Living alone since the death of her second daughter a few months before the war, Anna, fifty-six, had long been known as the family's "stoic and strong" one. But the news about her youngest son was devastating. She had nearly lost Sid, and now Murray was missing. Unable to stay in an empty house that once was

so full of life, she put on a nice dress, did her makeup and took the train from Queens to Grand Central Station. Seated in the main concourse day after day, watching soldiers coming and going, she wept and prayed. Then prayed some more.

Murray Simon had stayed at the controls of the crippled plane as long as he could. Behind him, wind howled into the wrecked portions of the fuselage, whipping the flames into frantic coiling tentacles. With the cockpit filling with gas fumes, he tied off the control wheel and grabbed his parachute pack. From the narrow catwalk above the open bomb bay, he dropped into the night. The slipstream dragged him sideways and he fell for several seconds before pulling the rip cord that popped open his chute. As he floated earthward, he counted seven canopies gliding across the moonlit sky. *Thank God all the boys made it out.*



The Simon brothers, B-24 flyers Murray (left) and Sidney, went missing in different theaters of war weeks apart.

COURTESY OF THE SIMON FAMILY

At that instant, the plane exploded in a huge ball of fire.

Murray thought he was heading for an open field but sailed past it toward a wooded area. As the tops of the trees reached for him, he threw his arms up to protect his face and eyes. His canopy lodged in a tall tree, suspending him a foot off the ground. Unbuckling his harness, he dropped down. After a few hard tugs on the canopy, he gave up trying to dislodge it as they'd been trained to do in order to hide it. He took off running into the dark forest and kept running until his lungs ached.

When he stopped after about a mile, he listened to make sure he wasn't being followed. All was quiet. He opened a zippered pocket of his flying suit and took out his escape kit. He flipped open a nickel-plated brass compass the size of a quarter. They had crashed ten or fifteen miles northwest of Roanne, which was right in the middle of Nazi-occupied France. Although the border with Spain was hundreds of miles to the south, Murray knew his best bet was to head in that direction.

At first opportunity, he left the woods, the likeliest place the Germans would start searching. He moved cautiously through plowed fields and vineyards, skirting farmhouses to avoid barking dogs. About 3 a.m. he came to a country road lined with oaks and pines. It was easier walking, and he tried to stay in the shadows of the trees. After about two miles he thought he saw someone approaching from the opposite direction and rolled into a ditch. It was a false alarm, but the brush-covered gully seemed a good place to spend the rest of the night. He curled up and slept until daybreak. Chewing an energy-boosting Horlicks tablet from a tin, he practiced pronouncing a few common phrases on a French-language card. He knew his success in evading capture depended on finding people willing to risk their lives to help him.

About 7:30 a.m., a farmer came down the road pushing a cart filled with hay. Glancing toward the ditch, he was startled to see Murray.

Murray waved. "*Je suis Américain*," he said.

The farmer nodded but then shook his head vigorously. He was too afraid to help. Murray put his finger to his lips, imploring the man to keep quiet about his presence. The farmer nodded curtly and continued on.

Now that it was light out, Murray crawled farther along the ditch rather than return to the road. Workers in pairs were already in the adjacent fields, but he thought it unwise to approach more than one person. When an elderly man cycled by, he looked directly at Murray but pretended not to see him and pedaled on.

Murray had no way of knowing that the man rode directly to the two-story home of Dr. Jacques Madjar in the nearby village of Mably— population 3,000, with a military armory guarded by a contingent of German troops—to report what he had seen. Madjar, a former French medical officer who had connections

with the local resistance, had heard the plane crash during the night and stepped outside in time to see the light show in the sky. He hoped all the clamor might be the start of the rumored Allied invasion but was disappointed when no more planes flew overhead. A few hours later, he was informed that partisans had found an injured flyer, who was taken to the hospital. Now, hopping on his small motorbike, Madjar followed the man on the bicycle to where he had seen the *Américain* in the ditch, determined to find him before the Germans.

When they reached the ditch, Madjar sternly warned the old man to forget what he saw, and if he didn't and they had any troubles, his comrades in the resistance would pay him a visit. After the man pedaled away, the doctor approached the ditch, where Murray was watching them.

“*Avez-vous me cacher?*” Murray said in fractured French off the card. He was trying to say, “Will you hide me?” but it came out “Did you hide me?”



French civilians at the crash site of the Simon crew's B-24 the day after it was shot down on the morning of May 6, 1944.

CARPETBAGGERS HISTORY WEBSITE

The doctor—a foot shorter than Murray—scratched his head. “What?” he said in English, one of six languages he spoke. He put a hand on Murray's shoulder and beamed. “Don't be afraid, my friend. Wait here. I'll be back.” He helped Murray cover up in the ditch under brush and leaves.

Madjar returned an hour later with a potato sack containing a change of clothes: coveralls, sweater and a beret. Murray changed into them, and they put his flying gear in the sack and buried it in the ditch.

Madjar explained he had sent word to the local Maquis chief and they would wait at the doctor's house for help to arrive. He directed Murray to get on the back of the motorbike, warning him to keep quiet.

They weaved through back roads and passed a German sentinel who paid them no attention before they pulled up to the doctor's house and rushed inside. Madame Madjar, six months pregnant and with a nine-month-old baby in the house, served the pilot their last two eggs.

A local resistance chief named Charlet arrived in a few hours. He spoke no English, so the doctor translated. Murray wanted to know if there was any news of other men in his crew. Charlet told him about the wounded Graham Hasty being taken to the hospital. His partisans had been holding out hope for the Allied invasion, Charlet said, and he pressed Murray for some indication of when they could expect it to happen. Murray knew nothing official but didn't want to disappoint. He offered his best guess, which turned out to be a rather extraordinary prophecy.

"From the buildup I saw in England," he said, "I'd say in early June."

Charlet and Murray bicycled to his home, where the pilot was able to speak with Charlet's wife in broken German, thanks to growing up around his mother, who spoke Yiddish, a Germanic language. Charlet discussed resistance activity in the Roanne area, which he said was occupied by about 1,000 German troops. He explained that the local resistance needed more arms, ammunition and supplies. Partisans were often getting caught these days; few, he said, made it past a year. When the Gestapo caught them, they were tortured to reveal other names. Charlet said one of his men had his eyes gouged out and another had his head dunked in freezing water until he passed out; then he was revived and the torture continued. In the end, the Gestapo shot them both.

The next morning, Charlet and Murray took the train sixty miles south to Saint-Étienne, a city of more than 200,000 residents. The train was crowded with people, including German soldiers. Murray feigned sleep to prevent anyone from speaking to him, and Charlet handled their tickets with the conductor. When they arrived, Charlet handed Murray off to another partisan, Danny, who had bought two train tickets to Valence, seventy-five miles farther south. Caught up in a jostling crowd headed for the platform, Murray was behind Danny, who held both tickets and passed through the gate, continuing on for a short distance. When Murray came to the gate, he had no ticket to show the collector, who talked loudly in excited French. Not being able to answer any questions,

Murray rushed through the gate and caught up with Danny on the platform, where they quickly boarded the train. Seated in a packed compartment, Danny let it be known that his friend was a *sourd-muet* [deaf-mute] to forestall anyone from trying to converse with him. When they arrived in Valence, Danny took the pilot home, where he lived with his mother, who was waiting to cook for the hungry American.

Six days after he was shot down, Murray was taken to another safe house in Valence, where he met a man who could accompany him over the mountains into Spain. Introduced as Jean-Pierre, he was six foot two, rugged yet regal, with tanned skin and tailored clothes. His real name, which he told Murray, was Peter Ortiz. He was a captain in the U.S. Marine Corps with an unusual background. Born in New York City to a Swiss mother and a Spanish father, he was educated at the University of Grenoble in France and spoke ten languages, including Spanish, French, Italian, Portuguese, German and Arabic. Seeking adventure, he had joined the French Foreign Legion in the 1930s, serving in North Africa. After his discharge, he went to Hollywood and worked as a technical adviser on action films. When the U.S. entered the war, he joined the Marines and was sent to Morocco, where he conducted reconnaissance behind enemy lines. He joined the OSS in 1943, and in January 1944 parachuted into France to evaluate and train resistance groups.

Murray told Ortiz about the missions being flown by the Carpetbaggers, and the Marine was cheered to hear that U.S. planes were making increased drops because he knew how much the partisans needed the arms and supplies.

Ortiz said he had just been ordered to return to England via Spain. London had offered to arrange a guide to take him across the border into Spain, but with all the German spies and collaborators around, Ortiz preferred using his own trusted connections.

“Look, Murray, you can stay here, but you’ll likely be found and killed along with anyone hiding you,” said Ortiz, “or you can join me in getting back to London, which may result in both of us getting killed. You should know that I was betrayed three weeks ago and almost caught, and there’s a big reward on my head. We’ll both be wanted men.”

Not knowing when his next opportunity to leave might come, Murray didn't relish the idea of staying put. He liked Ortiz's directness and had a feeling this was the guy to throw in with to try to get back.

Almost overnight, the resistance in Valence provided Murray with a forged French ID card using his passport photo taken of him in civilian clothes at Harrington. He was now Maurice Simon. His real birth date of December 1, 1920, was used, but his new birthplace was Lyon, France.

A few days later, Ortiz picked up Murray in a long black car driven by a Frenchman, explaining they were heading to Lyon. German soldiers shouted "Heil Hitler" and saluted them as they drove through the town center, and Ortiz coolly waved back. As he did, he told Murray they were in a stolen Gestapo staff car—one of ten Ortiz and some partisans had taken from a military garage. The same group, Ortiz noted with some pride, had blown up no fewer than eighteen locomotives in German rail yards.

When they arrived in Lyon, they were dropped off and walked several blocks to a flat where a young woman, Louise, a courier for the resistance, cooked them lunch. Murray stayed for two days while Ortiz disappeared for long periods to make arrangements for their trip.

On May 16, Louise came back from the train station with two first-class tickets for Murray and Ortiz to Carcassonne in southern France. Before they started the three-hundred-mile trip, Ortiz told Murray that if anything arose on the train with French or German personnel, they would have to "handle it ourselves" and must not be separated or arrested. Murray had observed that Ortiz was unarmed except for a paratrooper's knife, which he had no doubt the big Marine would use if circumstances called for it.

When they arrived at the Carcassonne station, they avoided a pair of drunks trying to pick up French women. Ortiz pegged the obnoxious duo as Gestapo. Murray and Ortiz kept their distance from the pair and boarded a local train to Quillan, forty miles away. Located in the foothills of the Pyrenees, the town of a few thousand residents was surrounded by vineyards and fields of sunflowers, with snowcapped peaks in the distance. Ahead lay a high-mountain escape route through the central Pyrenees into Spain that had been chosen to avoid checkpoints and contact with German patrols.¹

When they stepped off the train, a man Ortiz knew directed them to wait at a nearby café. Their first guide soon showed up, a young French woman name Lucienne who lived in the mountains. She led them on foot through the woods for about six miles, slipping them unseen past a border guard station and through the village of Axat. They hiked another few miles to the small commune of Artigues, where they stopped at a canteen and were replenished with hot food and cold drink. After supper, Lucienne took them to a private home where they were to wait for the Spanish guides who would lead them over the Pyrenees.

After waiting two days, Ortiz grew impatient. He knew a local tobacco smuggler and appealed to him to help them get over the mountains. The smuggler, Martinez, who made his living making clandestine trips into Spain, agreed. They left the next morning at 4 a.m., with Martinez leading them through heavy woods and steep terrain. They hiked for twenty-four of the next twenty-nine hours. At 2 a.m. on May 19, they crossed into Andorra, a small, landlocked country in the eastern Pyrenees bordered by Spain and France, and checked into a small hotel.

The next day, they took a taxi a short distance to the Spanish frontier and hid in the hills until two new guides arrived to take them the rest of the way. They arrived in Barcelona on May 24. Not wanting to take a chance on being picked up by Spanish authorities, Murray and Ortiz went directly to the British consulate. Two days later they were on their way to Madrid, then flown to Gibraltar, a British fortress that guarded the entrance to the Mediterranean. Questioned by British civilian liaison officers, Murray was quarantined and treated like a prisoner for forty-eight hours until he was flown by military transport to London.

Arriving in England on June 2, Murray was sequestered in an aging Victorian hotel in downtown London. Hours of questioning followed, beginning in a small office with an OSS officer and a transcriber, then U.S. Army intelligence officers. Murray was asked to relate everything he remembered from his takeoff on the night of May 5 to his return through France and Spain. He went through his entire journey, complete with the names of locations and anyone who had

assisted him, including the many “helpers,” as Ortiz had called them, who had risked their lives to help a downed American pilot reach safety.

He filled out an “Escape and Evasion” report with the type of details that might be useful to other airmen shot down over France, and he drafted a handwritten statement. Soon, another Carpetbagger pilot showed up. Second Lt. Frederick Kelly arrived from Harrington to identify Murray, a security procedure to ensure the Germans didn’t use the identities of downed U.S. pilots to plant spies in Allied forces.

For three days, in between all the interrogations and paperwork, Murray remained totally isolated, and for a time could not call or write anyone, not even his mother to tell her he was okay. When he was at last done answering questions, he was allowed to ask one of his own: *What about the rest of my crew?*

Murray then learned he was the first one to return.

On the morning of June 21, 1944, a reporter for the *New York Post* knocked on Anna Simon’s door. The local paper had received an official press release stating that her son, Murray, was MIA over France. The War Department routinely sent such notifications to hometown papers, and the *Post* was seeking further information for a short article it planned to run.

The knock at the door was answered by a young man in uniform.

The reporter explained the reason for the visit.

The lieutenant smiled. “I’m Murray Simon. I just got home.”

Murray, who never returned to his squadron at Harrington but would spend the rest of the war training new pilots in the United States, had arrived in Washington, D.C., from London on a TWA flight the day before. He had taken the train to Grand Central Station and transferred to a local train to Queens, where his mother had been waiting at home for him since receiving his cablegram from England a few days before. But the first word that her prayers were answered had come in a telegram from the adjutant general a week earlier: AM PLEASED TO INFORM YOU YOUR SON SECOND LIEUTENANT MURRAY L SIMON RETURNED TO DUTY.

The reporter had found quite a different story than he expected.

Murray related what he could about his crash and the help he received from the resistance. The reporter also heard about Sid's recent rescue at sea, which Murray himself learned about from his mother only when he got home. A photographer showed up to take a picture of mother and son hugging in a reenactment of his arrival—Murray in his Army overcoat and holding his valise—to illustrate a feature story headlined: “Pilot Reported Missing over France, Tells How Underground Saved Him.” The article described Murray's escape from Nazi-occupied France after Sid's rescue as “the second piece of good fortune to come to the family.”

The photo of Anna embracing her youngest son was captioned:
“Her Anxious Vigil Is Over.”

I. Between 1940 and 1944, there were an estimated 33,000 successful escapes into Spain along the 270-mile length of the Pyrenean chain, which ran from the Bay of Biscay in the Atlantic Ocean to the Mediterranean Sea and acted as a natural border between France and Spain. The central Pyrenees included the highest summits of the range, with a maximum elevation of 11,168 feet.

TEN

THE RESISTANCE

The Simon crew bombardier, 1st Lt. John “Johnny” Mead, jumped from their crippled B-24 at about nine hundred feet. Landing in a pasture, he looked up to see the plane’s final plunge to the ground, resulting in a roiling fireball and explosion that reverberated across the nightscape.

Unhooking his chest harness, he gathered up the collapsed canopy and hid it with his chest harness and flying suit in the underbrush. He had on olive pants and a shirt under his leather jacket. He didn’t hear any voices and dared not call out for any of the crew because he had no idea how close the enemy might be. Having assisted with the navigation on the flight, he knew they had come down in the vicinity of Chenay-le-Châtel, twenty miles north of Roanne on the Loire River.

Johnny had known the plane was doomed when both wings caught fire. He struggled through the thick smoke filling the fuselage and helped several men jump from the bomb bay, two of whom were dazed and needed assistance to hook up their chest packs. Then he jumped. He had last seen Murray Simon and French Russell in the cockpit, struggling to keep the bomber in the air for the crew to jump, and had no idea if they had made it out in time.

The break of dawn found Johnny outside the village of Vivans, according to his silk escape map. He had walked four or five miles during the night. Unfortunately, he had not found any water to drink. Parched and hungry, he decided to try to find help at the first opportunity.

He observed a two-story farmhouse from a distance and after a while saw a man in overalls step out of the back door. Johnny made his move and approached. From thirty feet away, he waved hello.

The farmer seemed a bit rattled and didn’t say anything.

“I am American. American.”

The man beamed. “*Américain! Américain!*”

Whisked into the house, the exhausted airman was soon at the kitchen table being served slices of fresh-baked black bread and strong coffee. Afterward, he took out a pack of Lucky Strikes and lit up. The farmer, Jean-Celestin Pion, was delighted to smoke his first American cigarette given to him by the first American he had ever met.

Neither the farmer nor his wife spoke English.

Johnny took out a list of French phrases. He pointed to: “*L’ennemi est-il proche?*” [Is the enemy near?]

“*Non,*” said the farmer, smiling.

By now Johnny could hardly keep his eyes open. He was shown to the wine cellar, where there was a couch on which he could rest. When he awoke with a start a few hours later, the farmer was standing there with his daughter, Marinette, twenty-four, whom he had gone to get in the nearby village of Mably, where she worked. She spoke some English, and with the list of common phrases, he got across that he had been shot down and wanted to contact the resistance. She understood, and promised to return with someone who could help.

From a rather exotic French lineage, Johnny now wished he had learned the language when he was younger. His paternal grandmother, Claudia Victoria Thierry de Mauregard de-Ville d’Avray, known to her grandchildren as “Claudy,” delighted them by speaking French and telling colorful stories about their roots. Claudy claimed they descended from the first mayor of Versailles, who became Baron of Ville d’Avray. Serving as the first *valet de chambre* [chamber valet, a high-ranking court adviser], the baron resided in the luxurious apartments of Louis XVI, the last king of France before the 1789 revolution. After the king and queen were guillotined, the baron was arrested and died in prison.

Johnny was one of thirteen children born to devout Catholic parents in Jacksonville, Florida. It made for a crowded and animated dinner table, and a flock of young worshippers at catechism and filling the pews at St. Paul’s Church. After high school, he went to Notre Dame for a year before transferring

to the University of Florida, which he left before graduating for a chance to learn the marine insurance business in New Orleans.

To all who knew him, “Johnny” was a fitting boy-next-door moniker for the young man who had an abundance of warm charm and a winning smile. An inch over six feet and a trim 165 pounds, he had wavy blond hair, blue eyes, and spoke in a soft drawl as smooth as molasses. Not long after their meeting at a high school dance, he gave his heart to Dorothy Stallings, a brunette who had the humor and intelligence to match his own. They were easy and fun to be around, but there was nothing frivolous about either of them. Together, they had a plan. After he was established in business and she graduated from college, they would marry and start their life together. A Methodist, she would convert and they would raise their children Catholic. Then the war intruded.

In March 1942, Johnny, at age twenty-one, enlisted in the Army Air Corps rather than wait to be drafted. Eight months later he graduated from bombardier school and was commissioned a second lieutenant. With two weeks’ leave, he returned home to marry Dorothy in a small family ceremony. She was within a few weeks of obtaining her degree from Florida State College, and after their three-day honeymoon, she returned to Tallahassee to finish her classes and take final exams. They spent the next eighteen months living on the base at Cherry Point, North Carolina, before Johnny’s squadron went overseas in fall 1943 to fly anti-submarine patrols over the Bay of Biscay. A few months after that, they were flying Carpetbagger missions over France. The Simon crew’s ill-fated flight on May 5, 1944, was Johnny’s twenty-fifth combat mission.



Bombardier John "Johnny" Mead.

U.S. ARMY SIGNAL CORPS

For two days he was the guest of the Pion family. For his safety and theirs in the event a German or French Milice search party showed up, he stayed out of sight in an upper room, where his meals were brought to him. On the morning of the third day, Marinette returned with a stocky man who looked and spoke French. He also spoke English with a British accent and introduced himself as Victor. He asked a series of probing questions and seemed to be evaluating Johnny's responses as well as his demeanor. Only later did Johnny learn that the Germans sometimes planted impostors posing as airmen in an area where a plane went down to root out villagers and partisans willing to aid Allied pilots—marking the helpers for arrest and execution. After a long conversation that convinced Victor that Johnny wasn't an impostor, he identified himself as an SOE agent. His real name was Jean Coleman.

Over time, Johnny came to learn more about Coleman, who was born in Neuilly-sur-Seine, France, to an English banker and a Swiss mother. When the Germans invaded France in 1940, he escaped to England and enlisted in the Royal Navy. He was recruited by the SOE's French Section three years later. After several unsuccessful tries, he parachuted into France in fall 1943 to join the ACOLYTE resistance network, which had been started three months earlier by another SOE agent, Robert Lyon, code name "Gigi," who had been one of the first French Section recruits in August 1941. Upon Coleman's arrival, Lyon put him in charge of the Roanne branch of the network.

Coleman brought to the Pion farm some civilian clothes and an extra bicycle. Johnny changed out of his uniform and bade a farewell to his first but not last French hosts who risked their lives to help him. The two men set out by bicycle for Roanne with Coleman leading the way about one hundred feet in front. When they reached the outskirts of the city, which was garrisoned by nearly 2,000 German troops, Coleman dropped back alongside Johnny whenever they passed any Germans.

After winding through city streets, they stopped in front of a large building and went inside to the apartment of Joseph Genet and his wife. Their home was considered a safe house even though Genet was a *gendarme* employed by the local Vichy government. He was accepted as a German loyalist when in truth he was a key member of the resistance.

Johnny was told he would stay with the Genets until he could be spirited out of the country. But a few days later, a worried Coleman arrived back at the apartment with news that Robert Lyon had just been arrested by the Gestapo. That put Coleman in charge of ACOLYTE.¹

Coleman was shorthanded, he told Johnny, and wanted to know if the airman would consider staying to help organize the reception efforts for the containers being dropped almost every night and assist with distributing their contents to local partisans and training new recruits.

Johnny liked Coleman and knew he was doing important work. And he was very grateful for all the help he was receiving from the resistance. Further, given how soon the Allied landings on the French coast would likely take place, he thought staying to help the French in their fight to kick the Germans out of their country was a noble mission. He said yes to Coleman right away but added he would have to ask for permission. Coleman had a coded message sent by wireless to London on May 14 and received a response six days later. Using Johnny's serial number, it read: REGARDING 0733073. KEEP HIM.

Johnny received a new identity. Inside a worn billfold were forged papers identifying him as Jean Noel Dombret, a farmer. Everything inside the wallet was in order, including a bicycle-tax receipt and pictures of French pinup girls to distract any Germans checking the papers. Although he worked at learning enough conversational French so he could communicate with the partisans—most of whom did not speak English—he would never be fluent enough to get past a Vichy or even German checkpoint, hence his ID listed him as a deaf-mute.

After two weeks, Coleman moved Johnny to another safe house in a different neighborhood of Roanne. It was the residence of a French civil engineer named M. Bossanard, code-named "Babo," who was the Free French intelligence agent in charge of that district. Little did the Germans know that he regularly harbored Allied evaders until arrangements could be made to get them into an escape network that would take them out of France. Also living upstairs in his expansive flat were several Jews on the wanted list.

Six blocks away was a long-abandoned textile factory warehouse where the resistance brought munitions from the airdrops. The guns in the steel containers were packed in heavy grease. At the warehouse, they were removed, cleaned and

assembled prior to being distributed to partisan fighters. Almost daily, Johnny made the trip to and from the warehouse either by foot or bicycle, on the way passing German soldiers on the streets and even a German barracks. He carried a beat-up satchel that contained a copy of the French-language edition of *Signal*, a magazine published in more than twenty languages by the Germans as a propaganda tool in occupied countries. Under the magazine was a newspaper with a pistol concealed in its folds. If he was stopped, it was hoped a glance at the pro-Nazi magazine would allow the “deaf-mute” to be waved on. If that didn’t work, the pistol gave him at least a fighting chance to get away. As he was working with the resistance, he had no doubt that if he was captured the Gestapo would treat him as a spy, not a military POW, and the sentence would likely be death by execution.

The ACOLYTE network was engaged in hit-and-run acts of sabotage while waiting to strike bigger blows against the Germans once the Allied armies landed in France. To be prepared for the bigger fight, they were receiving increased airdrops at multiple locations. From his experience pinpointing drop zones from the air, Johnny knew how to best position the four signal lights in a field so they could be spotted by an aircraft.

On the night of May 28, 1944, he took a group of volunteers to the ACOLYTE 6A drop zone northwest of Roanne. The landing field had been used successfully three other times, Johnny was told, and there was a farmhouse a mile away where everything could be taken and sorted out until it could be safely moved into Roanne.

Arriving two hours early for the 2 a.m. drop, he dispersed six men with tommy guns and grenades as guards around the drop zone from a half mile away and stationed three more lookouts a quarter mile away. Positioning the lights and waiting with him in the field were a dozen partisans ready to collect the containers and load them into oxcarts.

Piloting the B-24 headed to ACOLYTE 6A that night was one of the original Carpetbaggers, 1st Lt. Jack H. Munn, twenty-six, of Los Angeles, California. It was his crew’s seventeenth combat mission. Loaded into the bomb bays were a dozen containers, and the dispatcher had eight smaller packages without parachutes that he was to toss out the Joe Hole.

Set to handle the S-phone communications from the plane to the party on the ground was the radio operator, T/Sgt. Clarence H. Brown, twenty-seven, of Cleveland, Georgia. At about 2 a.m., when they were within a few miles of the drop zone, Brown established contact with the partisans. Most of the ones he had talked to on other missions spoke very little English, and the English they did speak was heavily accented and difficult to understand. But tonight whoever was on the other end was clearly not French.

“Are you British or American?” the voice from the ground asked the radioman.

Being from the heart of Dixie, Brown knew a drawl when he heard one. To tease his fellow southerner, he said, “Neither. We’re Yankees.”

“Who’s the pilot?”

“Lieutenant Munn.”

“Well, I’ll be damned. Tell Jack hello. Tell everybody hello.”

“Who the hell is this?”

“This is Johnny Mead!”

Brown knew the entire Simon crew were MIA since not returning from their mission three weeks earlier. *If Mead had made it, did that mean the rest of the crew was okay?*

Johnny said he didn’t know about everyone in his crew, but some were “perfectly all right.” For security reasons, he gave no names.

Johnny reported they could now hear the engines of the B-24, and said the signal lights were lit—three white lights and a red light flashing the Morse code for the letter “P” (dot-dash-dash-dot). Brown confirmed they saw the lights and would start their run-in for the drop. Johnny gave him the wind speed and direction, and said they were standing by.

On a single pass, the containers and packages went out.

Johnny reported a few minutes later: “Good drop!”

“Johnny, this is Jack!”

He was surprised to hear Jack Munn on the S-phone now. He couldn’t give the pilot any details about his own travels or activities, but Johnny did ask the pilot to take a message back to Harrington.

“Tell Colonel Heflin the boys are doing a good job!”

By the time all the packages, containers and parachutes were gathered up in the field, then loaded into the carts under piles of straw, it was beginning to get light outside, a dangerous time to be on rural roads.

Johnny Mead, the only Carpetbagger in the war to be officially detached from the Army Air Forces to become a member of the French resistance, rode in a line of carts loaded with containers, packages and parachutes. On the seat next to him was a Sten submachine gun.

That same month, a prominent member of the French resistance showed up at Harrington. Paul Rivière had just been exfiltrated from France to England on an RAF Lysander and was now serving as a liaison officer for de Gaulle's French Forces of the Interior (FFI) in London. Born in Montagny, Rivière had been wounded in action at Pont de Genne in June 1940. The German columns advancing south across France in the area of Saumur—thirty-five miles west of Tours—totaled more than 10,000 motorized troops, 150 tanks or armored cars and 300 artillery pieces. The French force comprised 800 younger cadets from the cavalry school at Cadets de Saumur who had started their classes only months earlier (older cadets had already left to serve as junior officers in the army). The only officers remaining were the instructors, one of whom was Rivière. The outnumbered cadets had two dozen armored vehicles and no artillery but organized a defense along the Loire River, covering four bridges and a front twenty-five miles wide. For three days they held off the Germans, with heavy casualties inflicted on both sides. When the cadets withdrew and Saumur was finally entered, the German commander praised the resistance of the students. As the three-day battle occurred after the national message by Marshal Pétain calling for the end of all fighting and France's capitulation to Hitler, the Battle of Saumur is often considered one of the first acts of the French resistance.

Only days after his return to England, Rivière came to brief the Carpetbagger crews on the resistance. The crews not flying that day crowded into a large, smoke-filled hall. The French patriot was escorted to the podium by Col. Heflin, who introduced him as a resistance organizer who ran, "from the French end,"

the airdrops in the Haute-Savoie department of south-central France and was a “true heroic figure in the anti-Nazi struggle.” He also introduced a French-speaking American captain from the London office of the OSS who would act as interpreter when needed. Heflin explained that the presentation was to be in the form of questions and answers, then he sat down in the front row.

To the flyers who were risking their lives nightly to deliver munitions and supplies to the Maquis, Rivière, now a colonel in the FFI, did not look like a famed resistance fighter. Short and slight, he wore horn-rimmed spectacles that gave him the look of a schoolmaster, which he was before the war. In his answers, he showed that he wasn’t here for public relations but to provide a complete and honest picture of what was happening on the ground in France.

The questions from the floor came quickly and easily.

“How far away does the reception party recognize our aircraft?”

The planes were heard and recognized two or three minutes before they actually appeared overhead.

“When are the reception lights usually turned on?”

When the aircraft were first heard. Not before for fear of being spotted by an enemy patrol. Rivière added that on most moonlit nights the aircraft were clearly recognizable.

“How many people are needed at a drop zone?”

Most reception committees were at least twenty-five men for one standard drop of twelve containers.

“How is our accuracy?”

It depended on the altitude from which they made the drop and on the force of the winds. It was best to make the drop from a height of four hundred feet. This usually produced very accurate results. A drop made from a higher altitude could go astray.

“How close might the Germans be to a drop zone?”

At times they were on the spot before the parachutes even hit the ground.

“How much of what is dropped reaches the resistance?”

Counting what the Germans seized at or near the drop zones, as well as what they later confiscated on the roads and elsewhere, the partisans in Rivière’s

group ended up with 60 to 70 percent, which, he assured the flyers with a sly smile, “is put to excellent use.”

The answer was a reminder that these weren’t routine supply missions. They were dropping matériel hundreds of miles behind enemy lines to partisans under constant pressure of being discovered. It was dangerous work on the ground as well as in the air.

If a reception committee was detected by a large force of Germans or French Milice, the two groups fought it out. But most enemy patrols were only a few men, and they usually called up reinforcements before making a move. That delay worked to the benefit of the partisans.

Rivière told a story of one of his reception parties being detected by a German patrol. However, a large armed guard of partisans was in evidence protecting the drop zone, so the patrol withdrew while reinforcements were sent for and brought up. By the time they arrived, the operation had been successfully completed and not a soul was to be found in the field. In the event of such detection, a drop zone became unusable for a time, he added. But partisans maintained a constant watch on the field, observing enemy activity in the area and reporting whether or not a location was ready for use again.

Questions now shifted to a topic close to the hearts of the crews: the best escape and evasion procedures for downed airmen in France.

“Is it easier to find help in some areas than others?”

Yes. Some districts had more German collaborators and were more dangerous. If a downed airman needed help, he should approach working people and peasants rather than the well-to-do. Priests had proven to be helpful, too. Always approach a person who was alone, not a group. Some would hide flyers for a night and ask them to leave in the morning because they were afraid of being exposed to the Gestapo.

“Is it best to remain hidden for a couple of days or to move immediately and rapidly away?”

It was definitely best to get away from the scene. The Germans always made an immediate search of an area where there had been a plane crash.

“Is it better to walk toward Switzerland or Spain?”

Both were extremely difficult without expert knowledge of the terrain. Rivière drew laughs with the wry observation that traveling in the direction of Switzerland could lead only to internment by the Swiss if they made it, while traveling in the direction toward Spain, if one made it there, could mean a “more or less prompt return to England.” [II](#)

“Is it possible to put up a fight if we’re about to be captured?”

Not likely. Usually, arrests of Allied flyers were made by two members of a patrol, while others remained hidden in the bushes.

“Do German patrols wander off beaten paths very much?”

No, they stuck primarily to well-defined paths. In fact—here Rivière smiled that smile again—people seen on the road at night could safely be assumed to be either German patrols or French resistance.

Several questions were asked about the morale of German troops.

“Not good,” said Rivière, “but they will fight.” He added that SS troops were a higher caliber as to intelligence and morale, but the ordinary German soldier was quite unimaginative and capable of doing only what he was directed to do.

The resistance leader related a story of an encounter he had with Germans. He was driving a car taking 18 million francs to be distributed to partisan groups. It was the dead of winter and the road conditions were extremely icy. The car went into a skid and ended up coming to rest with its rear tires in a ditch. He got out and flagged down the next car, which he was startled to find carrying a German captain and two sergeants. The captain immediately ordered the two sergeants to attach a rope to the front bumper of the Frenchman’s car and haul it out with their own car. When the first effort failed, the officer ordered his men to put their shoulders into the job to get the car out of the ditch. After they finished tugging and pushing, the car was back on the road. “Well, now,” the officer said, “aren’t you glad we Germans are in France?” To which Rivière, who was working very hard to kill as many Germans as possible, answered with expected reverence, “*Oh, oui, Capitaine!*”

After answering their questions, Rivière told the Carpetbaggers that the reception committees throughout France waited eagerly every night for their planes. Men and women volunteers arrived at the drop zone an hour or two before the scheduled drop and remained until the last possible minute, often not

returning home until close to sunrise. They came back any number of nights necessary to receive what they needed to liberate France, and “every one of them works on their farm or at a full-time job.”

When the session ended, the Carpetbaggers applauded the man before them who so compellingly represented the face of the resistance. They stood at attention as the Maquis chief departed the hall.

“Everyone was deeply impressed,” one flyer later wrote, “by the vivid evidence presented as to the worth and importance of our mission.”

Eight weeks later, Paul Rivière returned to help liberate France with two other resistance leaders and an American wireless operator. They parachuted from a Carpetbagger plane piloted by Cliff Heflin, landing near the community of Rigny-sur-Arroux, northeast of the city of Clermont-Ferrand in central France. From there, they joined a clandestine group distributing arms, munitions and money across northern France.

I. Robert Lyon was arrested by the Gestapo on May 10, 1944, and taken to Montluc prison. Nine days later, during his transfer to Paris for further interrogation, Lyon escaped by jumping from a moving train as it went through Villeneuve-Saint-Georges. He took refuge with partisan friends in Tournan-en-Brie, where he received new identity papers. On June 5, the day before the Allied landings at Normandy, Lyon resumed command of the ACOLYTE network.

II. Switzerland forcibly defended its neutrality. This defense included rare instances of shooting down both Axis and Allied planes that penetrated Swiss airspace and interning any military personnel from either side who entered Swiss territory. Some U.S. aircraft—damaged or low on fuel—that could not make it back to their base landed in Switzerland. About 1,500 U.S. airmen were interned in Switzerland during the war.

ELEVEN

D-DAY

At 8 p.m. on June 5, 1944, the first four notes of Beethoven's Fifth Symphony sounded across the BBC airwaves from a London studio. The familiar notes were played by lower strings and clarinets in GGGF—short-short-short-long—which converted to dot-dot-dot-dash in Morse code for the letter “V,” as in Churchill's ubiquitous “V for Victory” sign.

The prelude marked the start of the evening broadcast of *Radio Londres* [Radio London], a French-language program produced since 1940 by de Gaulle's Free French that aired up to five hours daily to counter the drumbeat of propaganda by the Nazi-controlled Radio Paris and to send vital military messages to resistance networks in France.

The broadcast opened with: “*Ici Londres! Les Français parlent aux Français.*” [This is London! The French speak to the French.] Next, before the regular programming, comprising patriotic appeals, sketches and music, came this announcement: “*Avant de commencer, veuillez écouter quelques messages personnels.*” [Before we begin, please listen to some personal messages.] What followed were more than a hundred seemingly nonsensical phrases: “Jean has a long mustache.” “The carrots are cooked.” “The crocodile is thirsty.” “I wish I was by the seaside at sunset.”

Buried among that evening's messages—for which codebooks were required to understand their meanings—were two parts of the first stanza of Paul Verlaine's poem “*Chanson d'automne*” [“Autumn Song”]. This was the message that partisans had been waiting to hear. The first part, *Les sanglots longs des violons de l'automne* [the long sobs of violins of autumn] indicated that the Allied invasion of France would take place within twenty-four hours. The second part, *Blessent mon coeur d'une langueur monotone* [wound my heart with

a monotonous languor] called on partisans to strike at targets they had already been assigned, such as communications lines, railways and bridges used by the German military.

In the wee hours before some 133,000 Allied troops waded ashore at Normandy on D-Day, more than a thousand sabotage acts were carried out using tons of high explosives parachuted to them for this very day.

At Harrington Airfield, only two of the eleven crews flying on the night of June 5 were scheduled for missions in France. The rest were to make drops to the resistance in Belgium, which had been occupied by German forces since 1940. That most of the night's flights were to Belgium surprised the Carpetbaggers, given that dropping matériel into France had been a priority for months.¹

The briefing for the two crews headed to France was different, too. They did not attend the regular afternoon briefing, during which the nine other crews were ordered to avoid the French coast and fly a direct route from England to Belgium. The two France-bound crews had their own separate briefing by intelligence officers with only the command pilot, navigator and bombardier present. After learning the route they were to take to France—different than they had ever done before—they were told that no matter what happened to the airplane over France, even an in-flight emergency, they were *not* to fly back over the Channel between the Cherbourg Peninsula and the Port of Le Havre, the shortest route home.

To 1st Lt. Joseph P. Cox of Binghamton, New York, a tall and square-shouldered navigator still several months shy of his twenty-first birthday, it was obvious something big was up, but he knew better than to speculate aloud. Following dinner and after being handed their escape kits designed for France, Cox and the rest of the crew of “Cookie,” as their Liberator under the command of pilot Capt. John T. Kelly was named, took off shortly before 10:30 p.m. The weather had been breezy and mixed all day across the British Isles, with intermittent sunshine and showers as a cold front cleared.

Cox had calculated the course for the unusual route they were to follow. After takeoff, they headed down to Land's End, on the southwest tip of England

—a distance of 240 miles—which kept them from flying over any of the busy ports on the island’s east coast. Normally, they turned east far earlier and started across the Channel toward France, but not tonight. As they flew over the Bristol-Bath area, the tail gunner reported a “swarm of aircraft” approaching from the rear out of the north. Before long everyone could see the moonlit formations of RAF Lancaster and Halifax bombers filling the sky above them, also heading south. Customarily, the RAF formations flew east toward the Channel.

Upon reaching Land’s End, the lone B-24 turned to the southeast. Cox kept them on a course to skirt the German-occupied islands of Guernsey and Jersey, but not close enough to be a target for enemy antiaircraft artillery fire. Through gaps in the clouds below he noticed a fair amount of wake on the sea, and the winds aloft were at times blustery.

As they drew near to the coast, bright orange and purple explosions were visible to the east. From the nose compartment, Cox at first thought he was seeing large flares going off in the night sky. Except they weren’t flares, he realized, but large bombs—10,000-pound blockbusters, he guessed—detonating on the opposite side of the Cherbourg Peninsula. The navigator knew that stretch of coastline. *Why*, he wondered, *are they pounding miles of deserted Normandy beaches tonight?* [II](#)

They crossed into French airspace forty miles south of Cherbourg and continued another fifty miles east toward the small town of Mayenne. At forty-five minutes past midnight, Cox informed Kelly they were nearing the target, although they couldn’t see below them due to unbroken cloud cover, which the meteorologist had told them to expect. Trusting his navigator, Kelly started descending through the muck and they broke into the clear just under 2,000 feet. Cox had hit it on the nose because they immediately saw the signal lights, including a red one flashing dot-dash for the letter “A,” the correct code that night for SCIENTIST 95.

The SCIENTIST circuit had once been among the largest resistance networks in central France, operating from Paris to the Pyrenees with more than 10,000 members. But it had grown too fast and too large for its own good, and in 1943, infiltrated by spies and collaborators, many of its leaders were arrested and its arms depots found. Its organizer, Claude de Baissac, thirty-six, born in

Mauritius to well-to-do French parents and raised in Paris, had made his way out of France and to England with his older sister, Lise. They had both been recruited by the SOE in 1941. Claude then parachuted back into France in February 1944 to revive SCIENTIST, and Lise, who had worked for him previously as a courier, followed a month later. Under Claude's exacting leadership, SCIENTIST had again become an active circuit, especially in the Orne and Calvados regions, where he armed and trained volunteers for sabotage action designed to demoralize the Germans and delay their troop movements after the D-Day landings.

Dropping down to 425 feet, the B-24, flying parallel to the signal lights, released its dozen containers on the first pass. They had to pull up quickly due to a low ridge running perpendicular to the drop zone. They circled for another pass to release the other packages, which they did even lower at 370 feet, and again pulled up steeply to avoid the ground. Not more than ninety seconds later the bombardier reported a single-engine fighter crossing in front of them. The gunners in the tail and top turret were ready to open fire if necessary, but if it was a Jerry he either didn't see the black bomber or had more important business elsewhere, because his course didn't change and he soon disappeared.

They flew the prescribed route out of France, past the islands of Guernsey and Jersey, and at Land's End turned north for home. At that point, the radio operator came over the radiotelephone to say he had never heard all the different call signs he had been listening to that night. As they got closer to the populated areas, they saw numerous air bases lit up and planes circling with their landing lights on, all of which were against England's strict blackout rules.

"Boys, I think the invasion is probably on," Kelly told the crew.

But it wasn't until they landed at Harrington at 3:30 a.m. and walked into the debriefing room that they knew for sure. When they learned that the landings were at Normandy, it made sense to Cox why they had to take the circuitous route in and out of France. The Channel was filled with ships steaming from the British ports of embarkation for the invasion beaches on the other side of the Cherbourg Peninsula, between the ports of Cherbourg and Le Havre.

Normally, a returning Carpetbagger crew hit their racks for needed shut-eye after breakfast following their debriefing. But the Kelly crew was too excited to sleep, and they all stayed up—as did the other returning crews—to hear any updates about the landings in France.

Shortly after noon, Churchill's D-Day message was aired by the BBC, his familiar voice raspy but soaring in elocution. "During the night and the early hours of this morning, the first of the series of landings in force upon the European Continent has taken place. But all this, although a valuable first step—a vital and essential first step—gives no indication of what may be the course of the battle in the next days and weeks, because the enemy will now probably endeavor to concentrate on this area, and in that event the heavy fighting will soon begin and will continue without end, as we can push troops in and he can bring other troops up. It is, therefore, a most serious time that we enter upon. Thank God we enter it with our great Allies all in good heart and all in good friendship."

On the eve of the Normandy landings, Violette Szabo—as determined as ever to avenge the death of her French Foreign Legion husband, Etienne—was scheduled to leave for her second secret mission to France.

On her first mission two months earlier, she flew to France on a Lysander with Philippe Liewer, thirty-three, a Paris-born French journalist turned SOE agent being sent back to determine if the resistance circuit he had organized a year ago could be revived. Under his leadership, the SALESMAN circuit—operating between Rouen and Le Havre—had sabotaged electrical, railway and factory targets, and even sank a nine-hundred-ton minesweeper in a harbor with a three-pound charge that blew a five-foot hole in its hull. Liewer had returned to England in late 1943 to give an update on resistance activity in Normandy. When reports reached London of serious Gestapo penetration of his circuit in his absence, Liewer volunteered to return to investigate and reorganize the group. Violette went as his courier. After a bumpy landing in a pasture, they made their way by bus to Paris, where they settled in a safe house. Violette was shocked by how much Paris had changed since the prewar days, with hideous

swastika banners marring the most beautiful facades, the streets filled with men in Wehrmacht uniforms, and the sight of Jews of all ages forced to wear ugly yellow stars in public.

SOE had forbidden Liewer from showing his face in Rouen until he knew the situation there, and directed Violette to be his eyes and ears and travel to the city to assess the damage to SALESMAN. Boarding a train at Gare du Nord in the heart of Paris, she accepted a German major's offer to sit in the officers' compartment, where a group of Wehrmacht officers plied her with chocolate and cigarettes. ("It was an unhopd-for piece of luck to travel in total safety," she later explained. "No one asked to see my papers. But on arriving, it proved difficult to distance myself from my admirer. I promised to call him. He's still waiting.") She returned to Paris three weeks later to report that Rouen was dangerously full of inquisitive Germans, including teams of leather-jacketed Gestapo; hundreds of arrests had been made, and almost all of Liewer's friends seemed to have vanished. Posters around the city advertised a sizable reward for information leading to Liewer's arrest. SALESMAN was shattered. A Lysander brought the two agents back to England after only three weeks.



Violette Szabo, who became an SOE secret agent to avenge the death of her French Legionnaire husband.

WIKIPEDIA COMMONS

Having proven herself to be capable and resourceful, Violette was offered a second mission, which she quickly accepted. She was again the courier for Liewer, who was tasked with forming a new circuit, SALESMAN II, around Limoges in southwest-central France. On June 5, Violette, Liewer and two other agents—Jean-Claude Guiet, an American wireless operator, and Frenchman Robert “Bob” Maloubier, a weapons and demolitions expert—boarded an RAF Lancaster at Tempsford Airfield. Although their drop zone was located by the crew, no recognition signal was seen on the ground, and the plane returned with the agents aboard.

Guiet, whose parents headed the French department at Smith College, was a handsome Harvard graduate personally recruited for the OSS by its director, William “Wild Bill” Donovan. Guiet spent his childhood summers in France and spoke the language like a native. He was fresh-faced, with gleaming white teeth. In spite of his age—not yet twenty-one—he was a veteran of parachute jumps into France. In fact, the aborted mission was his fifth flight in a plane, but only his first landing.



French-born SOE agent Robert “Bob” Maloubier, a weapons and demolition expert who parachuted into France with Violette Szabo on the night of June 7, 1944.

SPECIAL FORCES ROLL OF HONOUR



American OSS wireless operator Jean Guiet, who parachuted into France with Violette Szabo and weapons expert Bob Maloubier.

COURTESY OF THE GUIET FAMILY

On the clear and chilly evening of June 7, the four agents arrived at Harrington for their next attempt, this time to try their luck with the American Carpetbaggers. After the letdown of their aborted mission, they agreed to insist on jumping even if there were no signal lights visible—what was known as a “blind jump,” not normally done because they could find themselves landing in the midst of waiting German or Milice forces. They hoped for better results with the U.S. flyers, although Liewer considered the Yanks “tenderfeet” because they had been doing clandestine parachute drops for only six months.

“Just hope they don’t let us out over the Alps,” he moaned.

“Don’t cry,” Violette said. “It’s a miracle we’re here!”

She was right, as they were all lucky to be alive after what had happened that morning. Spending their second idle day waiting at Hazells Hall, a seventeenth-

century manor on an estate taken over by the military, the agents were playing tennis doubles when the net suddenly disintegrated in an explosion that enveloped them in an acrid reddish cloud. An auxiliary gas tank had fallen off a fighter plane as it passed overhead and landed in their midst. Anyone standing a few yards closer to the net would have been killed. They were incredulous. Here they were, waiting to drop behind enemy lines, and they could have died playing tennis in Bedfordshire? “How about Ping-Pong?” Maloubier suggested.

Violette had the opportunity to see her two-year-old daughter, Tania, who was brought to the manor. She nestled Tania’s head in the crux of her shoulder and hugged her tightly. In the short time they spent together that day, the toddler seldom left her mother’s side. She was a little doll, hair done the English way to shake like small bells. Bob Maloubier noticed that every man who bounced the little girl up and down on his knee and gave her sweets she called “Papa.” Those were the only times Violette’s gaze looked melancholy during Tania’s visit.

At Harrington, the agents, all of whom knew the drill by now, went to the dressing hut to suit up. Their SOE escort officer was Vera Atkins, Maurice Buckmaster’s assistant from Orchard Court, who made it a point to accompany every female agent to the airfield before a mission. Atkins was one of the SOE leaders who had initially questioned whether Violette had what it took to be an agent, but those doubts had long since been dispelled. Violette had on a pair of white marguerite daisy earrings she had bought in Paris on her last mission, and they added to her natural luminescence, thought Atkins, who later recalled, “I had never seen her look more beautiful.”

Atkins rode with the agents out to the darkened flight line. Getting out of the car with them, she watched Violette zip up her flying overalls to the neck, adjust her parachute pack, shake loose her hair before donning the crash helmet she’d been given for the jump and, with a wave and smile, boost herself up through the Joe Hole and into the hulking bomber.

The plane’s dispatcher, Sgt. James W. Hall, twenty-two, of Sedalia, Missouri, had lined up empty ammo boxes for the agents to sit on near the Joe Hole, which he now covered with a sheet of plywood. Visible in the bomb bay were a dozen containers lined up like racks of bombs.

In the cockpit, pilot 1st Lt. Marvin Fenster, twenty-three, of Van Nuys, California, was finishing up the preflight checklist with the copilot, 1st Lt. Richard A. Warn, who was the ninth copilot Fenster had flown with over the course of his crew's twenty-three missions. His first copilot, with whom they had trained back in the States, asked to be removed from flight status after their second nighttime mission over France, during which they had to take sudden, stomach-churning evasive action to avoid flak. Evading antiaircraft fire was all about constant changes of direction and varying altitude without losing speed, as a slow-flying plane on a straight course made an easy target for ground gunners. Fenster didn't try to talk his copilot out of his request to be grounded. How could he? A B-24 cockpit was no place for any man who had lost his nerve. The rattled officer reported to the flight surgeon and was sent to a medical unit for further evaluation. He never flew with the Carpetbaggers again. Since then, Fenster had flown with a series of "newbie" pilots who needed one or two missions with an experienced pilot before taking their own crews into combat.

The big bomber lumbered down the runway at 10:24 p.m. and rose begrudgingly into the air, shaking and rattling. This night there were no prohibitions against heading eastward right after takeoff, and they were soon heading out over the Channel, riding through rain squalls.

Violette suggested a game of Pontoon—the British version of Twenty-One—and took out a deck of cards from one of the pockets in her overalls. The game dragged on because the cards kept sliding all over the place whenever the aircraft swayed, which was often. Serving as the banker, she won most of the hands, as usual.

About 1:30 a.m., the plane reduced speed, started descending and suddenly veered to the left, then into a much steeper turn.

The dispatcher gave a thumbs-up, but that wasn't enough for Liewer, who headed to the cockpit. "Going for news!" he yelled.

He returned a few minutes later wearing a big grin.

"Kit up!" he shouted. "They've got the DZ and beacons!"

The cover came off the Joe Hole. The dispatcher said that two of them would go out on the first pass, as would the containers, and the other two on a second pass. The agents had already decided their order of jump. Violette insisted on

ladies first, so she and Liewer went one-two, and Maloubier and Guiet with his wireless set jumped on the second pass.

All day Violette had been humming the Mills Brothers tune “I’ll Be Around.” Now, hanging under the stars beneath a fully opened canopy, she was tempted to start crooning but thought better of it in the event there were enemy patrols around.

Glancing down, she was astonished to see a large body of water below. The Americans had dropped them over a lake! She tried to recall everything she was supposed to do to keep from drowning. On contact with the surface, unbuckle the harness, get away from the canopy and shroud lines so they didn’t pull her under—she wasn’t able to think of anything else before she was swallowed up. Not by water but by tall wheat stalks that, swaying in the breeze, had looked like waves.

The Fenster crew had dropped them right on target, near Sussac, a village about thirty miles from Limoges. Swarthy men wearing red scarves, shoulder holsters and bands of cartridges appeared out of nowhere, helping Violette and the rest of the team hide their parachutes, while others spread out in the field to find all the containers. The agents were taken to a line of waiting cars, and they took off in a cloud of dust, racing bumper-to-bumper at breakneck speeds on a winding road, lights blazing, tires howling, gears clashing. Coming out of a final corkscrew turn in a semi-controlled skid, they squealed to a stop in front of a store.

A smiling, middle-aged woman in an apron stepped out of the grocery. “*Bienvenue à Sussac! Je suis Madame Ribiéras. Tu loges chez moi.*” [Welcome to Sussac! I am Madame Ribiéras. You’re lodging at my place.]

A crowd of Frenchmen followed the agents into the store, and Violette disappeared briefly. When she returned, her baggy overalls were gone, replaced by a casual suit. “As if emerging from a chrysalis,” Bob Maloubier observed, “she was a hit” with every man in the room.

Jean Claude Guiet threw an antenna across a row of shelves, opened up his radio set and keyed a coded message to London informing them of their safe arrival.

Three days later, Violette was set to meet with the head of a Maquis group at his headquarters in Pompadour, fifty miles to the south. It had been arranged for her to be driven partway by Jacques Dufour of the STATIONER circuit, and then she would bicycle the rest of the way.

The night before, Liewer questioned Dufour about the route he planned to take, which was the main north–south road from Toulouse to Paris. He asked if Dufour was certain the Germans weren't using it.

"Affirmative, *mon commandant*!" exclaimed Dufour. "I often cross Route 20 through Salon-la-Tour, which straddles it. It's my hometown, born there, all the inhabitants know me! Any hitches, they'd warn me."

"Should you do a quick reconnaissance first?" Liewer asked.

Liewer looked a bit soft but was far from it even as he was given to indulging in rich French fare whenever he had the opportunity. He had a round forehead made larger by a receding hairline and pale blue penetrating eyes that made people feel as if he could see through them.

"Useless! The Fritz haven't risked going there for months." Dufour went on to explain he had a network of friendly telephone operators in the area who sounded the alarm at any sign of Germans or Milice.

Dufour struck Liewer as a bit of a hothead. But he was a former French policeman, and he knew the area well and had lots of contacts.

"Fine," Liewer said. "But don't drive like the mad buggers who picked us up. Don't bring Violette back to me rolled in a tarpaulin!"

At 6 a.m., cup of coffee in hand, Violette struck a playful pose in a gabardine suit—back arched, legs akimbo—for Liewer and Guiet. "Less practical than trousers for running in Maquis country," she admitted, "but French women don't wear trousers and I'd only draw attention."

"Don't worry, you'll be a sensation in Pompadour," said a smiling Liewer, who planned to look for isolated countryside houses the team could move to because their current lodging was much too public.

Glaring unblinkingly at Dufour, Liewer used a stern voice: "Be sure you've got a spare wheel, a jack, enough petrol. And drive slowly!"

Before they went off in an old Citroën, Violette reached her arm out to Liewer, then Guiet and Maloubier. As the vehicle lurched forward, she gave

them a big smile, throwing air-kisses. In her lap was a Sten submachine gun loaded with a thirty-two-round magazine. Dufour had his own submachine gun next to him in case they ran into trouble.

Liewer didn't find what he was looking for until midafternoon. It was a cottage in front of an old grain mill that was being used to farm maggots for fishermen. Under a roof of sheet metal broiling in the sun hung some old quarters of beef crawling with white larvae. The stench was appalling.

"It's perfect," Liewer said. He told Guet he could set up his wireless. "The Germans will never come looking here."

They were back at Madame Ribieras's table in time for supper, and she had just served tender potatoes simmering in an ocean of double cream under a golden crust when a car braked noisily outside.

They weren't expecting Violette back for a few days.

Liewer and the others grabbed their weapons.

A young man covered in mud burst through the door. His name was Jean Barriaud. Speaking breathlessly in rapid-fire French, he explained he was a friend of Dufour's and had been riding his bicycle that morning to Salon-la-Tour when Dufour stopped to give him a lift. They strapped the bike onto the car and drove through a hamlet, then crossed under a railway bridge a mile from Salon-la-Tour. As they came out from under the overcrossing, Dufour cried out: "*Merde!*" Posted in the road at an intersection were three German soldiers. They waved for Dufour to halt. Barriaud said he jumped from the car and ran. As bullets whistled past him, he dove into a thicket. He heard more gunfire and then the sound of tracked vehicles on the road. He waited for hours before making his way home through the woods.

Liewer had that look that bore into a man. "What about Violette?" he asked. Barriaud did not know what had become of her, or Dufour.

"Can you take us to where this happened?" asked Liewer.

Barriaud said he could, but he suggested waiting until morning because they might run into a German roadblock in the dark.

Liewer didn't like it one bit and wanted to leave immediately to look for Violette, but he knew that waiting for daylight made sense. Hopefully, she had found a place to stay safe for the night.

The three agents got little sleep that night and were ready to leave before dawn when a lorry halted in front of the store and Dufour, covered in dirt and hollow-eyed, jumped out and rushed inside.

“Where’s Violette?!” Liewer demanded.

“She was taken.”

“*What?* You abandoned her?”

“No, I did what I could!”

As Dufour told the story, Violette’s team members burned with fury—not only at the arrogance of this Frenchman, who had argued the road was safe and he would have plenty of warning in the event it wasn’t, but also out of frustration that they hadn’t been there to help her.

Dufour said he stopped the car about thirty yards from the Germans, opened his door and dropped to the ground with his gun and started shooting. Violette had taken up a similar position on the ground on the other side of the car and opened up with her Sten. She dropped one of the Germans, but the other two soldiers continued firing in their direction. Dufour said he ordered Violette to retreat through a wheat field and he would provide covering fire, then she could do the same for him. They made it into the field, but an armored car showed up and began spraying the area with its heavy machine gun. They zigzagged until they reached the end of the field. As they ran through an apple orchard, Violette stumbled into a ditch and cracked her ankle. She couldn’t walk, and he tried to pick her up, but she waved him away, saying she’d only slow him down and that he should save himself. She got up on her knees, leveling her Sten at the field now filled with Germans chasing them. She had an extra magazine for her Sten, and said she would cover him and for him to get a message back to her team that the Germans were here in force, and they were SS troops. Dufour did as he was told and got away. He heard the *rat-tat-tat* of Violette’s gun firing until she ran out of ammunition. When he came to the farm of an old friend, he hid under a haystack just as the Germans arrived, led by an officer in a command car with its convertible top down. It parked close to where he was hiding. He saw Violette in the back seat with an officer, who offered her a cigarette. She slapped it away. Dufour said he heard the German questioning her as to the whereabouts of her companion and heard her answer, laughing, “He is far away by now.”

Dufour said that was the last he saw of Violette.

Liewer asked if Dufour was certain they were SS troops.

Absolutely. He saw the patches. Panzer Division Das Reich, heading north on the main road toward Normandy.

“None worse than Das Reich,” Liewer hissed to Maloubier and Guet; both had stricken looks. “We’ve got to get Violette out of there.”

Within days, the agents knew Violette’s whereabouts, as partisans reported seeing her being taken to the prison on Place du Champ de Foire in Limoges, thirty miles to the north. She had been spotted during the daytime being escorted to the interrogation building next to the prison. She was not in handcuffs or chains, just held by each arm by a Nazi goon.

Liewer came up with a plan, and he knew something about prison escapes. In 1941, as a member of a circuit in the Côte d’Azur region, he was arrested by the Vichy police and interned at the Mauzac military prison in southwestern France. Months later, he escaped with a dozen other SOE agents and resistance fighters by taking out a guard. Liewer had then made it through the Pyrenees into Spain and Portugal, and back to London. His escape was discussed in SOE training as a case study.

Maloubier, the arms expert, had with him a Welrod, a silent pistol that fired a single bullet at a time. Each shot used rubber baffles that smothered the detonation, so the only sound was a fuzzy *phut*. He knew how to fire it quickly and accurately and was confident he could take out the two escorts during the short walk without making any noise that would alert other guards. They’d have a vehicle waiting to whisk Violette away, and partisans in position to provide supporting fire. As the final escape plan was taking shape—such as timing the escape route and having partisans ready to blockade the road after they passed—terrible news arrived.

Violette had just been moved under armed guard to the second-largest prison in France, located in the town of Fresnes, south of Paris. Fresnes was used by the Germans to house, in horrific conditions, captured Allied agents and members of the resistance.

Maloubier and Liewer knew that changed everything. They could do nothing now to rescue Violette.

I. One of the planes that went to Belgium that night failed to return. The B-24 flown by the crew of 2nd Lt. Kenneth Pratt—on their fourteenth mission—was struck by antiaircraft artillery fire and crashed near La Hulpe in central Belgium, fifteen miles southeast of Brussels. Of the eight men aboard, only Pratt returned to England after being hidden by the Belgian resistance until U.S. troops liberated Brussels in early September 1944. Five of his crewmen were killed in the crash, and two others became POWs and spent the rest of the war at the Stalag Luft IV prisoner-of-war camp.

II. Targets for the preinvasion bombing of Normandy included the steel fortifications and tank traps built by the Germans on the beaches to prevent a seaborne invasion, as well as concrete gun emplacements and observation posts overlooking that stretch of coastline.

TWELVE

CHEF DU PARACHUTAGE

Soon after parachuting into France in April 1944, Nancy Wake recognized the changing conditions in the Nazi-occupied country she had fled a year earlier. The French had a new pervasive confidence that the Germans could be defeated, which only deepened after the D-Day landings. And she appreciated not having to always skulk around to stay ahead of the Gestapo, as she had done for those two years in Marseille. Now it was more open warfare against German troops, with partisans carrying out ambushes and large-scale sabotage.

Nancy and her other team members—organizer John Farmer and wireless operator Denis Rake—had moved out of the house they had used as their base into the forest to be with the Maquis. The partisans who had taken to the woods were a different sort from those patriots who remained in their homes and villages, aiding the cause by providing safe houses and passing on vital information. Those volunteers in the forest joined ragtag militias ready to fight to achieve *le jour de la liberation* [the day of liberation]. Rough-and-tumble types, they slept where they dropped at day's end under canopies of tall pines around sheltered campfires. As committed as they were to fight for France, many lacked military training, and Farmer and Nancy had to provide instruction in the weaponry they distributed. Hoping to instill discipline in other ways, the agents forbade stealing eggs, chicken and sheep to bolster a diet of wild mushrooms, game and birds. Pilfering from farmers, they explained, made it difficult to “win the hearts, minds and souls” of their countrymen.

“*Voler les Boches*,” Nancy told them. [Steal from the Krauts.]

There were thirteen resistance groups active in their widespread area of operation, and Nancy visited them all. She met the leaders, observed the readiness of their groups and assessed their needs to help her decide which ones

should be given priority for guns, explosives and cash. One month, she handed out French francs equivalent to more than \$100,000 to be used to purchase provisions and bribe corrupt officials. Wielding enormous power as the *chef du parachutage* [head of parachutes], she was at times very popular or greatly unpopular.¹

Nancy had her own ways of handling resistance leaders who were put off at being judged by a woman. One was to outdrink them with whatever alcoholic beverages were available: wine, whiskey, gin—it didn't matter. Harking back to her days as a foreign correspondent when she had won drinking games in Parisian brasseries, she used her limitless tolerance to alcohol to gain respect from the most chauvinistic of Frenchmen. And it didn't hurt that she could swear in multiple languages and enjoyed a good cigar. At the same time, she went nowhere without her Chanel lipstick, face cream, toothpaste and brush, and two satin nightdresses, one pink and one blue. "However mannish I look by day," she told Denis Rake, "I want to sleep in satin."

One thing Nancy did not do was take a lover in the forest. In war and with so much uncertainty about the future, people easily fell into the arms of others for comfort. She was not without her own desires, but she knew giving in to them was a mistake. Not only would she lose her mantle of authority, but if she took one man to bed it would become known, and sex-starved men of the forest would vie for her attention.

Following D-Day, life was a blur of activity for Nancy, organizing airdrops and overseeing distribution to ensure that every able-bodied partisan in the Auvergne region was armed and had ample ammunition. By then, she had formed a handpicked crew of Maquis drawn from various groups who helped prepare fields for drops, provided security, set up the signal lights and unloaded the containers and loading carts and vehicles.

On the morning of June 20, a large plateau at 5,000 feet of altitude in the Massif Central range of mountains outside Chaudes-Aigues that Nancy had been using for parachute drops for six weeks came under attack by a regiment of Waffen-SS—crack combat units with a sworn allegiance to Hitler—supported by armored vehicles and mobile artillery.



Carpenter B-24 dropping containers over France.

U.S. ARMY SIGNAL CORPS

A few miles away, Nancy, who had been up for nearly forty-eight hours, had just fallen asleep after soaking away the fatigue in the hot baths of the spa from which Chaudes-Aigues drew its name. Jolted awake by the sounds of gunfire, she flung herself out of bed, dressed in slacks and shirt, grabbed her Sten gun and joined Farmer. Sentry reports indicated the mountain passes leading up to the plateau were *noir du monde allemande*—black with the figures of Germans snaking their way higher.

Nancy and Farmer sped by car to the other end of the plateau, where the local resistance leader, Gaspard, had his headquarters. An imperious Frenchman who did not like his views argued with—and with whom they had had friction in the past—he headed one of the largest Maquis groups in the area and was responsible for defending the plateau.

During the short drive, Farmer and Nancy agreed that the best course of action given the enemy's strength was for the Maquis to withdraw from the plateau and meld into the countryside to fight another day. Hit-and-run tactics worked best for the French resistance; springing a deadly ambush and moving on was more effective than facing a more powerful force on its own terms. For this reason, Nancy insisted that any groups receiving arms and money have prepared escape routes at all times.

When they arrived at Gaspard's headquarters, Farmer made a strong case for him to order a withdrawal while there was still time.

Gaspard adamantly refused. "*Mais, non!*" He confessed to being surprised by the attack, making his men "*de belles cibles*" [handsome targets]. But the

Germans were also convenient targets, he argued, and it was an opportunity to kill many of them. Retreat was out of the question.

Farmer and Nancy considered Gaspard's stubbornness such folly that they decided to notify London. Rejoining Rake, Nancy wrote out a message and coded it using a magnifying glass to read the tiny letters and numbers on a small strip of celluloid that wireless operators used to decipher communications with London. Nancy described the dire situation and Gaspard's refusal to withdraw. Rake first sent the team's identifier, which had to be acknowledged by London before he sent a full message. But the operators in London weren't listening for them because it wasn't their scheduled time, which differed from day to day so that the German detector vans—which drove around searching for Allied radio signals—couldn't easily pin down the location of a transmission. When London at last responded that it was ready to receive their message, Rake tapped it out on his Morse code key. Knowing it could be hours before they heard back, he settled in by the radio, waiting to hear the team's preamble—"The cow jumped over the moon"—which always preceded any message London sent them.

Meanwhile, Nancy rushed to where the munitions from the previous night's drop were stored. Single-handedly, she loaded guns and ammunition into the car, then set out to deliver them to partisans blazing away at Germans on the rocky slopes and winding paths below.

When she returned two hours later, Rake was decoding an incoming message. London agreed the outgunned Maquis should withdraw. That wasn't a surprise to Nancy, but she wondered what impact the advice would have on Gaspard. It wasn't anything that she and Farmer hadn't already told him. Besides, she knew he considered himself answerable not to London but to de Gaulle's Free French.

That gave her an idea.

"Den," she said, "I want you to add something to that message."

"What's that?"

"Sign it 'Koenig.'"

French general Marie-Pierre Koenig was one of the most highly regarded officers on de Gaulle's staff in London. After leading Free French forces against the Germans in Syria, Lebanon and North Africa, he had just been given

command of the French Forces of the Interior (FFI) to carry out a unification of all the resistance groups in France.

“Or would you shrink from such a deception?” She smiled wearily.

“Shrink, dear?” Rake laughed. “Since when have I been a violet?”

She was betting that Gaspard wouldn’t ignore a signed dispatch from Koenig, and she was right. When she handed him the message, Gaspard swelled with pride that the famous French general had sent him a personal wire. Without another contrary word, Gaspard started making plans to withdraw his forces under the cover of darkness that evening.

Nancy was greatly relieved. The enemy’s superior numbers and firepower would have eventually overwhelmed the defenders and cut off an organized withdrawal. Any partisan not killed in the fighting and who was captured would have been shot. A bloodbath was averted.

She now headed for the village of Fridefont eight miles to the northeast to ensure that another group of partisans knew about the planned withdrawal. Exhausted, she fought to stay awake behind the wheel and became aware of impending danger only when she heard a high-pitched whine. Looking up, she was shocked to see a Henschel 126—a two-seat Luftwaffe reconnaissance plane—diving on her. It was close enough for her to make out the facial features of the pilot in the front seat, including his brown-tinted goggles. Then came the ugly rattle of the machine guns spitting bullets that stitched lines in the dirt road. Nancy swerved the car. The plane whizzed past, then banked hard to come around for another strafing run. She was still a few miles from her destination, with little cover on the remaining stretch. Twice more the German attacked, and she swerved, braked, then sped up to ruin his aim.

Out of nowhere a resistance member she recognized appeared in the middle of the road, motioning her to stop. He told her Fridefont had been evacuated and the partisans were in the woods. He’d take her there on foot. She jumped from the car to follow, but at that moment the plane was back, its machine guns spraying bullets. The Frenchman dove into a shallow ditch and Nancy followed, landing on top of him. With his target now stationary on the road, the German finally hit the mark. A sudden roar and blast of heat blew over the ditch when the car exploded.

As long shadows fell over the plateau after sundown, German troops finally reached the top only to find the Maquis defenders who had killed hundreds of them during the climb had simply vanished.

At that moment, Gaspard's partisans were making good their escape by obscure paths, rugged game trails and rocky descents. Anything they couldn't carry they burned, leaving nothing useful behind. Withdrawing in groups ranging from fifty to a hundred partisans, they dropped into backcountry comprised of dense forests, raging rivers and steep descents, heading for their new objective: a rendezvous in three days at Saint-Santin, a village sixty miles west. None of them went there straight as a crow flies but took meandering courses with detours through thick cover to frustrate roving enemy planes searching for them.

The SOE agents each traveled with a different Maquis group to avoid losing the entire team in one fell swoop if they were attacked. After three days and nights of trekking, with only short rests along the way, Nancy's group met up with Gaspard's group three miles from Saint-Santin. To her surprise, the impervious leader fell in step beside her, linked his arm in hers and talked about the chaotic events of the past few days. It was, Nancy felt, a "wonderful moment of recognition on his part, the first time he treated me like an equal." She also believed it was his way of acknowledging she and Farmer were right to push for the withdrawal. Here they were, on a brilliant sunny day, with his resistance group intact instead of lying dead on the plateau.

Gaspard set up his headquarters in an isolated house on the outskirts of the village, and Nancy joined him at his invitation to await the arrival of the rest of the partisans. Everyone was exhausted but elated at their many adventures and happy to be alive after what they had faced.

Rake finally hobbled in—his bad leg injured in an earlier parachute jump giving him trouble on the long hike. Without delay, he gave Nancy the bad news that he had smashed and buried his radio set and burned the celluloid strip containing their codes prior to crossing a rushing river to escape a German search party with dogs. He said as the barking grew closer he had been "petrified" that his radio and codes would fall into enemy hands. But after he got

rid of them and when the Germans didn't chase after him, he felt he had made a stupid decision. He was now fully prepared for Nancy to "fly into a temper and storm."

But she said softly, "You did right, Den."

"I had to do it," he muttered, sounding as miserable as he looked.

"Of course you did."

Had the Germans captured the radio and codes, they would have been able to request airdrops in precise locations where the Gestapo was waiting and not only recover the matériel but capture parachuting SOE agents, who would be tortured for information and executed as spies.^{[II](#)}

Even as Nancy reassured Rake, she felt sick in the pit of her stomach because she understood the gravity of the situation. The radio was the most important piece of equipment an SOE team possessed. It was their lifeline to London, and gave them and the resistance forces they supplied what they needed, when they needed it. It was essential to replenish the losses Gaspard's partisans had incurred in arms, ammunition and supplies, but without a radio she was helpless to set up airdrops for them or other resistance groups at new landing fields. Also, London couldn't give them new sabotage targets or missions. Her mind was working fast now, and she knew there was but one thing to do. She had to find another SOE wireless operator who would send a message to London that her team urgently needed a new radio and a set of codes. In the seven weeks they had been in France, however, she hadn't crossed paths with another SOE team and had no idea where to find one now.

Rake recalled that during his first days after arriving in France—before joining Nancy and Farmer—he stayed briefly at a safe house where there was an SOE wireless operator. He didn't know the address in the city of Châteauroux but described the house and said it was a few doors from a bistro on a tiny square that had one scraggly tree. He didn't know the radioman's name but recalled he had a "hunched shoulder."

It was not much to go on to locate someone in a city of 30,000 residents, but Nancy knew she had to try. Her first thought was to travel to Châteauroux by car, but reports from partisans warned that the Germans, furious at their failure to wipe out the Maquis on the plateau, were impeding civilian traffic on roads in

and out of major towns with checkpoints and roadblocks. To heighten security further, all identity cards issued in the Auvergne region had been canceled, and new ID cards were being issued. Nancy's forged ID was stamped as originating in Auvergne. It was foolish for her to accept the German invitation to citizens to call on them to obtain a new card. With all the checkpoints and no valid ID, she was told she would be lucky to get through by bicycle, and going by car was out of the question. In fact, Farmer initially objected to Nancy going by *any* conveyance because it was just too dangerous.

"I've got to go," she said, and that ended the discussion. She had the responsibility of being her team's contact with London and for organizing the parachute drops. For that, she needed a radio. She was left with no choice but to bike the 190 miles to Châteauroux.

Since she'd abandoned the plateau, Nancy had only the slacks and blouse she was wearing. Such unfeminine, battle-stained attire would not do for the long bike ride through German-infested country. While her situation would be precarious in many ways, she did have one distinct advantage. She had long ago learned that sexual attraction knew no national borders or political ideologies. She was often ogled by the soldiers, who were supposed to be suspicious of everyone as possible threats, but who became distracted when she dressed and acted feminine. She planned to play that advantage to the hilt. She wanted the Germans standing between her and her objective to think it impossible that an attractive young woman on a bike was an Allied spy intent on bringing death and destruction to them and their fellow Nazis. She went to a friendly tailor for a fitting for a new dress.

Farmer, realizing they didn't have a bicycle rugged enough for an arduous journey, went out one night and brought back a bike with a sturdy chassis and thick tires. He also sent word to Maquis contacts in the areas Nancy would be passing through to look out for her and provide her with information about checkpoints and troop movements. Together, Nancy and Farmer mapped out the best route for her to take to Châteauroux, sticking whenever possible to back roads that crisscrossed the countryside and where the Germans rarely ventured for fear of ambush. She decided not to take a gun, as it would be easy to find if she were searched. She would just have to talk her way out of trouble.

Striking in her new attire, her raven hair pulled back by a black cotton hairband, Nancy pedaled off early one morning ready, eager and brimming with confidence that she could do this.

A worried Farmer wasn't so sure. He shouted at her: "Remember, after Puy-de-Dôme, go by Saint-Amand, Bourges and Issoudun."

She gave a quick wave and soon was out of sight around a bend.

After she left, Farmer and Rake were both glum. Some of the partisans questioned whether the *belle mademoiselle* [beautiful miss] was capable of cycling nearly four hundred miles round-trip over a rugged course that included mountainous ascents. It seemed foolish to spend so much time defenseless on a bike—without even acceptable ID papers—in the midst of Germans looking for people like her. Even Farmer and Rake, who were well aware of Nancy's strengths and willpower, wondered if they would see her again. Had they sent her off to certain capture and death?

Nancy made good progress that first day, and the Maquis contacts along the first part of the route proved to be helpful. When there were reports of checkpoints, someone would scout ahead and wave her on when the coast was clear. Through some early villages she even had an escort riding with her. Whenever she had to take a main road, she walked her bike, reasoning that if she saw German vehicles approaching from a distance she would have time to step off the road and hide. But that wasn't always the case, and on the outskirts of one town a troop truck roared past her filled with catcalling Germans. She waved back demurely even as she thought how much she'd like to see them crash and burn.

She cycled through the mountainous Puy-de-Dôme stretch, making good time but leaving her legs feeling like hot lead and her body aching in new places. When it started to get dark, she stopped at a country bistro midway between Montluçon and Saint-Amand-Montrond. She bought a simple meal and a glass of red wine and listened to every snippet of conversation she could pick up. The Germans, it seemed, had not been in the area for some time. That was what she wanted to hear. As she paid the check, she let the owner know she intended to ride into town, but once outside she hid in an old barn out back. She had to look as fresh as possible each day, like a young housewife tootling along home or to a

farmers market, rather than someone on a long trip who might arouse suspicion. So as not to wrinkle her dress, she hung it on a nail, covered herself with straw and slept soundly.

Awakening before dawn, she dressed quickly and rode through rolling hills to reach Saint-Amand-Montrond, a farming community surrounded by woodland and pastures. She stopped at a bistro, where she found the coffee filled with grounds but the food hot and filling. Again eavesdropping on others, she learned that German troops had arrived in Bourges—the next town, twenty-five miles away—the day before. No one seemed to know if they had just passed through or remained in the city. Back on her bicycle, she headed in that direction with some trepidation.

Up and down countless hills and dales, she pushed at the pedals, digging deep, trying not to count the revolutions or focus on her heavy legs or burning lungs. Late that afternoon, after crossing a bridge on the Yèvre River, she rode into Bourges, known for its half-timber houses and the twelfth-century Gothic Cathedral of Saint Étienne. The streets were quiet—too quiet for a city of 50,000 residents. Shutters and shops were closed, and few people were to be seen. Nancy only later learned that Bourges was a city in mourning, with a populace cowering in terror. That morning the Germans had rounded up locals suspected of resistance activity and shot them in front of their families and neighbors. Rounding a corner, she found herself facing a formation of Germans marching in step down the middle of the street. Smiling wanly, she pedaled past them.

She had planned to reach out to a partisan contact here for a safe house where she could get some rest, but with the city locked down and rife with Germans, she elected to keep going. She stopped at a small restaurant just outside the village of Issoudun and ordered a full meal. While it was being prepared, she visited the toilette and used the basin to freshen up, ever conscious of not wanting to attract attention by looking like a bedraggled traveler. After the most delicious repast of her journey, she ordered a bottle of brandy and invited the older proprietor to join her. By the time the bottle was half-empty, the proprietor, who quickly revealed his hatred for all things German, had told her everything she wanted to know. Knowing the lay of the land was important for

someone traveling through strange country who didn't want to appear to be a stranger. Leaving the restaurant as sober as when she entered, she shopped at a market in Issoudun and stowed her purchases in a string bag slung from the handlebars to look like a local housewife. The German patrols the proprietor warned her about passed without giving her a second glance. She ran into a checkpoint on the way out of town. She stopped and got off her bike as if to show her ID, but that sign of apparent cooperation was enough for the guard, who waved her through. His eyes stayed on her as she hiked up her dress to her knees to remount the bike.

"Au revoir," she said brightly.

Had she been asked for her ID, she planned to say she had left it at home. If that didn't work, she'd flutter her eyelashes at the Kraut and say flirtatiously, *"Tu veux me chercher?"* [Do you want to search me?]

By the time she rode into Châteauroux, she had gone nearly two hundred miles in two days on five hours' sleep. But there was no sense of relief because she still had to find the nameless radioman in this bustling industrial city filled with German occupational troops. If she failed to find him and get her message to London, her arduous journey would be for naught. She cycled through the streets for hours but had no luck locating the bistro on the square. She did, however, run into someone she knew.

Bernard was a Maquis she had met when she visited his group in the Brive-la-Gaillarde area of southwest France several weeks earlier. Hopping off their bikes, they embraced like old friends. Over coffee, they learned that they had come to Châteauroux for the same reason. His group's Free French wireless operator was recently killed in combat, and he was looking for a replacement radioman said to be operating there.

As if Bernard had changed her luck, Nancy soon found the bistro on the square. When she knocked on the right door, a man with a hunched shoulder answered: the radioman Rake had described to a T. He let her inside the flat, and she explained her situation. He adamantly refused to send a message for her because she did not have her proper codes for a transmission. For all he knew, he said, she could be Gestapo. She pointed out if she were Gestapo, he'd be dead already, but no manner of logic or pleading changed his mind. Disgusted with

the lack of cooperation from an SOE colleague, she returned to the bistro, where Bernard was waiting.

After hearing of the SOE operator's refusal to send Nancy's message, Bernard said if they found the Free French radioman he could relay her message to London. They bicycled to another neighborhood, where Bernard learned from a trusted contact that the Frenchman he was looking for had just left town after a close call with the Gestapo. But he was told there was another French wireless operator with a resistance group in a forest a short distance outside Châteauroux.

Riding separately to the other side of town, Nancy and Bernard rendezvoused near nightfall, hid their bikes and continued on foot into the forest. They soon found the band of partisans. The Maquis leader explained to Nancy that because his group was aligned with the Free French, they were in communication with Algiers, the capital of the Free French government-in-exile. He agreed to have his wireless operator send Nancy's message to Algiers, asking that it be passed on to London. She wrote out a message addressed to "Colonel Buckmaster, SOE," telling him succinctly why they needed a new radio and codes and providing the location where they should be dropped to her waiting team.

After a few hours' sleep and anxious to start her journey back, Nancy left early the next morning. Rather than take the circuitous route back to Saint-Santin, she decided to take the most direct and shortest route and to hell with the Germans. Back on the road, she soon passed exhaustion, with the threat of a "complete collapse" seemingly around the next bend. Every time she turned the pedals she was racked by pain. But refusing to give in, she kept moving through the night, fighting off cramps that threatened to seize up her legs if she stopped pedaling.

She had a scare south of Montluçon when a shadowy figure emerged on the road in front of her, but it turned out to be a Maquis who had been one of her earlier escorts. Seeing how she was struggling, he rode with her more than a hundred miles all the way back to Saint-Santin.

When she pulled up at their encampment, Farmer ran out to greet her. "How are you?" he asked worriedly.

Unable to respond, Nancy cried.

She couldn't stand up and had to be helped to a raised bed of feathers and leaves in the forest. All the skin had been rubbed away from the insides of her thighs, and the village doctor did what he could with ointments and dressings. For the next few days and nights, Nancy could barely move, unable to stand, walk or even sit up without pain. All she could do was lie flat on her back, immobile.

A week later, however, when the drone of a B-24 was heard on a moonlit night, Nancy was there to see the canopy of a parachute floating down in a nearby field, landing a new wireless set, as requested.

Their *chef du parachutage* was back in business.

I. The Maquis groups for which Nancy Wake was *chef du parachutage* and the approximate number of their fighters, who totaled nearly 7,000: Commander Fabre (300); Corps France Issoire (150); Chazemais (440); Cérilly (440); St. Plaisir (450); Montmarault (800); Moulins (360); Lapalisse (850); Montluçon (650); Ambert MUR (700); Ambert FTPF (800); Pontgibaud (400); and St. Gervais (300).

II. The Germans had long used captured radios and codes to deceive the Allies. In June 1942, a roundup of SOE agents and their French associates netted the Germans a large quantity of arms and two wireless sets. They recalled their radio expert, Dr. Josef Goetz, from vacation to exploit the radios in what the Germans called *Funkspiel* [radio game], a technique of receiving messages and transmitting controlled information over a captured agent's radio. In October 1943, Noor Inayat Khan, the last remaining SOE wireless operator still active in the Paris area, was arrested after being betrayed for reward money. The Germans found her codes and security checks and used them to exchange messages with London that resulted in the capture of more SOE agents and their radios. As recently as February 1944, the Germans had used seized radios and codes to set up a parachute drop, and as a result apprehended an entire SOE team—organizer Joseph Antoine France Antelme, courier Madeleine Damerment and radio operator Lionel Lee—along with their radios and codes as soon as they stepped foot on French soil. All three were imprisoned and later executed by the Germans.

THIRTEEN

STAR SPANGLED HELL

A few minutes past midnight on June 28, 1944, a black B-24 piloted by 1st Lt. William E. Huenekens took off from Harrington for a cross-country training flight over England. There were only six crewmen because the two others who were meant to be on the flight were on a late-arriving bus returning from a twenty-four-hour pass.

Bill Huenekens, twenty-seven, was a cum laude graduate of Harvard University (Class of '39), where he crewed on an eight-man boat, was on the debate team, and served as editor of the paper, proving the validity of the glowing recommendation by the headmaster at St. Paul Academy prep in Minnesota that he was “one of the best.” Upon his 1942 graduation from Harvard Law School, Huenekens volunteered for Army flight training, during which one of his instructors noted he “thought like a lawyer.” After being selected to fly B-24 Liberators, he trained with his crew in the States before flying them across the Atlantic. They had arrived at Harrington a month ago, and to a man they were eager to complete their Carpetbagger practice flights and become “operationally ready” for missions to Nazi-occupied Europe.

With pressure to increase the amount of matériel flowing to the resistance forces now that Allied armies were fighting in France, more than a dozen new crews like theirs had arrived at Harrington. However, due to attrition from operational losses, as well as crews rotating back to the States after completing the required number of missions, some of them were replacements rather than additions to the existing four squadrons.¹ After six months of operations, the Carpetbaggers' aircraft losses amounted to nearly one full squadron, or some sixteen aircraft.

That night of June 28, the Huenekens crew was one of nine new crews scheduled for a training flight, although two planes were late scrubs: one was judged “unserviceable,” and another was grounded because of an engine that wouldn’t start. There were another eighteen planes headed on missions to France, carrying more than three hundred tons of supplies to two SOE networks operating southwest of Paris.

Airborne over the central Midlands, the Huenekens crew carried out a series of course changes at low altitudes utilizing dead reckoning and visual references, practicing the navigational skills necessary to locate a drop zone in a dark field. Finished by 2:30 a.m., they made a wide turn at Duxford—just south of Cambridge—and headed northwest, sixty miles from home. Huenekens contacted the Harrington control tower for permission to enter its flight pattern and began reducing altitude.

From his rear-facing position, tail gunner Sgt. Randall G. Sadler, twenty-nine, of Clay County, Texas, was the only one to see the aircraft coming up fast. Was it the silhouette of a radar-fitted Junkers Ju 88 night fighter? Sadler couldn’t be sure, but as he clicked off the safety on his twin .50-cal. guns he shouted a warning—“On our six!”—into his headset a split second before a steady stream of cannon shells ripped through the metal airframe, igniting fires fueled by broken oil and gas lines.

Killed instantly by the cannon fire was the flight engineer, Sgt. Carl R. Adams, of Iowa City, Iowa, who died at his post just behind the cockpit, and the copilot, 2nd Lt. John M. Cronan, of New York, New York. Huenekens, with Cronan now slumped in the seat next to him, used all the strength and leverage of his six-foot-four frame to fight for control of the aircraft while monitoring the gauges, which were jumping wildly. Smoke and flames were everywhere. Without a moment to spare because he knew they were going down with no time to set up an emergency landing, Huenekens hit the bail-out alarm—*gong-gong-gong*—and fought to keep the dying airplane airborne long enough for everyone to get out, as was the ethos of U.S. bomber pilots, who understood their first responsibility was to their crews. After losing two engines, then a third, the plane went into a steep, powerless glide from which there was to be no recovery.

At the sound of the bail-out alarm, two second lieutenants, navigator Robert Callahan and bombardier Robert L. Sanders, quickly left the nose compartment and rushed aft. With the cabin engulfed in flames, they found their access to the bomb bay—the mid-cabin emergency egress—was cut off. Callahan, already wearing his chest-pack parachute, headed through the thick smoke toward the only other exit available to them.

Sanders saw his chest-pack chute hanging on a hook a few feet away, but when he tried to reach it he was driven back by the flames. He rushed forward after Callahan, whom he found seated on the edge of the open door to the nose-wheel compartment, ready to jump. Sanders shouted that his chute was burnt. Callahan motioned for him to climb onto his back. Sanders did, wrapping his legs piggyback-style around Callahan. Sharing one parachute, the two men dropped into the pitch-black void. Once clear of the blazing bomber now fully engulfed in fire, Callahan pulled the rip-cord handle and the canopy snapped open with a jolt that almost broke Sanders's grip, which would have sent him plummeting a thousand feet to his death. Callahan yelled for Sanders to work his way around to his front so they could keep ahold of each other. After Sanders did so, there was a loud explosion below, and a fiery plume rose from where the plane went down.

The double weight under the single canopy caused them to drop faster than usual, and they hit the ground hard in a wheat field, just outside the village of Eaton Socon. Their tail gunner, Randy Sadler, with serious burns on his face and hands, landed nearby. A farmer brought the three men to his house and made a phone call that resulted in an ambulance from Harrington picking them up. Sanders ended up with a sprained ankle, and his knees and wrists were bruised, but the two men who shared a parachute had accomplished something never done by U.S. airmen in the war. The pair's successful jump with a single parachute was big news, and an article about their feat appeared in *Stars and Stripes* and was reprinted in dozens of newspapers back home: "Single 'Chute Brings 2 Flyers Safely Down from Burned Liberator."

Back at Harrington, Col. Heflin was intrigued by the maneuver that soon became known as "Callahan's Trapeze," which he thought could save lives. He had the two flyers demonstrate how it was done by suspending them from a

crane and lowering them to the ground in a single chute before dozens of cheering Carpetbagger crews. Callahan and Sanders were also sent around to other Eighth Air Force bases in England to teach their fellow flyers.

Callahan was awarded a Silver Star for “gallantry in action that saved the life” of Bob Sanders. But when he wrote home to his mother in Milwaukee, he had a different act of heroism on his mind. “Bill, our pilot, saved our lives in keeping the plane in the air those extra seconds,” he wrote.

Sadler knew this to be true as well. He penned a letter to Huenekens’s mother, Helen, in Minneapolis, telling her, “At the crash site, Bill was found still at the controls. Even to the last he was thinking of his crew and our safety. He was a great flyer and a wonderful man. We all loved him more than I am able to tell you.”



“Callahan Trapeze.” Reenactment of two airmen successfully sharing one parachute.

U.S. ARMY SIGNAL CORPS

July 1944 was the first month the four squadrons at Harrington reached their full complement of planes and, even more importantly, crews trained in Carpetbagger operations. The number of missions to supply the resistance dwarfed the totals of the previous months.

On the Fourth of July—two nights shy of a full moon—thirty-nine planes rumbled down Harrington’s main runway one after the other until the last B-24 lifted off just before midnight, each headed for a drop zone in central or

northern France. Only then did an uneasy silence fall over the airfield. Duty officers in squadron ready rooms, crew chiefs and mechanics in hangars, controllers in the tower—everyone who fretted over the aircraft and cared about the men who flew them—settled into a waiting game knowing that, due to strict observance of radio silence, it would be hours before they found out who would return that night and who would not.

The Ellis crew took off at 11:17 p.m. on their eighteenth mission, headed for DONKEYMAN—one of the SOE's more rural circuits—operating in the Yonne department, some one hundred miles southeast of Paris. Its partisans had sabotaged a factory in Mantes making cellophane—used to waterproof weapons, ammunition and explosives—and reports and photographs of other successes were sent to London. As a result of their efficiency, DONKEYMAN was to receive twenty-five airdrops of munitions, cash and supplies that summer of 1944.

Navigator Gene Polinsky, who three months earlier had nearly fallen from the plane without a parachute as he kicked loose a broken bomb bay door, mapped their precise course to the DONKEYMAN drop zone located between two lakes. Although he valued the plane's electronic and radio navigation equipment—particularly when flying in inclement weather—he relied heavily on map reading and dead reckoning to get them where they needed to be. To accurately estimate their current position and course based on earlier-known positions, he constantly monitored wind speed and direction, as a shift of either could blow them off course. Minor adjustments to a course could be made during a flight, but it was vital to avoid known sites of anti-aircraft artillery and enemy airfields circled in red on his map. Europe was very well mapped and had been for years, with every town, village, mountain, river, highway, lake and forest in its proper place. While the bombardier viewed the passing terrain through the nose bubble, Gene stayed focused on the calculations that went into keeping them on course, understanding that he had to be at his very best at all times. How different this was from being a navigator in a heavy bombing squadron, he often thought. He knew navigators on B-17 Fortresses flying in large formations on bombing runs into Germany who passed their time reading comic books while their pilots followed the leader. One alert and skilled navigator out of

thirty-two or a hundred planes was all it took to get a large formation of bombers to Berlin, Hamburg or other targets.

On Carpetbagger missions, crewmen had to place their trust in their own navigator. It was he who got them safely across the Channel and took them to drop zones in dark fields behind enemy lines without getting lost or overflying enemy strongholds, and always on solo flights with no other planes to follow. Hence, skilled navigators were every bit as popular as good pilots at Harrington. Someone on the Ellis crew always volunteered to carry Gene's heavy bag to the plane, and he was sure to be offered tins of coffee or an extra sandwich on a long flight. A few of the guys told Gene about a story circulating around the base that any crew with a Jewish navigator was "damn lucky" and had a better chance of surviving. "Why's that?" a bemused Gene wanted to know. "Because you guys are so smart, sir."

Three missions ago, the Ellis crew had experienced its closest call so far. On June 22, after departing Harrington, their outbound track through England's congested skies was handled, as usual, by British traffic controllers. But one gun crew on the ground didn't get the word that an American bomber was passing directly overhead at 7,800 feet because twenty miles due south of London Gene's plane received "heavy accurate anti-aircraft fire" from the ground. The pilot, Neil Ellis, the even-keeled North Carolinian, took "violent evasive action" by diving and banking, but they still sustained several hits in the fuselage big enough to put a fist through. As curses flew over the crew's interphone headsets, a furious Gene pinpointed their exact location. No flight systems were damaged, and they continued on their mission without incident. Back at Harrington, Gene reported the incident to an intelligence officer, with the warning that a British gun crew at that location needed to be admonished for nearly bagging an American B-24. Then, on their very next mission—a successful drop two nights later—they had to shut down engine #2 due to low oil pressure and make it home on three engines. But if anyone on the Ellis crew was thinking as they took off on July 4 that their luck had changed for the worse—even with their Jewish navigator—no one said anything.

Two hours into their July 4 flight, Gene guided them right to their DONKEYMAN drop zone, which he found a mile and a half west of the

briefed location. He did so even though the plane's radio compass was not working, but with the help of the Gee Box radio-signal homing device. Like every Carpetbagger navigator, Gene never actually saw the ground or the target he was responsible for finding, since he sat beyond the blackout curtain behind the bombardier, who made visual confirmation by identifying the flashing of the night's code letter. For the sake of accuracy, tonight's drop was made from a very low 300 feet, and on a single pass to limit their time over the target when the low-flying plane was most vulnerable to enemy ground fire. There were some problems, however. The code letter was flashing at the wrong end of the triangle of signal lights, resulting in a few containers landing a hundred feet beyond the last light. Also, the tail gunner reported the parachute on one container failed to open. On the way home, they dodged "lots of flak and flares." And while still in French airspace, a four-engine plane—likely a Luftwaffe long-range reconnaissance aircraft—crossed close in front of them at a 90-degree angle. It wasn't a flawless mission, but it was another completed one, and they landed safely back at Harrington. While the Ellis crew's good luck was holding, four other crews weren't as fortunate that night.

What befell the Carscaddon crew aptly fit the name of their B-24: "Hell and Back." After crossing the coast of France, they were jumped by three twin-engine Ju 88 night fighters about fifty miles inland. The *Balkenkreuz*—a black-and-white cross that was the emblem for all branches of the German military—on the Luftwaffe fighters glinted in the moonlight as they swooped past, blasting away with their cannons. A running battle ensued as pilot 1st Lt. Oscar C. Carscaddon Jr., twenty-six, of Alexandria, Virginia, took evasive action while the gunners in the tail and top turrets returned fire with their twin .50-cal. machine guns.

Unable to shake the attackers, the plane took hit after hit. When engine #2 caught fire, Carscaddon cut its fuel and feathered the propeller, which stopped it from windmilling and turned the blades parallel to the airflow to minimize drag. The fighters kept up their attack on the lone bomber until they suddenly pulled off. It was soon apparent why they had cleared the area when the sky filled with explosive bursts of AA fire over Elbeuf that rocked the plane. Once they were

out of range of the ground fire, the fighters were back, pressing their furious attacks to down the B-24.

Operating the top-turret gun was flight engineer Sgt. Franklin J. Hasty (no relation to tail gunner Graham Hasty of the Simon crew). Hasty, twenty-four, of Gowrie, Iowa, was responsible for the mechanical systems and electronics aboard. And right now he was damn angry that his plane was taking so much punishment. As one of the fighters bore down on them from three o'clock—coming from their right side at the same altitude—Hasty saw their tracer shells whiz past his turret. Unblinking, he squeezed the trigger and sprayed his own fire on the rapidly closing intruder. (Every fifth round in a .50-cal. machine gun was a lit-up tracer to help a gunner hit his target.) When the fighter was no more than one hundred yards away, it wobbled and fell off into a tight spin, out of control.

With fire raging in the bomb bay, the #2 engine aflame, and some flight systems failing, Carscaddon hit the bail-out alarm. Planning to be the last to jump and give everyone time to find an exit, he told his copilot, 2nd Lt. Otis W. Murphy, twenty-two, of Utica, New York, to get out.

Hasty fired off a few more blasts to keep the remaining fighters at bay, then dropped out of the turret to retrieve his chest-pack parachute. When he found holes in it from flak fragments, he threw it aside, grabbed a handheld fire extinguisher and headed back to the bomb bay, where he succeeded in dousing the flames. He rushed back up to the cockpit to report the fire in the bomb bay was extinguished and learned from Carscaddon that the engine fire had also died down, likely from lack of fuel. The pilot and engineer discussed whether the damaged aircraft was still flyable with some instruments out and decided to try to nurse it home. Carscaddon dropped down to treetop level to avoid enemy fighters and, not knowing their exact location, headed west. At the coast, he had to take evasive action to avoid searchlights and moderately light flak. Limping across the Channel, "Hell and Back" made it to the southern tip of England, where they were met by friendly aircraft and searchlights that guided them to a landing at Ford Airfield in Sussex. The bomber hit the runway with no flap control to slow its approach, its bomb bay doors stuck open, and no brakes. Rolling off the end of the runway, they slammed into a ditch and ended up in a

planted field with a smashed nose, badly damaged underside and collapsed landing gear.

An inspection of the plane found three bullet holes in the #2 engine, more holes under the cockpit and right wing, a large jagged hole on top of the left wing, and a huge opening approximately three by two feet in the belly of the aircraft. Hundreds of smaller holes caused by cannon fire and flak bursts pockmarked the fuselage. Carscaddon and Hasty didn't have a scratch, but the fate of the six men who bailed out was not known.^{II}

The Carscaddon crew were far from the only Carpetbaggers to run into serious trouble that night, which would prove to be an evening of heightened enemy fighter activity and intense antiaircraft fire across France. In fact, they were among the luckier ones.

After taking off at 11:25 p.m., a B-24 flown by 1st Lt. John J. Meade, of Long Island, New York, crossed the Channel at about midnight. As it did, the navigator found his homing radar was malfunctioning. While not crucial to completing their drop mission in France, it was, according to crewman T/Sgt. Frank E. Hines, of Lafayette, Indiana, "an omen of things to come."

Shortly after entering French airspace, they encountered a Messerschmitt Bf 110 twin-engine night fighter at an altitude of 5,000 feet. Rather than dropping close to the ground to try to lose the German, Meade, flying his sixth mission as command pilot, climbed to 8,000 feet, entered a cloud bank and changed course several times. But when they came out of the clouds, the radar-equipped fighter was waiting and attacked them from behind, raking the B-24 with accurate cannon fire. In the tail-gun turret, S/Sgt. Ellis H. Syra, twenty-two, of Marion County, Indiana, was killed instantly. The bomb bay caught fire, which quickly spread to the left wing, and the two engines on that side were lost. At the sound of the bail-out alarm, five crewmen made it through the smoke and flames to jump from the open bomb bay. The two pilots bailed out from the nose-wheel hatch. The copilot, 2nd Lt. James L. Lovelace, of Jackson, Mississippi, pulled his rip cord while inverted. When the canopy opened below him, he fell through it, collapsing the chute. He hit the ground headfirst.

It was days before news reached Harrington of the fate of the Meade crew, marked as "Missing" on the operations board when it hadn't returned by 8 a.m.

Partisans reported two dead bodies at the crash site near the village of Autruy-sur-Juine, south of Paris: the tail gunner still inside his turret and a short distance away the copilot entangled in his canopy. The other members of the crew were in the hands of resistance forces and in hiding until they could be liberated by advancing Allied troops.

A bigger mystery was the fate of the B-24 flown by 1st Lt. Charles R. Kline, of Harrison, Oklahoma. They departed Harrington at 11:31 p.m. for their eighth mission with eight men aboard but never made their drop near the village of Dammartin-en-Goële, twenty miles northeast of Paris. In the morning, partisans found a crash site with the burned-out B-24 at Lagny-le-Sec, six miles from the drop zone. The plane had apparently exploded in midair, as the remains of the entire crew were inside the wreckage. From a U.S. Air Forces casualty report: "The reception party had to move to another field, but was unable to contact the [Kline] crew. As the complete crew perished we shall not know what happened exactly. The aircraft possibly repeated the run over the dropping zone and thus attracted the attention of a fighter." The report also included this stunning new intelligence: a Luftwaffe airfield from which a dozen Messerschmitt fighter planes were based was only three miles from the original drop zone. Had the Carpetbaggers' brass at Harrington been informed of an enemy airfield so nearby, the mission would have been scheduled for a drop at a different location.

The final luckless crew of that July 4 night took off at 11:13 p.m. on their ninth mission. Their B-24's playful nose art depicted a curvy pinup model in a bathing suit and a red-and-blue-striped stick of dynamite burning at the wick next to the moniker "Star Spangled Hell." The pilot, 1st Lt. John O. Broten, twenty-five, of Glen Ridge, New Jersey, was the scion of a prominent family. He attended Culver Military Academy in Chicago prior to enrolling at Rutgers University in 1939. Two months after the U.S. entered the war, he enlisted in the Army Air Corps and began flight training. Next to him in the cockpit was the copilot, 2nd Lt. Edward Tappan, twenty-three, of Tucson, Arizona. Growing up, his affluent family's Swiss governess and French maid taught him the language that one day would quite possibly save his life. The self-proclaimed cowboy attended a private prep school with a decidedly horsey atmosphere, and

he played polo and competed on the rodeo team at the University of Arizona. When he entered the Army in August 1943, the tall, rangy Tappan was initially in the cavalry, but when he found out there weren't in fact any horses to ride, he applied for flight training.

The Broten crew's flight across the Channel into France was uneventful. Their navigator, 2nd Lt. Roy C. Gehue, a Canadian and one of the few Carpetbaggers who was not an American citizen, brought them with pinpoint accuracy to their VENTRILOQUIST circuit drop zone a hundred miles south of Paris. The circuit had been among the first to be established by the SOE in early 1941, but was shut down a year later after its leaders were killed in combat or arrested. It had been reactivated three months ago.

After the signal lights and proper code letter were observed, voice communication was established with the partisans on the ground over the S-phone. Broten circled and came in low and slow over the lit-up field. All the containers went out on cue, and the partisans acknowledged a good drop. Broten pulled up and began gaining altitude for the trip back across France to England. The hardest part was done.

They were still climbing—had just passed through 2,000 feet—and were south of the city of Orléans when the attack came out of nowhere. A twin-engine night fighter was suddenly below them. Instead of attacking from behind or above, where the Liberator's guns would be most effective, the Bf 110 came up from underneath and used its upward-firing twin *Schräge Musik* 20mm cannons, a devastating weapon that poured hundreds of rounds into the B-24's vulnerable undercarriage from tail to nose. Shells ripped through the fuselage, the bomb bay and vital parts of the aircraft, causing explosions and fires everywhere.

In the cockpit, one shell came up through the deck between the two pilots so close that it clipped Tappan's sleeve off his jacket and nicked his wrist. In the next second, the plane's hydraulic accumulator—a system used to control the bomb bay doors, landing gears and wing flaps—caught fire, filling the cockpit with flames and black smoke. Broten, fighting with all his might to keep hold of the dying ship, ordered Tappan to sound the bail-out alarm. With the plane now a mass of seething flames, Broten yelled for his copilot to get out. Tappan

couldn't even see the narrow escape hatch above their seats for all the smoke. Located right in front of the top gun turret, it was designed as an emergency exit from the cockpit in case of fire on the ground. He hadn't heard of anyone jumping from it in flight, but with a wall of flames behind the cockpit it was the only way out.

Tappan found the hatch handle by feel and pulled it open. The wind-blast howled in his face and fanned the flames coming from behind the burning control panel. He pulled himself up into the hatchway—but got stuck midway, leaving him halfway in and halfway out of the plane.

And then “Star Spangled Hell” exploded in the starry night sky.

Somehow, miraculously, an unconscious Ed Tappan was propelled clear of the blast that in an instant took the lives of his entire crew.

I. The twenty-five-mission “top” instituted by the Eighth Air Force in winter 1943 due to alarmingly high cases of fatigue, mental exhaustion and low morale among bomber crews was raised to thirty combat missions in March 1944, after which an airman would be sent home for reassignment or given ground duties in England. In July 1944, the top was raised again—to thirty-five missions.

II. The only member of the Carscaddon crew to evade capture was the copilot, Otis Murphy, who was hidden by partisans until liberated by U.S. forces the following month. He returned to Harrington with an alarming story of being fired on by one JU 88 after bailing out. The German pilot dropped flares and continued strafing him on the ground, wounding Murphy in the leg. As for the rest of the crew: T/Sgt. Charles E. Cernik, of Houston, TX, was interned at Stalag Luft IV, while the others—2nd Lt. Joseph C. Denaro, of Boston, MA; 2nd Lt. William L. Granbery III, of Nashville, TN; S/Sgt. Laurie A. Salo, of Minneapolis, MN; and S/Sgt. Paul A. Stralka Jr., of South Superior, MN—were interned at Buchenwald concentration camp as *Terrorflieger* [terror flyers] with 160 other Allied airmen for two months (August 20 to October 19, 1944) until a high-ranking Luftwaffe general learned they were in the hands of the *Schutzstaffel* (SS) and ordered them moved to a Luftwaffe-run POW camp, Stalag Luft III, where they spent the rest of the war. Many returned with horrific stories about Buchenwald, where in September 1944 as many as forty captured SOE agents were executed: hanged from meat hooks or strangled by piano wire in the camp’s “Tower Block.”

FOURTEEN

BEHIND THE LINES

When he came to after blacking out, Ed Tappan found himself swinging under a billowing canopy, still clutching the metal handle from his chest-pack parachute, though he had no memory of pulling the rip cord. In a dreamlike state, the dazed copilot watched a large metal piece from an airplane falling past him in slow motion. *How strange, he thought. Why is a vertical stabilizer from a B-24 tumbling through the sky?*



Copilot Edward Tappan.
U.S. ARMY SIGNAL CORPS

Tappan landed in a tall wheat field next to a wooded area, adding a sprained ankle to his injuries, which included a painful knot on his head as well as cuts, bruises and burns on his face, hands and arms. He pulled in the shroud lines to gather up the canopy, then headed into the timberland. He listened for any sounds of his crew who might have landed nearby and those of an enemy patrol, but it was quiet other than the

chirping and croaking of the nighttime forest. Certain he was alone, he lay down, hurting and exhausted. The next thing he knew, it was dawn.

In the early-morning light he moved cautiously through the woods. When he came to a road, he saw two men on bicycles chatting away in French. Making a snap decision, Tappan stepped out and hailed them.

“Bonjour, messieurs.”

They stopped and looked at him curiously.

Tappan explained in his fluent French that he was a downed American flyer. The Frenchmen glanced at one another but didn't say anything. If they were on the right side—as he was betting they were—he understood they would have learned after years of Nazi occupation to be careful about subterfuges and collaborators. Were they wondering why, if he was really an American, he spoke their language so well? Tappan came closer so they could see his oil- and soot-covered clothing and burned face and hands. Those stark visuals apparently helped them make up their minds that he was telling the truth. They exchanged a few words with each other, then told Tappan to remain out of sight and they would summon help.

Stepping back off the road, Tappan knew if he had guessed wrong about the men, he would soon be a prisoner of war—or worse. But instead a woman came down the road about an hour later, bringing him civilian clothes, a tin of hot coffee, and a hunk of fresh-baked bread. She and her husband had a dairy nearby, and the bicyclists had stopped to tell them about the American flyer in the woods. She told Tappan to hide until dark, then walk to their place less than a mile away.

That evening, after cleaning Tappan's wounds, the farmwife treated his burns with olive oil and honey, which had a soothing effect. He ate a hearty meal, after which the husband showed Tappan to the basement, where he slept the night. For the next several days his routine was to hide in the hayloft in the Faucon family's barn during the day—in case the house was searched—and sleep in the basement. He was often visited by the family's two young daughters, ages nine and fourteen. The girls liked to play a French game similar to Twenty Questions, a spoken parlor game that encourages deductive reasoning and creativity. They were good at it, and the lively exchanges with them took Tappan's mind off his situation. So excited was the family to have their special guest, they invited friends to come meet the *Américain aviateur*, which they did, bringing pots of soup and casseroles. Even as he ate well and met many friendly folks, Tappan worried that his hideout might be discovered by the wrong people. It

would mean not only his capture but a serious threat to the family that had taken him in.

After a week, two resistance members came for him one night. Tappan asked if they had information about any of his crew. They did not but told him that scattered and scorched pieces of an aircraft containing human remains were found a few miles away. Tappan began to contemplate the awful possibility that he was his crew's sole survivor.¹

After exchanging warm goodbyes with the Faucon family, Tappan and his escorts began a walking-and-bicycling journey that lasted several days before he was guided into a forest not far from Châteaudun, a village ninety-five miles southwest of Paris. They soon came to a well-organized camp in the Fréteval Forest—code-named SHERWOOD after Robin Hood's domain—where Tappan joined 152 downed Allied airmen from the U.S., Great Britain, Canada, New Zealand and Australia, who were waiting under the very noses of Germans to be found by Allied troops advancing inland. He asked again about his crew, but none of them were there.

The officer in charge of the forest camp was Jean de Blommaert, a Belgian member of British Intelligence, who had parachuted into France in April 1944 to implement "Operation Marathon," helping Allied airmen who had been shot down or crash-landed evade capture. The prudent Blommaert made arrangements with local resistance leaders to avoid any activity in or around Fréteval Forest, as it could attract unwanted attention and jeopardize the camp. He negotiated with local farmers, bakers and merchants to deliver food to the camp by horse and cart, and he set up an elaborate system of guides and safe houses to get airmen from other parts of France to the camp. Tents, medical supplies, cash and other needed items were parachuted into nearby fields at night.

The first evaders had arrived at the camp in late May, and its population had been growing ever since. By the time Tappan entered the camp in July, there was a roster of airmen standing regular guard duty and working as cooks, cleaners, lookouts and night fishermen. All tentage was camouflaged by foliage, which had to be changed whenever it started to dry out. A field hospital was set up away from the main camp, but the badly injured—mostly burn victims—were cared for in the homes of local residents. A doctor and a barber made weekly visits. The key to morale was hearing the latest war news, and a bulletin board with news from the BBC broadcasts went up in the center of camp.

Living conditions were not luxurious, but neither were they inadequate. The fact that he was with other airmen gave Tappan a feeling of camaraderie, although there was tension felt by all about the possibility of their large camp being found by the Germans.

Some events brought home that fear of discovery. One group of resistance fighters blew up a German gasoline dump a few miles away. The next day, German troops entered the outskirts of the forest and combed the place with machine-gun fire, believing that the partisans might be hiding in the nearby woods. But the Nazis were reluctant to go any farther into the forest for fear of an ambush.

Because Tappan spoke French, he was regularly sent into Châteaudun to pick up eggs, chickens and whatever else the townspeople could share. On one trip, he learned that five local residents had been pulled from their homes by the Germans and shot on suspicion of harboring Allied airmen. They went to their deaths not saying a word about the camp. Not for the first time, Ed Tappan realized how much he owed the freedom-loving people of France.

Two hundred and fifty miles away in the city of Roanne (population 40,000), evader Johnny Mead, formerly a Carpetbagger bombardier and now a de facto member of the resistance, had as a precaution remained off the streets for forty-eight hours after D-Day.

During the short lull, a surprise guest arrived at the home of “Babo” Bossanard—the FFI intelligence agent in charge of the Roanne area—where Johnny was staying. It was Johnny’s “nose buddy” from the Simon crew, navigator John Reitmeier. A firm handshake turned into a bear hug, and the two flyers were soon seated in the back garden surrounded by a high stone wall, smoking cigarettes, reflecting in almost disbelief that they were in the middle of occupied France, surrounded by Germans, when not so long ago they were flying above it all. Combined with the fact they had both been only a handful of missions from finishing their combat tours and returning to the States, the whole scenario seemed unreal.

Reitmeier caught his friend up on his experiences since bailing out of their burning plane. His parachute canopy flared near the ground, causing him to land hard, striking his head and injuring his back. After spending the night in an empty cabin, he walked to a village and saw people going to Mass. He connected with members of the local resistance, who took him to a series of houses where he stayed a few nights at each, and finally to the family home of Antoine and Lucette Buffet in Loddes, who put him up

for a month while other arrangements were made for him. Antoine then took him to the train station, where he met his guide, a young woman who accompanied him on a train filled with Germans to Roanne, where he was brought to Babo's residence.

When it was time for Johnny to resume his daily trips to the warehouse six blocks away to clean and assemble weapons, his navigator buddy accompanied him. Once again they worked side by side—not guiding a B-24 to a drop of weapons, but making them ready for combat.

A week later, the leaders of the ACOLYTE resistance circuit decided it was time to mobilize two new units. The largest group was to locate in the mountains north of Roanne, and the other one near the small village of Fragny, ten miles to the south, close to the banks of the meandering Loire River. Johnny was put in charge of the latter group and ordered to establish an arms depot and a base for sabotage operations.

A disappointed Reitmeier was in no condition with his bad back to make the trip. In fact, it had been arranged for him to see an orthopedic specialist in a few days. The flyers wished each other the best of luck.

On June 26, Johnny and two Frenchmen loaded up a box truck at the Roanne warehouse, covered the cargo and themselves with a tarpaulin and were driven through the city at midday. It was vital the shipment of arms reached their destination; the Frenchmen in the back of the truck had Sten guns and Johnny had his pistol. When they arrived outside Fragny, they unloaded the weapons and explosives—enough to arm a few hundred fighters—into an old barn on the side of a hill.

Johnny started his new group with just a dozen men under his command, but recruits—most in their twenties and some as young as fifteen—who were eager to join arrived daily, and that number doubled by the end of the first week. By the next month it had grown to sixty volunteers, whom Johnny described as “dedicated and brave men of all ages and every walk of life.” He gave instruction in U.S. field equipment—pistols, grenades, machine guns, bazookas—and a rugged, bilingual Alsatian who spoke English, Ferdinand Besch, who became Johnny's aide-de-camp, taught his specialties: ambush and sabotage.

Soon, practice was over. Johnny led a team that blew up a railroad bridge near the village of Changy that served the main line between Lyon and Roanne, halting rail traffic until repairs were made. Another ACOLYTE team carried out a mission near the town of Saint-Germain-Lespinasse, northwest of Roanne, blowing up tracks and overturning in a tunnel a locomotive pulling a German military train.

In early July, Johnny received a Carpetbagger drop at Fragny. As grateful as he was for the new supplies, Johnny wished he had been on the S-phone because he would have given the B-24 pilot a piece of his mind. For no discernible reason, the drop was made from nine hundred feet. As a result, the containers and packages were so widely scattered that it took until daylight to gather them up and move them off the field. *Newbies*, he decided. *The old crews would not have dropped so high.*

Word had spread of mixed results from a different kind of airdrop—not nighttime ones like the Carpetbaggers flew, but by a large formation of B-17s dropping at the same time over an area in broad daylight. The goal was to get quicker deliveries of munitions to larger groups of resistance fighters. But Johnny heard they were fraught with difficulties and starkly exposed the risks of mass daylight drops. During such a drop that month over a rugged plateau in the Vercors mountain range, a hundred miles south of Lyon, seventy-two B-17s dropped nearly nine hundred containers suspended beneath red, white and blue parachute canopies. The Luftwaffe was quick to react, strafing the landing field, dropping incendiary bombs, and firebombing the nearest village, Vassieux-en-Vercors, preventing the partisans from collecting even half the containers. And ten days later, two hundred SS troops attacked the same village, massacring more than four hundred civilians.

A few days after the first Carpetbagger drop to Johnny's group at Fragny, an unusual wireless telegraph message to the FFI in London came over one of the circuits used by the resistance, reporting that an American airman, Lt. John Mead, was in command of the *maquis de Fragny*. The FFI shared the information with the OSS, which passed it on to Harrington Airfield, where the astonishing news was received by the Carpetbaggers' group intelligence officer, Capt. Robert D. Sullivan.

Sullivan, or "Sully" as he was known to all—who was reputed to have the longest, best-waxed handlebar mustache in England—was not a flyer. After graduating from intelligence school in December 1942, he joined the anti-submarine squadron on the East Coast that later became one of the first Carpetbagger squadrons. When Johnny Mead joined the same squadron, he and his wife, Dorothy, lived next door to Sully and his wife, Aurelia, on the base in North Carolina, and the couples became close friends. Sully knew that Dorothy went back to living with her parents in Jacksonville, Florida, after Johnny went overseas and was now teaching elementary school.

As the intelligence officer, Sully was aware of Johnny having survived the crash of the Simon crew on May 5 and subsequently being allowed to stay with the resistance, but no one had heard anything from him since he shocked the Carpetbagger crew over

the S-phone on May 29—six weeks before. Now came word that he was in *command* of partisan fighters! Sullivan had to smile. *Good ol' Johnny, running true to form and giving 'em hell.* But Sully also knew another side to him: earnest, resolute and prayerful, a man who went to Mass not just on Sundays. Sully had no doubt his squadron mate could handle his new role in the war.

The next day, Sully was in a briefing room telling other officers about the latest message regarding their own Johnny Mead when a clerk came in and handed him an airmail letter. He opened the envelope quickly when he saw who it was from. Inside was a short, heartbreaking note from Dorothy Mead asking for “some crumb of information about Johnny.” So far, the only word she had received was the official telegram reporting her husband was “missing in action.”

The hell of it was, Sully couldn't tell her that Johnny had survived the crash of the Simon crew on May 5 and become an evader behind the lines in France, because doing so would break a litany of security measures meant to protect Johnny's life and the lives of untold others. He couldn't give her the kind of reassuring information she desperately sought. Rather, he would have to write back telling her not to give up hope, along with whatever other platitudes he hated having to spew. She had to wait, not knowing if her husband was dead or alive, until he made it back to England. That is, *if* his irrepressible friend made it back.



Newlyweds Johnny and Dorothy Mead.

COURTESY OF THE MEAD FAMILY

Toward the end of July, Johnny became concerned that the location of his unit's base of operations was known by too many people after a troop of Boy Scouts appeared one day at the barn door, which was wide-open, giving them a view of him instructing men in the use of a .50-cal. machine gun. The final straw came two nights later when a

shadowy group of men approached through the woods but withdrew when the tough Alsatian, who was on duty, challenged them and threatened to open fire.

The next morning, Johnny, not taking any chances, gave orders to empty the barn. Keeping what they could carry, some munitions were sent to the partisans operating north of Roanne, and the rest were buried in a nearby cornfield so they could be retrieved later. That night, Johnny and thirty armed partisans moved across a small valley in the moonlight to a hilltop with some abandoned field shacks and a 360-degree unobstructed view. He sent a messenger north to let the ACOLYTE leaders know the latest developments.

A few days later, one of the scouts Johnny sent out reported a force of Milice, thirty to forty strong, approaching their old hideout from the north. Johnny wasn't worried about that because the barn was empty, but would they go away when they found nothing? He soon had his answer when the uniformed, black-jacketed Milice entered the valley, heading their way.

Johnny ordered his men to take up defensive positions—including the placement of several .50-cal. machine guns with wide fields of fire—until he could appraise the situation and decide the best course of action. Then came worse news: some two hundred German soldiers were approaching up the hill from the opposite side. At that point, Johnny knew that someone must have spotted them over the past few days, because this was a coordinated attack.

Their right flank to the east was impenetrable terrain sloping sharply downward toward the main highway to Roanne, leaving their only viable escape route to the west, across a pasture of foot-high grasses and into a heavily wooded area. Despite some of his men wanting to stand and fight, Johnny knew it was foolhardy when they were surrounded. He ordered them to withdraw in twos and threes.

Before they could start out, two vehicles with mounted machine guns moved onto a narrow road beyond the pasture. Johnny and the Alsatian, each with a Sten gun and pistols, set out first to show the others how the escape could be done. Once across, they intended to provide covering fire for the others if necessary. But stealth, they knew, not firepower, would win this day. They crawled through the field and made it across the road without being seen. From the woods, they watched as their men followed, a few at a time. Once a group made it into the woods, they headed off in different directions. But the last two men crossing the field were spotted and drew enemy fire.

Johnny jumped out of the woods firing his weapon, trying to suppress the hostile fire long enough for his men to get across the field. One of the armored cars tore down

the road and skidded to a halt closer to them, the barrel of its machine gun pointed at the tall blond American wearing a red beret. Before Johnny could hit the dirt a burst of bullets whistled past him. His beret came flying off. *Shot off by a bullet!* He didn't stop to retrieve his lucky beret, as the German troops were charging toward them after killing the two partisans in the field.

Johnny and the Alsatian lit out through the forest. Their escape soon came to a halt at the Loire River. It was about half a mile across here, but there was no turning back, as their pursuers were thrashing through the woods behind them. They dropped their Sten guns into the bushes and jumped into the chilly waters. Johnny, who grew up swimming in the Atlantic off Florida, had no problem making it to the other side, and the powerful Alsatian was not far behind. A few shots rang out from the other side, but none of the enemy jumped into the water after them.

They headed for Saint-Polgues (population 200), where Johnny knew the mayor to be a friend to the resistance. Reaching the village the next morning, the mayor invited them to stay at his residence for a few days, which they did. After exchanging messages with the leaders of ACOYTE, Johnny was told to proceed to the mountains west of Roanne, where a new group that included men who had escaped from the hilltop was assembling.

Johnny and the Alsatian joined a group of sixty partisans at Tarare, thirty miles from Roanne. When they first entered the village they found a dozen fresh bodies—nine women and three men—who had been shot in cold blood by a retreating German officer. The situation in this part of France was tense and changing almost daily. The German occupational forces were showing signs of panic as the Allied armies were driving farther inland, and they were even more cruel than before, making arrests and executing civilians on the slightest pretext—not only hunting down Maquis with a vengeance but anyone suspected of aiding the resistance.

Johnny's group split into smaller bands and spread out over the area, cutting telephone lines, knocking out bridges, blowing up railroad tracks and trestles—anything to harass the enemy's communications, logistics and troop movements.

By late August, a second Allied invasion force, which had landed in the South of France two weeks earlier, was moving rapidly up the Rhône Valley toward Lyon, sixty miles east of Roanne. And to the west, de Gaulle's Free French Forces were moving toward Vichy at lightning speed to liberate the pro-Nazi capital.

Sent to Marcigny—twenty miles north of Roanne—Johnny's unit was placed under the command of Col. René Gentgen, who had formerly led an alpine infantry

regiment of the French army and was now the head of the Saint-Étienne intelligence network of the FFI. Gentgen put them in the field with other partisans to guard the bridge over the Loire River at Chambilly, thus blocking the German garrison at nearby Saint-Yan from sending reinforcements to the west or south toward the advancing Allied forces. (They guarded the bridge instead of blowing it up so it would remain usable to the Allies.) After the Germans withdrew, Johnny and his men entered Saint-Yan, where they found the bodies of thirty unarmed civilians who had been slaughtered by the retreating Germans in front of the town's only hotel.

On August 22, 1944, Johnny entered a liberated Roanne. Without a German uniform in sight and with townspeople now busy going about their daily lives, it was already a different city than the one he had left, riding in the back of a truck filled with munitions two months earlier but half a lifetime ago.

He knew his work with the resistance was at an end, and so did his commanding officer back at Harrington Airfield. The next day, he received this wire: "Congratulations on your good work. Suggest you return immediately if possible. Don't take any chances. Heflin." He was not surprised it took the colonel only twenty-four hours to realize he was out of work, but he laughed at his caution not to "take any chances." What a war.

As Johnny Mead's turn as a Carpetbagger-cum-guerrilla came to a close, he thought about the partisans he had fought with against their mutual enemy. He knew firsthand that much of France south of the Loire River had been liberated by the resistance. Of course, the powerful Allied invasion forces had made it possible. Still, the liberation of half their country was a great communal effort by the freedom-loving French people. It was his honor to have flown missions to arm them in their struggle and later fight by their side. He would never forget their courage and sacrifices.

Dorothy Mead soon received the Western Union telegram she had been praying would arrive. "My darling wife. Feeling fine. Miss you terribly. Love you with all my heart. Yours devotedly, Johnny."

It was a humid and already blistering August morning, but Ed Tappan, strolling down the road toward Châteaudun to pick up fresh eggs to take back to the camp in the Fréteval Forest, didn't mind at all. The errand broke up the monotony and beat some of the other communal jobs divvied up among the 152 flyers still waiting to be found by Allied troops. In fact, Ed took some pride in knowing he could pass for French, both in dress and speech, even if he was stopped and questioned.

Then, coming down the road, was a beautiful sight: three American G.I.'s in a mud-caked U.S. Army jeep.

Ed tried to flag down his countrymen, but they kept going.

They thought he was French—

“Wait, guys!” he yelled. “I’m an American pilot!”

They stopped, and he caught up with the jeep. The soldiers did not look pleased, as he thought they might be at coming across an American pilot. Quite the contrary. They greeted him with disbelief. Even if he could speak English, this guy *looked* French. Maybe he was a Nazi collaborator or even a German spy? They were reconnaissance scouts for a column of Gen. George Patton’s tanks, and in no mood to slow down or take chances.

“So who’s the Brooklyn Dodgers?” one G.I. asked.

“A baseball team,” Tappan replied, a bit too anxiously. “New York.”

“Who’s their manager?” the same wise guy asked.

Tappan was a cowboy from Arizona and could tell them a lot about horses and the rodeo, but he didn’t follow baseball at all.

“I don’t know. Look, fellas, I’m a B-24 pilot. Shot down last month. I’d like to go back to your lines. Will you take me?”

The G.I.’s looked reluctant to do so.

“There are a hundred and fifty other guys in the woods back there you should rescue, too. American, British, Canadian pilots.”

That got their attention, and he got his ride.

After interrogations by Army intelligence, Ed and the other airmen from the Fréteval Forest were soon winging their way back to England.

¹ The seven Broten crewmen who perished when their aircraft exploded in midair were: 1st Lt. John O. Broten (pilot), of Glen Ridge, NJ; 2nd Lt. Roy C. Gehue (navigator), of Bear River, Nova Scotia; 1st Lt. Alfred C. Emert (bombardier), of Seymour, TN; S/Sgt. Harry L. Sparks (engineer), of Piedmont, AL; S/Sgt. William Freidkas (radio operator), of the Bronx, NY; Sgt. Harry R. Ellis (dispatcher), of Longview, TX; and Sgt. Michael J. Pranzetelli (tail gunner), of Wallingford, CT.

FIFTEEN **LIBERTÉ!**

Soon after acquiring a new wireless set in a nighttime airdrop in late June, Nancy Wake learned that a group of partisans holed up in the forest had caught three women alleged to be spies and were using them as prostitutes. Nancy showed up unannounced at their camp and demanded the women be placed into her custody. Sitting as judge and jury to determine if they were innocent victims or Nazi spies, she questioned each of the women. The youngest was seventeen, and she tearfully swore she would never do a thing *contre la France*. Nancy believed her and ordered her freed. The second woman, in her thirties, fell in love with a man in the Milice and was being punished for her choice of lovers. While Nancy didn't condone her for sleeping with someone who helped the Nazis hunt down and kill partisans, the woman didn't deserve such appalling maltreatment. She was freed, too.

The third woman was a different matter. She announced her allegiance to the Nazis and admitted to being sent by the Germans to spy on the Maquis. Clearly, she could not be released and allowed to go back to the Gestapo with what she had learned. As Nancy told the woman, the circumstances left them no choice. "We cannot release you, and we do not have the facilities to keep you. This is war, and you must have known you would be shot if you were caught spying on the Maquis for the Germans."

Though these men had no problem with keeping three women against their will and sexually assaulting them, they initially drew the line at executing the female spy. Nancy wondered if they were more interested in keeping a camp prostitute than removing a security threat.

"*Si tu ne lui tires pas dessus, je le ferai,*" Nancy said evenly. [If you don't shoot her, I will.]

A dozen men hastily formed a firing squad. The condemned woman was placed before the trunk of an old pine tree. She refused a blindfold. As they lifted their rifles, she stared at Nancy, at whom she spat. Then she thrust an arm out in the Nazi salute. "*Sieg heil!*" were her last words before shots rang out and her shattered body fell to the ground.

Nancy knew that if the woman had escaped and reported back to the Gestapo partisans, lives would have been lost. Still, she realized in such moments just how much she had been changed by all the killing and suffering in war. She had felt an utter lack of emotion as the woman was executed on her orders. She didn't used to be so hard, but the enemy they were fighting had toughened her. It had started years earlier in Vienna when she first saw the mistreatment of Jews by storm troopers and vowed to hurt the Nazis however she could. Since then, the war had been the canvas for so many horrific scenes, some beyond comprehension.

One event she could not shake happened when she left a Maquis encampment for a brief visit to a nearby village. A troop of Germans arrived, blocking off the exits, and started a house-to-house search for a wanted resistance leader. They failed to locate him but found the man's wife, who was seven months pregnant, and two-year-old daughter. They were taken to the village square, where the wife was tied to a lamppost. A crowd that included Nancy gathered, and everyone was angry but helpless to do anything. Once, twice, three times, a German officer demanded the wife reveal the whereabouts of her husband, but she refused to say. The officer then barked an order to a soldier, and for the rest of her life Nancy would never forget what happened next. The German soldier walked up and slit the woman's stomach open with his bayonet. She bled to death in agony as her screaming toddler gripped her hand. Afterward, the Germans allowed someone to take the little girl away but posted a guard over the body of the slaughtered woman for twenty-four hours as an example to others who protected the resistance. All Nancy was able to do was watch in horror and solemnly swear to kill even *more* Nazis whenever she had the chance.

In July, Nancy was given one of those opportunities when she went on what she later called "the most exciting sortie I ever made." The idea for it came from

Henri Tardivat, the sweet-talking Frenchman who had helped Nancy out of the tree in April when her parachute became entangled. Since those earliest days after their landing in France when he had taken her and John Farmer around to meet other resistance leaders, Tardivat, who led his own partisan group, had become the Frenchman Nancy most admired as a leader, tactician and fighter. He was intelligent, reliable and brave, and he also had a sense of merriment, which Nancy appreciated in stressful times. When she was not on the road visiting resistance groups or organizing airdrops, he invited her to take part in some of his escapades—blowing up rail tracks, cutting phone lines, knocking out bridges. “She is the most feminine woman I know, until the fighting starts,” Tardivat told a comrade. “Then she is like five men.” Often the best plans fell apart when the first shots were fired, and Tardivat saw how Nancy could improvise, use instinct, and take initiative in these situations.

Enemy convoys passing through Tardivat’s area of operations were guaranteed to receive some damage. His group became adept at setting trip wires in suitable terrain. A wire attached to a tree on each side of the road was tripped by the first vehicle in the convoy and buried explosives blew it to smithereens. Tardivat and Nancy always enjoyed watching their handiwork from a nearby hill.



French Resistance leader Henri Tardivat, who fought alongside Nancy Wake.

SPECIAL FORCES ROLL OF HONOUR

When he sent a courier to her in late July asking if she had time to join him for “a bit of fun,” she showed up at his camp a few days later. They had both long been vexed by the presence of a Gestapo substation in Montluçon. Tardivat had devised an unusual plan to eliminate it in broad daylight. After careful reconnaissance, he believed the best time to attack was at 12:25 p.m., when the Gestapo officers—creatures of their indulgences—were sipping aperitifs shortly before their lunch, during which time the front and rear entrances to the building were left unattended.

On the day of the attack, Tardivat, Nancy and fourteen others left in four cars for Montluçon, where a group of partisans armed with Sten guns had preceded them and scattered into safe houses, ready to provide any support needed for their withdrawal after the attack. The cars pulled up to the substation at precisely 12:25 p.m. and the attackers rushed forward. Nancy and Tardivat dashed around the building to the back door and ran up a flight of stairs to the top floor, where the senior officers gathered for lunch. Nancy stopped at her assigned door as Tardivat went down the hallway to the next door. On his signal, she turned the handle, put her shoulder on the door and threw it open. Glimpsing startled Germans looking up at her, she tossed a hand grenade inside the room, slammed the door shut and ran for the stairs, with Tardivat close behind. Multiple explosions rocked the building as other partisans threw grenades into rooms through windows and doorways. When the smoke cleared, thirty-eight Gestapo lay dead inside the wrecked headquarters.

Within minutes, the partisans were making good on their getaway, but they didn't get far before they came to a crowd of waving and cheering civilians in the middle of the road. The residents had heard the series of explosions and thought they were being liberated. With a large garrison of German soldiers in the town, reprisals for such a demonstration after the attack would be swift. The partisans leaned on horns, threatened and cajoled, ordering everyone off the streets and back to their homes.

Emboldened by their success, Tardivat and Nancy decided to take their caravan twenty miles northeast to Cosne-d'Allier (population 2,000) to stop a passenger train—not to disable or rob it, but just to show they could do it. As the train pulled into the station, several armed partisans headed for the coal-burning engine to prevent it from moving forward, and others went through the cars directing the passengers to disembark. After presenting their papers and stating that their travel had nothing to do with helping the Germans, they were allowed to reboard. As the train pulled away, partisans on the platform called out, "*Vive la France!*" The message to their countrymen who had lived in fear for years was resounding: the resistance was gaining strength, and the Nazis were no longer the only ones who could stop trains and check papers.

A few nights later, an airdrop included a special package for Farmer and Nancy. Inside, they found British army uniforms—at last, they were able to show the flag rather than carry themselves incognito. Other SOE operatives all over France were doing the same thing, an intended signal to the populace that the Allies were already there and on their way to liberating the country. Attired in a khaki shirt and slacks, Nancy's rank slide on her collar had the three "pips," or small insignias, for a captain; equivalent to a lieutenant in the Royal Navy or RAF. Wherever she went, she would be accorded the privileges of rank, including snappy salutes from delighted Maquis, with whom she had for months lived in the forest and fought battles beside as equals.

On August 15, 1944, 150,000 American and Free French soldiers—making up the Sixth Army Group—landed at Côte d'Azur on the French Riviera, opening a second front in France. Caught in an Allied pincer movement from the west and the south, the Germans began withdrawing divisions out of the South of France in a desperate effort to move them back to Germany. Behind the lines, resistance groups mobilized to impede their retreat toward the Belfort Gap in the Vosges Mountains, thirty miles beyond which lay the Rhine and the gateway to Germany.

Spreading out his worn and well-used Michelin map before Nancy, Tardivat pointed to two bridges—a railroad and a road span—over the Allier River near the town where they had recently stopped the train.

"We must take out those bridges," he said.

Normally, they would have done advance planning on such an operation, as Tardivat had for the attack on the Gestapo station. But with the Germans coming their way, quick action was called for. Anticipating upcoming sabotage missions on an expanded scale, Nancy had weeks earlier started stashing explosives from nighttime airdrops in a cave. They assembled their team, loaded up the cars and returned to Cosne-d'Allier. In a daring daylight move, they drove right into the center of town to ensure there weren't any Germans they had to take care of first. They then headed for the twin bridges a short distance out of town.

The trick to blowing up a bridge, Nancy had learned, was to place explosives at its weakest point, which most often was underneath the structure near its

center point. Nancy and Tardivat—with explosives strapped to their backs—slid down ropes to the struts of the bridge and worked their way to the middle of the span, where they secured the charges. Setting the timers for five minutes, they quickly climbed back to the top, where they were appalled to find an audience of villagers congregating. They had come to watch the resistance in action and were chattering excitedly about how this same group of partisans led by the same *jeune femme* [young woman] had recently stopped one of their trains. It was a close call, but they were shooed off the bridge just in time.

The explosions knocked out enough weight-bearing supports to cause the bridge to crater in the middle, then the entire structure followed, with massive steel parts tumbling into the river below. Next, the nearby railroad bridge was blown, sending bridge segments as well as twisted tracks splashing into the Allier River.

Nancy took in the extraordinary scene before her. These must have been the most well-attended bridge demolitions of the war, even though what happened here was going to isolate the village of the celebrating locals and be a serious inconvenience to them for some time to come. But they didn't care. They were delighted that the Germans would not find the bridges they needed.¹

Next up for demolition was a large German munitions depot fifty miles to the southeast. It had four entry gates, and each was guarded by a pair of sentries. All eight sentries had to be neutralized before they could sound the alarm, Tardivat explained. From the bushes about a hundred yards away, Nancy and three partisans watched the silhouettes of the two guards at the gate they were assigned to take. As a security measure, the surrounding low scrub had been cleared some thirty feet in front of the gate, which meant they would be exposed on their final approach.

They started crawling slowly forward. There had been a recent rain, so the leaves didn't rustle as they closed the distance. It took nearly half an hour to reach the edge of the clearing. They were so close now, Nancy heard the crunching of jackboots on the wet gravel beneath the sentries. She watched as the sentries met in front of the gate, turned around, went back in the other direction, then repeated the routine.

With her heart pounding and her mouth so dry she couldn't swallow, she waited. When the sentries were moving in opposite directions and too far apart to be able to help each other, she gave the signal.

Jumping to their feet and breaking into a sprint, Nancy and one of her men headed for the sentry on the left, and the other two partisans went for the second sentry. When she was still a few paces away, the German spun around. In a flash, she saw his mouth gape in surprise and the glinting bayonet at the end of his rifle swing toward her. Reaching him first, she slammed the edge of her hand against the side of his neck below the ear and thrust her forearm under his jaw, snapping his head back. Suddenly a lifeless weight against her, the German slid to the ground like a bag of rocks. She and her men guarded the gate against a surprise attack while Tardivat and his men placed their bombs and explosives and set the timers. Then everyone faded off into the night and were a mile away when the munitions dump went up with a thunderous explosion that lit the sky.

Nancy was relieved to return to her room in a rural château she and her team had moved into a few miles outside Montluçon. She realized how spent she was, not just from that night's mission, but by the war. Since killing the sentry, she'd repeatedly wiped her hands on the side of her trousers, and she didn't know why. Was she trying to remove the taint of violence she had committed with those hands? She had practiced at the SOE school in Scotland to silently kill someone if that day ever came, and now it had. Killing was nothing new to her, but this time it had to be done not with guns or explosives but up close and personal.

She loathed the Germans—*loathed* them—and she had killed Nazis and ordered more to be killed without feeling any qualms at the time or remorse afterward. But never so close before as to feel against her body that of another human being the moment she extinguished their life.

Perhaps fittingly, the sentry was the last one, and that night's mission the last target and the last combat of the war for Nancy Wake.

After four years of Nazi occupation, Paris was liberated on August 25, 1944, when a column of American and Free French troops entered the city to find only scattered German snipers firing from rooftops and cheering crowds

greeting them with open arms. Gen. Charles de Gaulle, leader of the Free French government-in-exile, led a parade of troops down the Champs-Élysées and through the Arc de Triomphe.

Five days later, after organizing a nighttime airdrop, Nancy returned to the château to find a hundred partisans waiting to celebrate her thirty-second birthday. Bottles of long-hidden champagne and wine appeared, and she was presented with bouquets of colorful wildflowers picked in nearby fields by Frenchmen with whom she had fought.

A few days later, a message from London reported the German garrison in Vichy had made the same decision as their comrades in Paris and withdrawn without a fight. Nancy set out with John Farmer and wireless operator Denis Rake to drive the forty-five miles to Vichy to take part in the liberation of the pro-Nazi capital. Vichy France represented everything they had been fighting against, and they were determined to be there at its end. To their surprise, they were among the first to arrive and were greeted with the same reception the liberators received in Paris. There were tricolor French national flags flying and folks cheering, hugging, kissing, laughing and crying. A cappella voices caroled the most beautiful song in all of France: “*La Marseillaise*,” the national anthem since the eighteenth century. The second line of the first verse captured the mood of liberation: *Le jour de gloire est arrivé!* [The day of glory has arrived!] To Nancy, it felt like a cathartic and collective release for a people who had lived, suffered, resisted and survived under Nazi occupation. The revelries went on late into the night. In the morning, a ceremony was held in the town square to remember those who had lost their lives and give thanks that their city had emerged intact. Wreaths were laid and ranks of Maquis, still bearing the arms they had fought with, marched triumphantly in the streets.

Nancy was enjoying the spectacle when she saw the face of an old friend who had been the receptionist at the Hôtel Louvre et Paix in Marseille. She hurried to her side and the two women embraced. They had a difficult time hearing over the crowd noise and took turns bending close to each other’s ears to be heard.

“What are you going to do now, Nancy?”

“Go back to Marseille.”

Her friend looked perplexed. “Why are you going there?”

Nancy wasn't sure she heard right. Why *wouldn't* she go back? That was where she had left Henri a year ago. That was their home. There was no place on earth she would rather be now than with her husband.

Nancy answered, "To see Henri."

"Oh no, Nancy, don't you know? He's dead."

Before her friend could say another word, Nancy burst into tears. Even as they flowed, she pressed for details. But the woman knew only what she'd heard: that the Germans had killed him because he wouldn't cooperate with them.

Dear, sweet, wonderful, laughing Henri. Dead! For his safety and her own, she had not dared to contact him after her return to France four months earlier. But she hadn't doubted he was home managing his business, and they would be together again. After he didn't join her in England as planned, she did have the terrible nightmare that he was dead. But she had convinced herself it was unreasonable to let a dream unnerve her.

Nancy heard a primal scream of anguish. Did that sound come from her? Yes, because an alarmed Denis Rake was quickly at her side, taking her by the arm, keeping her from collapsing and leading her away. Farmer joined them, and the two men escorted her through the crowds to a quiet hotel lobby, where they sat down as she fought to regain her composure enough to tell them about Henri. "Anyone would have been torn apart by the news," Farmer later explained. "But in Nancy it seemed so much worse, because she was always such a happy, joyous soul. This was the only time I ever saw her seriously, seriously distressed."

"I want to go to Marseille," she finally announced.

They understood, and soon they were all in a big red Talbot automobile barreling south toward the port city three hundred miles away. When they reached the river Rhône south of Lyon, they found every bridge had been blown. After being told by local authorities that it was impossible to get across, Nancy found a riverman who owned an old flatbed ferry and made an impassioned plea for him to take them and the car to the other side.

When they reached Marseille, it was still in a state of siege, with pockets of German holdouts and streets filled with American soldiers and vehicles, and more pouring ashore from docked ships.

Nancy arranged where to meet her two friends later and took off on a journey she had to make alone. Her first stop was a neighborhood butcher's shop whose proprietors she knew from the local resistance. It was closed, but she went around to the back and rapped on a window, hoping the butcher and his wife would answer. When the door opened, the look on the butcher's face told her he had hoped he wouldn't have to be the one to give her the bad news. Nancy stepped inside and said she'd been told Henri was dead and wanted to know everything that had happened.

Gradually, the pieces fell together, although it took several days to get the full story from a number of people. Among those she spoke to was a Protestant pastor who had survived the same Gestapo prison where Henri ended up. As she feared when she fled Marseille following the series of arrests in the O'Leary network, the group had been infiltrated. In early May 1943—a month after she left—Henri opened the apartment door to a man who gave the correct O'Leary password, to which Henri gave the correct response. The man was a Gestapo agent, and within minutes Henri was under arrest and on his way to Gestapo headquarters on the Rue Paradis. Soon suspicious that Henri's missing wife, Madame Fiocca, was the much-wanted "White Mouse" resistance organizer they had long sought, they subjected Henri to daily beatings and torture to get information out of him. When they couldn't break him, Gestapo agents went to Henri's father and said the only way his son could be saved was by telling them everything about his wife's whereabouts and all her contacts in the resistance. The father went into the prison and tried to convince Henri to do just that, said the pastor. Through "shattered teeth and bloodied lips," Henri told his father to never again speak to him of such things. He would not cooperate with the Nazis, and that was the end of it. The pastor said Henri, his back "caved in from beatings," was taken from his cell and shot at dawn on October 16, 1943.

Nancy blamed herself for Henri's death, and she always would. Suspicion had fallen on them both because she had stayed involved in resistance activities for too long in Marseille and taken too many chances. If the city was unsafe for her to stay, as she believed it was by spring 1943, it was also too dangerous for Henri. She should never have left without him. Had they gone together, he would still be alive.

She had one last stop to make before leaving Marseille and returning to Paris, where she, Farmer and Rake were to catch a flight back to London, as the F Section was recalling agents and shutting down networks that were being overrun by advancing Allied forces.

She hadn't had the heart before to visit the beautiful apartment overlooking the Marseille harbor where she and Henri had lived and loved. It was beautiful no longer. While the walls were still standing, all their furniture and personal effects were gone or lying broken and violated on the floor. Whoever had lodged there after Henri's arrest had ransacked the place before pulling out in a hurry. Only later did she learn that it was three female Gestapo agents who had taken over the apartment.

The one personal relic that survived she found in the cellar. Henri's wines had been consumed or taken, but on the floor under some rubble was her cherished edition of *Anne of Green Gables*. It was the heartwarming story of a spirited young orphan girl whose indomitable spirit and endearing antics had once inspired another young and adventurous girl named Nancy to make her own way in the world. She sat on the floor, turned to the opening page and wept—tears of joy, and of sadness.

¹ During their retreat from southern France, vengeful German soldiers plundered and burned down town after town and carried out mass executions of civilians for alleged partisan activities. These atrocities did not subdue the uprising among the French populace. In fact, after the second Allied landing in the south, greater numbers of civilians joined the fight against the Nazis; even members of the Milice defected to the resistance, bringing with them their weapons and military training.

SIXTEEN

THE LAST CREW

Thirty-two B-24s took off on a stormy night from Harrington Airfield on September 16, 1944, for drop zones in the Haute-Marne region of northeastern France, where two SOE resistance circuits were still operating only a hundred miles from the German border. It was to be the final night of operations to supply resistance forces inside France.

The Liberator flown by 1st Lt. James M. McLaughlin, of Springfield, Illinois, was the last to take off at 10:30 p.m. His veteran crew had flown twenty-five daylight bombing missions—mostly over Germany—before arriving at Harrington a month earlier as a replacement crew. Tonight was to be their tenth Carpetbagger mission, which would give them credit for a total of thirty-five combat missions—now the magic number to punch their return tickets back to the continental United States (known in Army lingo as CONUS.)

Their longtime copilot, 1st Lt. Mellicent S. “Buck” Moorhead, of Allegheny County, Pennsylvania, had reached the thirty-five-mission “top” two days earlier as a result of an extra combat mission he’d flown months before with another crew. With Moorhead now awaiting his orders to CONUS, McLaughlin had been sent another copilot just for tonight. The McLaughlin crew was becoming increasingly superstitious—as were most crews—the closer they came to finishing their tour, and they thought it bad luck to have an outsider on their last mission. Also, it took many hours flying together for a pilot and copilot to meld into a well-functioning team, as McLaughlin and Moorhead had long ago done. Their roles in the cockpit were so seamless that their communications usually consisted only of glances and hand signals. Moorhead kept careful watch on the oil pressure, oil temperature and cylinder-head pressure, since they were usually the first indications of an engine problem. He was deft at making adjustments to

the mixture of fuel and air entering the engine's cylinders, along with keeping engine temperatures in check—the latter by cracking open the flaps located at the bottom of an engine's cowling—all of which could alleviate a potentially dangerous situation. He also monitored the radar altimeter that measured their exact height above the terrain to ensure they didn't hit a mountain or hillside in low-visibility conditions. While he did all this, the tall, lanky McLaughlin stayed hands-on flying the bomber. In the squadron briefing room that afternoon, Moorhead found his buddy "Mac" and offered to fly with him that night, which the pilot was happy to hear. But a couple of hours later, McLaughlin had a change of heart. "Buck, you're finished," he told the copilot. "You have your thirty-five. Don't take the chance."

After takeoff, McLaughlin gained altitude over England, hoping as he did to get above the storm. Instead, the weather only worsened. Flying through thick soup with zero visibility and against howling winds that meant constant adjustments were required to remain on course, McLaughlin, known as a "good instrument man," utilized all his skills as they crossed the Channel. From there, they proceeded into France toward their drop zone—code-named BOB 269—near the town of Charmes, just south of the city of Nancy, which had been liberated the previous day by U.S. forces after a ten-day battle.

When they were ten minutes from their target, the overcast began breaking up and they saw patches of the ground. Normally, this was good news, giving them a better chance of spotting the signal lights and completing their mission. But this time, the clearing skies were not their friend.

As McLaughlin began to descend to a lower altitude, they were suddenly hit by a flak barrage of AAA fire from the ground that was devastatingly accurate. The first burst hit the trailing edge of the B-24's tail section, blowing off the elevator—a primary control surface for pitching the nose of the aircraft up and down. The plane fell off to the right. In the hands of a skilled pilot, various combinations of power, flap and trim settings offered a limited amount of pitch control, but McLaughlin realized—as the nose rose steeply—that the twin rudders on the tail were also not working. He had no control over the aircraft and knew what was coming next: an unrecoverable stall.

McLaughlin sounded the bail-out alarm, then turned toward the copilot, 2nd Lt. Carl E. Lee Jr., of Sacramento, California, who, on his tenth combat mission, normally flew with the Doyle crew. The cockpit window on Lee's side was broken, and he had been struck in the head and was obviously dead. McLaughlin rushed from the cockpit and followed his radio operator, S/Sgt. Henry Stec, of Brooklyn, New York, out the bomb bay.

McLaughlin landed high up in a tree in a darkened forest. Freeing himself from his chute, he worked his way down to the ground and hid in the woods until daybreak. Finding empty K-ration boxes—light meals distributed to U.S. ground troops—he felt certain he was behind American lines. A short time later, he met up with some G.I.'s, who escorted him to their regimental headquarters of the 79th Infantry Division, which had landed on Utah Beach a week after D-Day and been in combat ever since. McLaughlin told his story to an intelligence officer and the next morning was taken to the crash site. An Army mortuary affairs team was on the scene, and McLaughlin, stricken to learn that only he and the radio operator made it out safely, helped to identify the bodies of his crew.¹

Before beginning his journey back to England, McLaughlin was taken to meet members of Battery A, 115th AAA Gun Battalion, who operated four powerful 90mm antiaircraft guns. They felt as bad as he did. They had just moved into the area a few days prior, they told him, and their orders were to fire at any aircraft not showing IFF (Identification Friend or Foe), an electronic device that emitted a radio signal at one frequency, prompting an IFF transponder to emit a reply signal at a different frequency, indicating that an approaching aircraft was friendly. McLaughlin and other Carpetbagger pilots used the IFF system leaving or returning to England so as not to be shot down by British gunners but were under orders never to use it over France for fear it would help the Germans find them when they didn't want to be found.

Without an IFF signal, the Battery A gunners saw in the sky in the wee hours of September 17, 1944, an unidentified all-black aircraft.

“Friendly fire” shot down the last Carpetbagger crew.

From January to September 1944, the Carpetbaggers flew 2,263 nighttime missions over Nazi-occupied territory, delivering to resistance forces some 10 million pounds of supplies and dropping more than 500 agents and special forces operators behind enemy lines. At their peak, the Carpetbaggers numbered about 250 officers and 1,500 enlisted. They lost 33 B-24s to enemy fighters, antiaircraft fire, ground collisions, mechanical failures and bad weather—costing the lives of 229 airmen.

After France was liberated, Eisenhower estimated the contribution of the French resistance forces was equal to five Army divisions, or approximately 75,000 combatants. After the war, Eisenhower wrote: “In no previous war, and in no other theater in this war, have resistance forces been so closely harnessed to the main military effort.” He believed the organized, armed and trained resistance forces in the occupied territories had shortened the war by six months.

The French Croix de Guerre with Palm was awarded to the Carpetbaggers. The citation read: “A magnificent unit, distinguished by its dash, courage, and spirit of sacrifice. From 4 January to 17 September 1944, it flew over 2,000 night and day combat missions, in unprotected planes, over French territory that was still [enemy] occupied. It dropped, by parachute, many arms and such equipment for the use of the French Forces of the Interior, under conditions which were rendered perilous by fighter planes and very vigilant antiaircraft. It thus made a great contribution to the Allied war effort and to the liberation of French territory.”

A United States Distinguished Unit Citation, now known as the Presidential Unit Citation, was awarded to the Carpetbaggers: “For extraordinary heroism, determination, and esprit de corps in action against the enemy.... For extremely hazardous military air operations in flights of individual aircraft, during the hours of darkness at very low altitude, personnel of this organization demonstrated a high degree of courage and proficiency, executing missions in the face of vigorous enemy countermeasures, unfamiliar terrain and adverse weather.... It is safe to say that no group of this size has made a greater contribution to the war effort.”

In 2018, the Carpetbaggers, along with members of the OSS, were awarded the Congressional Gold Medal—the highest civilian honor given by Congress—

for their efforts in establishing, arming and training intelligence networks and resistance operations during World War II.

I. The dead crewmen who came within one mission of returning home from the war were: 1st Lt. George F. Bradbury (navigator), of Athens, AL; 2nd Lt. Ernest C. Skwara (bombardier), of Cleveland, OH; T/Sgt. Alfonse A. De Vries (engineer), of Grand Rapids, MI; S/Sgt. Merrill E. Brewer (dispatcher), of Worcester, MA; and S/Sgt. James G. Pirtle (tail gunner), of Portland, OR.

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DRAMATIS PERSONAE

THE FLYBOYS

John B. “Johnny” Mead. *Bombardier, Simon Crew.* Half a century after the war ended, he wrote to the widow of a Frenchman he had fought alongside, explaining how the Carpetbagger aircrews “felt close to the partisans below who received the containers we dropped.” He felt even closer to them after parachuting from his burning B-24 in May 1944. As the only Carpetbagger to be attached to the French resistance in the war, the downed flyer had a ground-level view of how vital the partisans were not only to the liberation of their own country but to the greater Allied war effort, particularly after the D-Day landings. In spite of the message from his commanding officer to “return immediately” to England after his stint with the resistance ended, Johnny was waylaid by a higher authority for a new assignment. An Army general requested his assistance in the clandestine return of some 1,500 U.S. military personnel interned in Switzerland—most of them airmen whose planes, unable to make it back to England, had landed in that neutral country. Publicly, the Swiss government declared that none of its Allied or German prisoners would be released until the end of the war. But they quietly allowed a series of nighttime flights by unmarked aircraft in and out of Bern to bring out the Americans in fall 1944. When Johnny at last returned to England, he learned he had been promoted to captain and approved for two Silver Stars, the U.S. armed forces’ third-highest military decoration for valor in combat: one for “gallantry in action against the enemy and outstanding leadership” while fighting with the French resistance; the second for his “courage, cool judgement, and utter disregard for personal safety” in assisting his “dazed and helpless” crewmen to bail out of their burning B-24. In November 1944, he returned home to his wife,

Dorothy, in Florida a few days before his twenty-fifth birthday. Granted a short furlough prior to his new assignment as a stateside instructor at bombardier school, he accepted the invitation of a Jacksonville civic group to speak at a luncheon. He “touched briefly on some of his experiences,” according to a newspaper account before he noted somberly, “the glamour passes after a few combat missions, and the war then becomes a grim business.” After his discharge from the Army, he returned to the insurance business in New Orleans. Over the years, he kept up correspondence with many of the partisans with whom he fought, and he attended several Carpetbagger reunions, where he swapped stories with old flying buddies. But at home, according to daughter Elaine McRae, “he didn’t talk about the war.” Johnny and Dorothy were married for sixty-two years. He died in 2005 at age eighty-six.

John A. Reitmeier. *Navigator, Simon Crew.* A week after he remained behind at the Roanne home of civil engineer M. Bossanard—the FFI intelligence agent code-named “Babo”—the Gestapo arrived to arrest Bossanard. Reitmeier was able to slip out the back door and escape through the yard. (He later learned that Babo was liberated by the Maquis an hour before he was to be executed.) With the help of the resistance, Reitmeier reunited with bombardier Johnny Mead in the forest outside of Fragny and for two weeks gave weapons instruction to new partisan recruits. Eventually, Reitmeier was relocated to a series of small farms, where welcoming families hid him until it was safe to travel. On September 5, 1944, he presented himself at an advance U.S. airfield twenty miles from the city of Lyons and was flown back to England via Italy, Algiers and Casablanca. On September 19, he arrived at Harrington Airfield, where he learned about the fate of his other crew members. Pilot Murray Simon was already home, copilot French Russell had returned to England in July, and the International Red Cross reported flight engineer Leo Dumesnil and tail gunner Graham Hasty were being held in Stalag Luft POW camps. The next day, the last two unaccounted-for Simon crewmen showed up at the base: radio operator Phillips Latta and dispatcher Homer Collier, telling the stories of their survival thanks to the help of the French. After returning to the U.S., Reitmeier became a navigation instructor. Following his discharge, he went back to his job as a

carpenter in the construction trades. He married twice and had a son, Glenn. In 1980, the former Carpetbagger wrote to Philippe Bailly, the first Frenchman who had helped him. "I am forever grateful because you were the friend who led me on the path of liberation." He returned twice to France to thank his many helpers and their families in person. He died in 2000 at age eighty-two.

Graham S. "Gray" Hasty. *Tail Gunner, Simon Crew.* Not long after being escorted by a German soldier through the bombed-out streets of Frankfurt and barely escaping an angry mob, Gray Hasty entered his first POW camp, Stalag Luft IV, which housed 8,000 American and 820 British airmen in four large compounds. Twin barbed-wire fences nine feet high surrounded the compounds, each of which consisted of ten long barracks. Searchlights and machine guns were mounted on towers, and guards with police dogs patrolled twenty-four hours a day. Food, or lack of it, became the most important thing in the lives of the prisoners. A typical menu for a day: breakfast, none; dinner, a thin barley soup; supper, a thin potato or cabbage soup. At times a bit of stringy meat of uncertain pedigree found its way into the soups. Each of the rooms inside a barrack housed twenty-five prisoners, and food was delivered to every room—always cold—in a galvanized mop bucket from which the POWs served themselves. By Gray's third week, he had settled into the monotony of camp life, broken only by early-morning formations for the guards to do a head count, occasional softball or football games and ever-popular bridge tournaments. Shortly after Gray arrived, his fellow Simon crew member Leo F. Dumesnil entered the camp, increasing the number of Carpetbaggers there to fifteen, from seven different crews. They were among the 93,941 American POWs in a system of nearly a hundred camps for Allied prisoners spread throughout Germany and Nazi-occupied countries. The Germans allowed a POW to write three letters a month, and Gray penned his first one to his fiancée, Mickey, to assure her he was okay, although he had no idea when or even if she would receive it. There was no limit on the number of letters a POW could receive, and Gray was soon receiving letters from home, as once Mickey had an address for him she wrote a letter every day. "Oct. 22, 1944. Dear Gray, The end of another lovely Sunday which would have been perfect if you could have been here, and darling, please remember

that whatever I do or wherever I go, there is always that feeling of something (the most important something to me) lacking—your presence, dear.... Darling, it will be so wonderful when you get home to say all the things I haven't said in these letters.... I love you, Mickey." Her missives helped him hold on until Stalag Luft I on the Baltic Sea—where he spent his last four months of captivity—was liberated by the Russians. The war with Germany ended on May 6, 1945, one year to the day after Gray's B-24 went down. U.S. transport aircraft were sent to shuttle the Americans to a tent city in France used as a holding place for men waiting to go home. After two weeks, he was flown to England, where he paid a visit to Harrington Airfield. The only person left at the base from the old days was a mechanic, who told him when the Simon crew failed to return the crew chief in charge of the ground crew that serviced their plane "cried liked a baby." In July, Gray crossed the Atlantic on a merchant ship loaded with G.I.'s. From Boston, he took a bus to Atlanta and called Mickey from the station. They wed the following month. Discharged from the Army in October 1945, he worked as a stage manager for Atlanta's first TV station and in later years started a number of businesses, from frozen food products to women's clothing. In 1995, Mickey suggested Gray write his memoir so what he'd gone through in the war "wouldn't be lost." In longhand on yellow legal pads, he penned, *4 Years, 4 Months, 4 Days*. It was the first time that their three adult children knew about what had happened to their father in the war. Gray died in 2007 at age eighty-six, six days after Mickey passed away.

Edward "Ed" Tappan. *Copilot, Broten Crew.* After he was liberated by G.I.'s in August 1944 while walking near his hideout with some 150 other Allied airmen in the Fréteval Forest, Ed flew back to the United States, and home to his wife, Margaret. Although it was clear to him by then that he was the sole survivor of the Broten crew, the rest of the men continued to be classified as missing in action (MIA). Pilot John Broten's well-connected businessman father, Oscar Broten, wrote to higher-ups in the government pleading for information but was stonewalled. Ed, who by then was based at Douglas Army Airfield in Arizona, where he was teaching Chinese pilots to fly twin-engine B-25 Mitchell bombers, could not respond to direct appeals from the families due to security. However,

that did not stop his wife from writing to John's wife, May Broten, in November 1944. *"Dear May, I'm sorry I haven't written you sooner but Ed is terribly nervous and doesn't like to talk about his experiences and it has taken a while for me to get the story from him. The plane was attacked by a night fighter (German) and was hit. It blew up in mid-air and blew Ed out. He was burned and knocked unconscious. He never saw any of them after that but the French civilians took care of him and later told him that the rest of the crew had been killed and that they had been taken to a beautiful burial place in Orléans, France, and that several hundred people had attended and brought many flowers.... I can't understand why the Army still has them listed as missing. Ed said they were a great combat crew and he is very proud to have been one of them. I'm awfully sorry, May, and wish there was something I could do. Ed looks alright to a stranger but he is very much broken up and those of us who know him best can only guess how badly.... Please accept our deepest sympathy. Love, Margaret."* The Army finally declared in February 1945 the rest of the Broten crew killed in action (KIA). After the war, Ed raised and trained quarter horses on their Tucson ranch, where he and Margaret reared four sons. Over the years, he corresponded with the French families who had sheltered him during the war. In 1994, he returned to France for the first time to thank his helpers and their families and visit farms and villages where he was warmly welcomed back. Ed died in 1996 at age seventy-five.

Eugene "Gene" Polinsky. *Navigator, Ellis Crew.* The actor-cum-navigator flew his thirty-fifth and last combat mission on August 10, 1944. Before leaving England and the war behind, he was ordered to "forget everything you saw and did" with the Carpetbaggers. Although he didn't talk about it at the time, Gene never thought he would die in the war. "I said to myself, nothing can ever touch me. I'm perfectly fine. I'm fine. It worked for a long time.... If you let it bother you, it would destroy you." After he boarded the luxury liner *Queen Mary*—converted to a troopship—in Scotland, they waited a long while for a late-arriving VIP passenger: British prime minister Winston Churchill. As he stepped from a car, he lit up a big cigar and flashed his famous "V for Victory" to the cheering troops at the railings. Following close behind Britain's wartime

leader were Royal Marines carrying cases of champagne and liquor. The ship stopped at Halifax, Nova Scotia, to let Churchill off for a meeting before continuing on to New York. Gene made it home to New Jersey in time for his twenty-fourth birthday in September. After a brief furlough, he was sent to an air base in Texas to teach navigation for the remainder of the war. In future years, Gene returned to the professional stage, as he had hoped, and famed acting coach Lee Strasberg became his teacher and mentor. Eventually, Gene founded an off-Broadway theater, earned two Grammy Awards and worked as an actor, writer, producer and theater critic. He and wife, Mary—they met in college in 1937—had four children. When asked near the end of his life what he wanted his grandchildren to know about his wartime service, he said, “That we were fighting to make a better world. There’s a Hebrew tradition known as *tikkun olam*. We wanted to heal the world.” Gene died in 2022 at age 101.

THE SECRET AGENTS

Nancy Wake. *SOE agent, F Section.* She was one of ten female agents (Josephines) dropped into France by the Carpetbaggers. Her family legend has it that upon her birth in New Zealand, the Māori midwife who delivered her cradled the infant in the crook of her arm and pointed out to Nancy’s mother the thin veil of skin that covered the top of the infant’s head. “That is a *kahu* and it means your baby will always be lucky,” the midwife said, tracing her finger across the fold. “Wherever she goes, whatever she does, the gods will look after her.” Perhaps that was true. Overcoming a lifelong fear of heights to parachute from a B-24 on a dark night over Nazi-occupied France—with a helpful push by the plane’s dispatcher—her fearless exploits as a British secret agent with the French resistance made her one of the most decorated servicewomen of World War II. In Paris after its liberation, she had an emotional reunion with Col. Maurice Buckmaster, who had flown over from London to lavish praise on his SOE agents for what they had achieved in France. Dining in Paris at the British Officers Club that had formerly been the German Officers Club, Nancy and a woman friend, both in British army uniforms, were apparently too slow in

placing their orders with an impatient waiter. He muttered in French—which he assumed the Englishwomen did not understand—that he preferred Germans any day to the rotten British. Nancy followed him back to the kitchen, delivered a few choice words, then planted a solid blow to his jaw. He fell flat on his back, unconscious. A few minutes later the manager marched over with the Third Secretary of the British Embassy, who had been dining at another table. The Briton took one look at Nancy and guided the manager away. “Do you know that just a few weeks ago,” the diplomat told the Frenchman, “that woman was killing Germans who would make mincemeat out of you and your waiter?” Nancy was soon downing a complimentary glass of her favorite vintage brandy. In later years, whenever she was asked what she was most proud of doing during the war, her answer was the same: “The bike ride”—nearly four hundred miles in seventy-two hours to get an urgent message to London that they needed a new radio to set up more airdrops. Her only regret in the war, she claimed: “Not having killed more Nazis.” Revered as a heroine in France, she was awarded that country’s highest military honors for bravery: the Légion d’Honneur, three Croix de Guerre and a Médaille de la Résistance Française “for distinguished services in active resistance to the enemy.” She also received Britain’s coveted George Medal “for brave conduct in hazardous circumstances”; the United States Medal of Freedom “for performing meritorious deeds aiding the United States in the prosecution of the war”; and a Companion of the Order of Australia for “achievement and merit of the highest degree for service to Australia or humanity at large.” The fall of Vichy France made the eventual outcome of the war clearer, although there were to be many more months of bitter fighting elsewhere before Germany’s unconditional surrender in May 1945. But Nancy’s active part in it was over. She flew to London on October 16, 1944, her mission accomplished. After the war, she found herself ill-suited for civilian life. “It was dreadful because I’d been so busy and then it all just fizzled out,” she told the *Australian* in 1983. She turned to politics in Australia and twice stood for the Liberal Party (1949 and 1951) but lost both races. In 1957, she married John Forward, a former RAF pilot and an executive with an Australian textile firm. After his death in 1997, she returned to England in the hope of meeting up with her surviving friends from the war. “I want to be

cremated,” she told a friend late in life. “And I want my ashes to be scattered over the mountains where I fought with the resistance. That will be good enough for me.” In keeping with her wishes, Nancy’s remains were scattered among the summertime wildflowers of Montluçon after she died in 2011 at age ninety-eight.

Violette Szabo. *SOE agent, F Section.* After her capture in June 1944 following a roadside shootout with members of the SS Panzer Division Das Reich, Violette’s fate was sealed when she was transported to Fresnes Prison in Paris before her fellow agents could carry out a bold plan to rescue her. Interrogated at the infamous building on Avenue Foch, the French headquarters of the *Sicherheitsdienst*—the SS intelligence agency headed by Heinrich Himmler—no evidence ever surfaced that under extreme duress (and likely torture) she identified any agents or divulged other secrets. In August, she and her fellow French Section agents Denise Bloch and Lilian Rolfe—both had been born in Paris, recruited by the SOE for their French fluency and parachuted into France in spring 1944—were put on a train to Germany with thirty-six male prisoners, many of them Allied agents. At Saarbrücken, the men were directed to Buchenwald and the women to Ravensbrück, a vast women’s camp operated by the SS. Although Ravensbrück was not an extermination camp with gas chambers, as a matter of policy women were worked to death: they died from severe exhaustion, malnutrition, beatings and lack of medical care. First sent to a subcamp, where they worked on farms and roads, the three women returned to the main camp as a bitter winter descended and worked outdoors in only thin dresses, clearing a site for the construction of a new airfield. It was exhausting labor: lifting heavy objects, digging out large tree stumps and carrying boulders. Pneumonia, dysentery and tuberculosis took a toll, as did the cold, exhaustion and beatings. Eventually, the three SOE agents who had arrived together were pulled off working parties and put into cells in the punishment block. Even as Hitler’s thousand-year Reich was collapsing on the battlefields, the Gestapo sent orders from Berlin to the camps for every Allied agent they held to be executed before they could be liberated. For Violette, Denise and Lilian that day came on February 5, 1945—three months before the end of the war—when they were

removed from their cells at 7 p.m. and taken to a courtyard by the crematorium. By then, Lilian was so ill she could not walk on her own, and Violette and Denise kept her upright between them. The camp commandant read aloud the execution orders in the presence of the camp doctor, an SS sergeant and two SS corporals. According to the testimony at a later war crimes trial, the three women were “very brave.” After they were ordered to their knees, a corporal came up behind each of them with a handgun and fired a single bullet through the back of the neck. After death was certified by the doctor, the corpses were removed by internees who worked in the crematorium, where the bodies were burned. Violette, Lilian and Denise were among the fourteen female SOE agents who died for the liberation of France. Twenty-three at the time of her death and a veteran of two missions into Nazi-occupied France, Violette was posthumously awarded the George Cross for a “magnificent example of courage and steadfastness,” the Croix de Guerre and the Médaille de la Résistance Française. Violette and her husband, Etienne, whose battlefield death fighting the Germans in North Africa she so sought to avenge, are believed to be the most decorated married couple of World War II. The Greater London Council put up a plaque on the wall of the house where Violette grew up on Burnley Road in South London. In 2007, their daughter, Tania Szabo, wrote a book about her mother, titled *Young, Brave and Beautiful*.



Plaque in front of Violette Szabo's family home.

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A work of narrative nonfiction must be meticulously researched before there are any attempts at writing compelling prose. This is not to say the latter is somehow less important. As David McCullough once advised his fellow historians, “No harm’s done to history by making it something someone would want to read.”

In my deep dive into the story of the World War II Carpetbaggers, I accumulated details, details and more details before I began writing. (Honestly, there is no such thing as having *too much* to choose from, only the peril of not having enough.) There are a number of individuals and publications that aided my search for what was needed to tell this story that was kept hidden for decades, even after most of the records of that war were declassified.

The dedication and work of the late Tom Ensminger (1946–2012) helped make this book possible. After taking an early retirement as a civil servant in the federal service, he devoted his efforts full-time for fifteen years to the historical recovery of the Carpetbaggers—the 801st/492nd Bomb Group. Motivated by the fact that his late father, Leo J. Ensminger, was a Carpetbagger who was badly wounded on his eighteenth mission in August 1944, Tom produced voluminous information about the airmen, the aircraft and their secret missions for the OSS and SOE. He privately published *Spies, Supplies and Moonlit Skies* and established a website (www.801492.org) that documents every crew, aircraft and mission they flew and every secret agent they dropped behind enemy lines. It is remarkable how many records remained buried in archives or on dusty rolls of long-forgotten microfilm that Tom found, then used his analytical skills to organize for future researchers and authors. There are two other volumes written by individuals closely connected to the Carpetbaggers that were very helpful in piecing together this story: the late Ben Parnell’s *Carpetbaggers*:

America's Secret War in Europe (Ben's brother, Garrett C. Parnell Jr., was a Carpetbagger who was killed in the war) and the late Robert Fish's *Memories of the 801st/492nd Bombardment Group* (Bob was one of the top commanders of the group). Also, many thanks to Phil Swearngin for his historical research.

Magazine writer Katie Sanders, whose late grandfather was Carpetbagger pilot Murray Simon, first brought this story to my attention and provided research material for this book. A trunk of her grandfather's letters and memorabilia in her mother's attic had first spurred Katie to find out about the man she never knew. In the intervening years, she interviewed veterans and their families, visited France to thank the families who had helped her grandfather evade capture, went to Carpetbagger reunions and even took a hop in a vintage B-24.

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR



BRUCE HENDERSON is the #1 *New York Times* bestselling author of more than twenty nonfiction books, including *Sons and Soldiers*, *Bridge to the Sun*, and *Rescue at Los Baños*. An award-winning journalist and author, Henderson has taught at USC School of Journalism and Stanford University. He lives in Menlo Park, California. Visit his website: BruceHendersonBooks.com.

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SOURCES

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Abate, Arthur G.
Abernethy, Curtis A.
Adamson, Donald C.
Agneta, Nicholas J., Jr.
Albers, Edward J.
Albrecht, Robert H.
Albright, James K. W.
Alford, William T.
Allan, Robert C.
Allen, William F.
Ambrose, George W.
Anderson, James L.
Anderson, Karl A., Jr.
Anderson, Lester W.
Anderson, Lloyd L.
Anderson, Loren G.
Anderson, Rosslyn C.
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Andrews, Howard F.
Archambault, Charles E.
Archer, Robert H.
Arensburg, Robert L.
Arlin, Leo
Armstrong, Harold, Jr.
Arnold, Noland V.
Arnold, Robert L.

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Auda, Robert F.
Babik, Leo P.
Babin, Minor J.
Baker, Elbert L.
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Baldino, Michael A.
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Barton, Jack P.
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Beaman, Ralph P.
Bear, John Y.
Beard, Charles W.
Beggs, James P.
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Bellgardt, Richard E.
Beller, Albert J., Jr.
Bender, Robert E.
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Bennett, Raymond H., Jr.
Beno, Kenneth R.
Berkoff, Lawrence
Bessette, Albert L.
Bethart, Edgar J.
Beverley, Bernard J.

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Bieluwka, Bruno M.
Bindel, Richard C.
Bitzer, Earl E.
Bjorge, Wilson
Blakley, Billy D.
Blackburn, Thomas W.
Blackman, Charles E.
Blackwell, Benjamin H.
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Bonsall, Oliver T.
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Bowden, J. P.
Bowen, Hubert A.
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Brown, Ervin L.
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Cazzell, Leslie C.
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Crance, Jerome
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Crompt, Frank E.
Cross, Floyd E.
Croteau, Raymond
Culver, Edwin L.
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Curry, Parker D.
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Eisenhour, Fred L., Jr.
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Frank, Alfred L.
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Fuller, Raleigh E.
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Goswick, Leroy E.
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Granberry, William L., III
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Gray, Darwin S.

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Greenman, Harold C.
Greenway, George W.
Greenwood, Reed B.
Gregg, Kenneth B.
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Groff, David C.
Gross, Vernon L.
Guevara, Francisco A.
Guilfoil, Phillip J.
Guy, Edward F.
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Hamilton, Bill R.
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Hansen, Victor H.
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Heddleson, James J.
Heflin, Clifford J.
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Heiny, Deane A.
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Henderson, George W.
Hendrickson, Robert S.
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Herdman, Edwin G.
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Herron, Grady L.
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Heyward, Marion S.
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Horton, Jack W.
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Huesers, Howard D.
Hummel, Jerome J.
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Hunzelman, Lester G.
Husbands, James H.
Hutt, Harold A.
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Jackson, Milton L.
Jackson, Robert C.
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Jenness, Arthur J., Jr.
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Johnson, Robert K.
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Johnston, Paul R.
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Jones, Edward J.
Jones, Hugh D.
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Joyce, Maurice L.
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Kagan, Sidney D.
Kalbfleisch, Adolphe W.
Kanizar, George J.
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Kavanaugh, William P.
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Kelly, Irwin T.
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Kendall, Thomas K.
Kennedy, Russell H.
Kensinger, Dean G.
Kernodle, Kenneth E.
Kibbie, William H.
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Kirkpatrick, George B.
Kitko, David
Kittrell, Ralph L.
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Knott, Russell H.
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Korrot, Roy L.
Krasevac, Albert L.
Kregor, Edward R.
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Kuhns, Harry E.
Kuntz, Kenneth G.
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Lamanna, Anthony R.
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Lanning, Corvin L.
Lapcsik, John, Jr.
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Lee, Carl E., Jr.
Lee, John D.
Lee, Warren H.
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Leindorf, Ralph
Leinhauser, Donald E.
Lemke, Frederick
Lenahan, Lawrence D.
Libeg, Nicholas W.
Lipira, Mario R.
Lloyd, Edwin C.
Loftus, Thomas J.
Lorhstorfer, William G.
Loucks, Dale S.
Lovelace, James L.
Lowery, Fred H.
Loyd, Laurel E.
Lucey, John A.
Luke, Alvon E.
Luttrell, Richard A.
Lynch, Howard W.
Lynch, William M.
Lyons, Ralph H.
Maassen, Ralph L.
Mack, Ralph
MacMillan, Henry D., Jr.
Macone, Richard J.
Majefski, Henry A.
Malaske, Arnold J.
Mantel, Robert I.

Manter, Harold E.
Marko, Andrew A.
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Marion, Eugene O.
Markworth, Ralph H.
Marriett, Robert B.
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Marshall, John W.
Martin, Hubert H.
Martin, Keith O.
Martin, Loren H.
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Martinez, Edward, Jr.
Marvel, Robert E.
Masters, Harold R.
Masut, Melvin
Matt, Charles W.
Maxam, Melvin W.
Maxwell, Robert W.
May, Robert E.
Mayers, Paul G.
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McCarthy, Thomas O.
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McClarran, Charles W.
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McCrory, James P.
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McDonald, Frank G.

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McGinley, Maurice G.
McGowen, Raymond L.
McGuire, Charles W.
McKee, William G.
McKenna, James C.
McKenney, Earl F.
McKinley, William C.
McKnight, William R.
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McLaughlin, Robert C.
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McMahon, Harold R.
McManus, Leonard M.
McMillion, Oren M.
McMorrow, John F.
McNeil, William R.
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Meador, George W.
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Menser, Donald F.
Merkler, Charles A.
Merola, Mario
Merrill, Joseph H., Jr.
Merrill, Robert S.
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Meyer, Louis W.
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Miller, Armand B.
Miller, Francis P.
Miller, Frederick W.
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Mondiek, Jack W.
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Mooney, James C.
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Moore, Hope C.
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Oman, Luther J., Jr.
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Osborne, Robert J.
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Pipkin, George
Pirtle, James G.
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